43rd Annual Report

Ames Residential

Satisfaction Survey

2025

CITY OF Ames™

CONDUCTED IN COOPERATION WITH INSTITUTE FOR DESIGN RESEARCH AND OUTREACH (IDRO), COLLEGE OF DESIGN, IOWA STATE UNIVERSITY

2025 Ames Resident Satisfaction Survey 43rd ANNUAL STATISTICAL REPORT

The City of Ames, Iowa, conducts an annual satisfaction survey of residents. In April 2025, the City mailed questionnaires to 1,350 city residents whose names were randomly selected from the City of Ames utility customers list (population=~20,000+). Additionally, 1,000 Iowa State University (ISU) students were randomly selected from a mailing list generated by the ISU Office of the Registrar. Stratified random sampling was used to have representation from the students based on classification (sophomore to graduate levels). First-year students were intentionally excluded from the ISU sample due to their minimal exposure to and use of the City of Ames' services.

Utility bill customers received a 12-page survey booklet via the U.S. mail. The booklet included the same standard benchmarking questions as presented in the 2024 survey. The survey was also available online. A link to the online survey was provided in the letter of introduction that was mailed out with the paper version of the survey. This link ensures that only randomly selected respondents have access to the survey. The online survey was available in five languages: English, Spanish, Chinese, Arabic, and Korean. The selected ISU students received the same online survey via email developed using the Qualtrics Survey Software. The analysis was completed with assistance from Nora Ladjahasan, Laurel Waterman, and Amy Logan from the Institute for Design Research & Outreach, College of Design, Iowa State University.

The biggest change in this year's survey was the elimination of the section on personal mental health. This was replaced by a section on Human Services Agency Funding (ASSET); the survey asked about various ASSET funding services focused on mental health and substance use disorder needs, basic needs, and youth development services and activities. It asked respondents if they had used the various services and if the city should spend more or less on them. It also asked respondents to number which services should be the three highest priorities.

Two minor changes were also made:

- Parks and Recreation section: two parks and recreation features (overall quality of indoor aquatics, and over quality of outdoor aquatics) were added to the list, and
- Sense of Community section (question C): added the following statements: "I served or considered serving on City Board or Commission," and "Language barriers make it difficult to be involved in the community."

This statistical report summarizes results from 464 respondents who returned usable questionnaires: 232 came from Ames's utility bill customers, referred to as non-student residents in this report (50%) and another 232 from ISU students (50%). Everybody who received a paper copy of the survey was classified and analyzed as non-student residents. Some (n=15) did not answer the question if they are full-time ISU students (missing information).

Twelve percent of non-student residents (n=28) took the online survey. This is almost the same as last year (13%, or 30 non-student respondents). No one responded to the online survey using any of the other languages available. Only 232 surveys from the students were included in the analysis to have the same representation as the non-student residents. Incomplete surveys and those who had lived in Ames for a shorter period were excluded from the student samples. The response rate for the Ames residents' group (non-student residents) was 17% and 50% for ISU students. The overall response rate for this year is 31%, which is 9% higher than last year (22%).

The number of questionnaires mailed or emailed included an oversampling of students in order to come up with the desired sample size that reflects target populations. The sample size needed to confidently generalize the findings was 382 for both groups (95% confidence level and a confidence interval of 5). The 464 complete surveys indicate we are over the required sample size. In other words, the findings or the data significantly reflect the responses of the total population. For more details on calculating sample size, refer to: https://www.calculator.net/sample-size-calculator.html

Respondents' Personal and Social Characteristics

Table 1 illustrates the personal and social characteristics of respondents who completed the questionnaire. Column 1 lists the categories of characteristics asked for in the survey. Columns 2-6 show personal and social characteristics of the individuals who completed surveys between the years of 2021 and 2025.

When asked their length of residence, the most common answers were 1-3 years (26%), 4-6 years (20%), and over 10 years (42%). Over the past 5 years, these have had the highest percentages, but those who have lived in Ames over 10 years have increased and those who have lived 1-6 years have decreased.

Over the past 5 years, the gender distribution of respondents has flipped every year. Last year, it was 58% female and 39% male; this year it was 38% female and 58% male. As usual, under 1% identified as non-binary or a 3rd gender and 3% preferred not to answer.

Average age of the respondents in this year's survey was 42.4 (22.1 years of age for ISU students, 57.2 for non-student residents). More than 1/3 (38%) were from 18-24 years of age (8% higher than last year's survey. However, the 25-44 years of age was 8% lower than last year's survey (22%). This year had the highest respondents over 75 years of age over the last five years (12%).

The categories for race were White, Black or African American, American Indian or Alaska Native, and Asian. 88% of respondents identified as White, 2% identified as Black or African American, .3% identified as American Indian or Alaska Native, and 5% identified as Asian. 1.8% identified as a different race and 3% preferred not to answer. This survey also asked if respondents identified as Hispanic or Latino. 5% said yes, 91% said no, and 4% preferred not to answer.

For the educational attainment of respondents, <1% have had some high school education, 7% have a high school diploma, 35% have had some college education, 25% have had a college degree, 6% have had some graduate education, and 25% have a graduate degree. Over the past five years, those with some graduate education or a graduate degree have decreased, those with some college or a college degree have increased, and those with only a high school diploma have slightly increased.

Of those who are not full-time Iowa State students, 42% are employed full-time, 47% are retired, 9% are employed part-time, 3% are a full-time homemaker, and 1% are unemployed. This shows an abnormally low number of those who work part-time and an abnormally high number of those who are retired compared to past years. Also, the number of unemployed respondents has decreased, and full-time respondents has increased over the years.

As for the distribution of the household income of respondents, 35% had a household income of less than $25,000, 15% had $25,000 to $49,000, 15% had $50,000 to $74,999, 10% had $75,000 to $99,999, and 25% had over $100,000. Over the past 5 years, there has been an increase in respondents with a household income of $100,000+ and a decrease in those with below $50,000. Those with a household income of $50,000 to $99,999 have stayed consistent.

Table 1. Demographic Characteristics

Characteristic	*2021*	*2022*	*2023*	*2024*	*2025*
	Percent (%)				
Length of Residence					
Less than 1 year	0	1	12	<1	5
1-3 years	35	34	24	36	26
4-6 years	27	24	12	16	20
7-10 years	5	8	6	8	7
More than 10 years	33	34	46	41	42
Gender*					
Female	57	55	39	58	38
Male	41	42	58	39	58
Non-binary/3rd Gender	1	1	<1	<1	<1
Prefer not to answer	1	2	3	2	3
Age (18 and over)*					
18-24	37	36	34	30	38
25-44	31	27	23	30	22
45-64	14	14	16	16	13
65-74	11	13	16	16	15
Over 75	7	10	10	8	12
Education*					
Some HS	<1	1	<1	<1	<1
HS diploma	5	3	6	3	7
Some college	30	30	31	24	35
College degree	22	23	27	33	25
Some grad work	13	13	9	11	6
Graduate degree	30	30	27	28	25
Employment Status*					
Employed part-time	37	36	30	33	9
Employed full-time	35	30	31	34	42
Retired	18	23	28	24	47
Unemployed	8	10	9	7	1
Full-time homemaker	1	1	2	2	3
Household Income*					
Less than $25,000	40	42	34	34	35
$25,000-$49,999	19	16	15	16	15
$50,000-$74,999	15	14	12	15	15
$75,000-$99,999	8	6	10	10	10
$100,000+	18	21	29	26	25

Respondents who own vs rent their homes were evenly split this year with 50% owning and 50% renting. Over the past 5 years, respondents who rent have usually held a slight majority, due to about half of respondents being students. Those who rent were asked their reasoning for renting; 54% said it's due to their short term stay in Ames, 27% said they lack adequate income, 16% said that renting has little or no upkeep, and 2% said it's because of more security.

Respondents who are homeowners differ from renters on several personal and social characteristics.

Homeowners have lived in Ames longer than renters (29.1 years and 6.2 years, respectively). Of those who have lived in Ames for more than 10 years, 88% are homeowners. On the other hand, 90% of the renters have lived in Ames for less than 4 years.

Not surprisingly, the average age of respondents who are homeowners (51 years old) tends to be older than renters (22 years old). Of those between 25 and 44 years old, more than half (61%) are renters, 39% are homeowners.

In contrast, 96% of those under 25 years of age are renters, and 97% of full-time college students currently rent. For those with a college degree or higher, 75% are homeowners and 25% are renters.

Finally, homeowners typically have higher household incomes than renters. Eighty-two percent of homeowners earn $50,000 or more, whereas only 18% of the renters earn more than $50,000. (Statistics from this paragraph are not shown in any tables.)

Table 2. Housing Characteristics

Housing Characteristics	*2021*	*2022*	*2023*	*2024*	*2025*
	Percent (%)				
Housing type*					
Rent	57	53	47	52	50
Own	43	47	53	48	50
If rent, for what reason?					
Short-term stay in Ames	77	79	74	69	54
Lack of adequate income	37	44	45	39	27
Little or no upkeep	23	26	15	23	16
More security	6	7	8	6	2
Location of home					
Northwest	46	40	50	41	49
Southwest	29	34	25	33	27
Northeast	14	11	12	12	11
Southeast	11	15	12	14	13

Respondents also were asked to identify the location of their home in Ames, as seen in Figure 1 below. Forty-nine percent of the respondents reside in the northwest part of the city (compared to 41% in 2024), Twenty seven percent (27%) are from southwest (33% in 2024), 11% from northeast (12% in 2024), and 13% from southeast side (14% in 2024). There are more respondents from northwest compared to last year and fewer from other parts of the city.

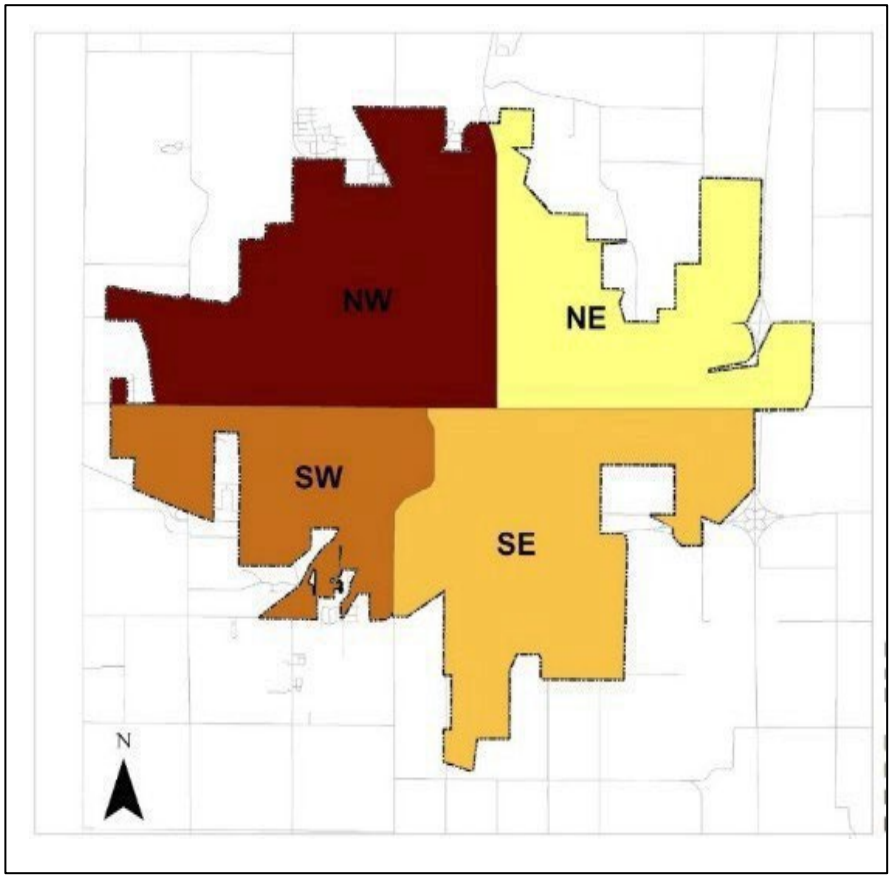
Figure 1. Geographic Sections

49% = Northwest

27% = Southwest

13% = Southeast

11% =Northeast



Priorities for On-Going Services

Survey respondents were asked to indicate their priorities for the upcoming City budget by indicating allocation levels (less, same, or more) on various services paid for by property or sales taxes. Budgeted funding amounts for each of the services were indicated. Table 3 shows the residents' preferences about spending priorities. A majority of respondents reported that they would like the City of Ames to spend the same amount as the previous year on all 10 service priorities. Fire protection was the priority that had the highest percentage of those that believed the city budget should stay the same (82.7%), while public art programs had the lowest percentage (56.4%) of people indicating the budget should remain the same. The public arts funding is interesting because although a majority believe funding should remain the same, 18% indicated they would like less funding, and 26% would like to see additional funding for public art.

On a scale of 1 to 3 (1 – less spending, 2 – same spending, and 3 – more spending), the priorities with an average closest to 2 are those that show strongest support to stay the same; this could either mean that a lot of people believe that funding should stay the same, or a fairly balanced number of people disagreed on increasing or decreasing the budget. For example, art programs had the lowest percentage to stay the same, but because many people voted both on a decreased and increased budget, the average stayed at 2.07. The higher above 2.0 means the stronger the support for increasing the budget and the lower below 2.0 means stronger support for a lower budget.

Priorities with an average above 2.0 were parks activities, Ames Animal Shelter and Animal Control, recreational opportunities, ASSET, CyRide, fire protection, arts programs, and Ames Public Library. Those under 2.0 were land use planning and law enforcement.

The priorities with the strongest consensus for an increased budget are parks activities, Ames Animal Shelter and Animal Control, recreational opportunities, and ASSET. The priority with the strongest indicator for a decreased budget was law enforcement, however it only fell below 2 by .11. These findings are in Table 3.

Table 3. Ongoing Service Priorities, 2025

On-going Service (budgeted amount)	Should the city spend?			
	Less (1)	Same (2)	More (3)	Average
	Percent (%)			
Parks activities ($1,751,347) (n=392)	3.8	63.5	32.7	2.29
Ames Animal Shelter & Animal Control ($796,763) (n=393)	8.1	60.3	31.6	2.23
Recreational opportunities ($1,361,795) (n=391)	6.4	65.2	28.4	2.22
Human service agency funding (ASSET). ($2,020,807) (n=387)	9.6	65.9	24.5	2.15
CyRide (public transit) ($2,227,370) (n=391)	5.9	76.7	17.4	2.12
Fire protection. ($6,907,726) (n=393)	4.6	82.7	12.7	2.08
Arts programs (Public Art & COTA) ($298,978) (n=392)	18.1	56.4	25.5	2.07
Ames Public Library ($5,420,555) (n=393)	15.0	63.4	21.6	2.07
Land use planning (both current and long-term) ($1,152,104) (n=385)	14.8	71.9	13.2	1.98
Law enforcement ($12,082,884) (n=392)	23.7	63.3	13.0	1.89
Other (please specify_____) (n=65)	3.1	64.6	32.3	2.29

"Other" Suggestions for On-Going Services

- Bike Paths and awareness.
- Building business infrastructure
- Campustown
- Climate action
- Conservation efforts and city cleanup
- Enforcing speed limits
- Erosion control
- Fire dept./EMS
- Flashing stop light
- Funding for addressing homelessness and helping affected individuals.
- Hotdogs
- Infrastructure
- Less money on law enforcement.
- Low-income housing
- More parking
- More public transport in general, Expanded Airport shuttle, more shuttles out to ISU satellite properties like research park/ASC/etc.
- Parking Enforcement

- Protecting & creating green spaces/wildlife
- Snow plowing streets
- Streetscape 200,000-$500k
- Updating Traffic Lights

Table 4 shows the five-year trends of the "spend more" responses for ongoing City services. Since 2021, the most significant increase in "spend more" responses were for recreational opportunities (19% increase from 2021), Ames Animal Shelter and Animal Control (16% increase), and parks activities (13% increase). The most significant decreases in "spend more" since 2021 have been for land use planning (14% decrease) and CyRide (11% decrease).

The biggest changes between 2025 and 2024 "spend more" responses were an 8% decrease for fire protection, a 6% decrease for CyRide, a 6% increase for art programs, and a 5% increase for Ames Public Library.

Over the past 5 years, the ASSET (human services) funding trend has been that 25% or more respondents have indicated that Ames needs to "spend more" on these services. This trend suggests that many citizens see additional human services funding as a perennial need that requires additional funding.

Table 4. Trends in "Spend More" Responses for On-going Services (%)

Services	"Spend More" (%)				
	2021	*2022*	*2023*	*2024*	*2025*
Parks activities	20	26	29	35	33
Ames Animal Shelter & Animal Control	16	25	23	29	32
Recreational opportunities	9	25	24	27	28
Human service agency funding (ASSET)	27	32	28	26	25
CyRide (public transit)	28	25	23	23	17
Fire protection	13	24	27	21	13
Arts programs (Public Art & COTA)	28	17	18	20	26
Ames Public Library	27	23	15	17	22
Land use planning (both current and long-term)	27	12	10	16	13
Law enforcement	18	21	18	16	13

When comparing the demographics of respondents with their support of certain services some statistically significant differences have been identified. The demographic data examined included years lived in Ames, age, gender, full-time student status, home ownership, education, employment status, household income, and geographic residence in town.

Level of support for increased spending for these two services (Fire protection and Recreational opportunities) were the same based on respondents' demographic information.

These groups of respondents supported **increased spending** on the following programs and services:

- Arts Programs (Public Art &COTA)
  - Short-term residents
  - Younger residents (18 to 24 years of age)
- Fire protection
  - No demographic correlation
- Human service agency funding (ASSET) agency
  - Non-student residents
  - Female
- Law enforcement
  - Homeowner
  - Non-student residents
  - Older respondent (older than 75 years of age)
- Ames Animal Shelter and Animal Control
  - Female
- Ames Public Library
  - Short term residents
- Land use planning (both current planning and long-term)
  - ISU Student
- Parks and amenities
  - Household income of $125,000 - $149,999
- Recreational opportunities
  - No demographic correlation
- CyRide (public transit)
  - Renter
  - ISU Student

Comments on Funding Allocation for Programs and Services

When asked for additional comments on funding allocation for programs and services, 45 respondents made comments. Some respondents felt like they did not have enough context or knowledge to answer the question.

For example:

- "I do not know. I am not informed enough to be able to offer a useful opinion."
- "I feel unqualified to answer funding allocation questions. I don't know enough. I also felt

the questions were unfair by listing actual dollars instead of percentage of budget. I have no direct personal frame of reference to understand $12 million as anything other than more-money-than-I-understand."
- "I'm not familiar enough to comment on it."
- "This is hard since I do not know what these services need."

There were a few mixed comments on funding for police, with five respondents wanting to spend less on police and two wanting more. One specifically wanted more support for mental health services within the department.

- "Ames police don't need all that money - give it to better things."
- "I made my comments on the police department before I saw these dollar amounts. It seems quite evident that a disproportionate amount is spent on law enforcement."
- "More assistance with mental health issues for police."

Other areas that respondents wanted more funding for included arts, parks and conservation, services and utilities, transportation, and homelessness.

- "Arts create vibrant community, a sense of safety and place - outcomes and increased quality of life, and business, tourism!"
- "I travel (the US) by Amtrak and see a lot of homelessness. We need to ensure we have cheap housing to prevent it happening here. I support that move. We need more funding for homelessness."
- "The city should beef up basic services- fire, police, water, streets, etc. Animal shelter may need extra transition funding + then hope to level off after the move."
- "More public transport and better walkable city planning, preservation of our green space and public arts and education programs and fixing those traffic lights that are unevenly timed."
- "Stop using pesticides and replace natural pest reduction techniques. Enforce on local farms, runoff reduction. Stop chemtrails from flying over Ames."

Lastly, there were some comments that mentioned overall satisfaction with funding for services and some other miscellaneous comments.

- "I am pretty satisfied with things the way they are. We have only lived in Ames for 5 years, but we love it here!"
- "It is important to fund certain aspects of the city so just continue to use the tax dollars to give back to the residents."
- "I would be willing to pay more taxes for increased budgets in these areas, and others if needed."
- "Land use planning appears to result in destroying the older neighborhoods of Ames and treating them as dumping ground rather than valued areas."

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Capital Improvement Priorities

Respondents were asked to prioritize seven suggested Capital Improvement Project (CIP) areas. Table 5 shows respondents' 2025 CIP priorities. This is based on a 4-point scale (1- not very important, 2 - not important, 3 - important and 4 - very important). This year, the three highest priorities were reconstruction of existing streets (3.3 average), traffic flow improvements (3.3 avg.), and sustainable solutions to projects (3.3 avg.). The least important priorities were off street bike facilities improvements (3.0 average), energy efficient upgrades to municipal buildings (3.0 avg.), and improvements to existing recreational facilities (3.0 avg.).

Table 5. Capital Improvement Priorities, 2025

Capital Improvement Priorities	Somewhat or Very Unimportant	Somewhat or Very Important	Average*
	Percent (%)		
Reconstructing existing streets	12	88	3.3
Traffic flow improvements	16	84	3.3 16
Sustainable solutions are incorporated into the above projects	16	84	3.3
Stormwater drainage improvements	18	82	3.1
Improvements to existing parks	17	83	3.1
Greenway Trails (recreational) improvements	20	80	3.1
Improvements to existing recreational facilities (e.g. aquatic center, auditorium, etc.)	20	80	3.0
Energy-efficient upgrades to municipal buildings	22	78	3.0
Off-street bike facilities (commuter) improvements	26	74	3.0
Other (please specify)	26	74	3.7

*1=very unimportant; 2=somewhat unimportant; 3=somewhat important; 4=very important

Other responses: (n=17)

- Apply + use grants etc. aggressively
- Beautification. Get rid of junk commercial & signs & improve sidewalk safety
- Generally, invest more in initial costs to avoid additional costs in upkeep/repair
- Improve sidewalks
- Improvement towards animal control (allowing them more funds)
- Land Usage

- Marking center lines
- More parking
- New animal shelter and more police officers
- Parking for football games (ISU)
- Please give us turning arrows on 13th/Grand East & West
- Put in roundabouts
- Riding the town of parking minimums
- Shuttle to Ankeny/DSM
- Sustainability!
- We need the city to be more bike friendly on major streets
- Zoning! Should not allow rentals in established neighborhoods!!!!!

Table 6 shows trends in survey respondents' views of the importance of CIP priorities in the last five years. Reconstructing existing streets and traffic flow improvements have consistently stayed at top priorities. With the addition of "sustainable solutions" and "improvements to existing parks" as options, these ended up towards the top of the list.

Across all priorities, there has been an increase across the years (from 2021 to 2025) in those identifying these as important priorities. Some of the biggest increases were stormwater drainage improvements (9%), traffic flow improvements (6%), reconstructing existing streets (5%), and off-street bike facilities improvements (5%). The only priority that decreased from last year was improvements to existing recreational facilities, decreasing from 82% to 80%.

Table 6. Trends in Capital Improvement Priorities (CIP)

Service	Very or Somewhat Important (%)				
	2021	*2022*	*2023*	*2024*	*2025*
Reconstructing existing streets	83	84	89	84	88
Sustainable solutions are incorporated to the above projects					84
Traffic flow improvements	78	83	82	82	84
Improvements to existing parks					83
Stormwater drainage improvements	73	75	78	76	82
Greenway Trails (recreational) improvements	77	77	76	79	80
Improvements to existing recreational facilities (e.g., aquatic center, auditorium, etc.)	78	76	76	82	80
Energy-efficient upgrades to municipal buildings					78
Off-street bike facilities (commuter) improvements	69	67	66	69	74
On-street bike facilities (commuter) improvements	66	65	62	69	
Other	96	68	81	61	74

Survey respondents ranked their three highest CIP priorities. Table 7 shows the results of those rankings. Traffic flow improvements had the highest percentage in each ranked priority, followed by reconstructing existing streets. After that, sustainable solutions, improvements to existing parks, and off-street bike facilities had the next highest combined percentages. An interesting outlier was that greenway trails. It did not do well as a first priority (only received 3%) but was ranked much higher as a second (13.4%) and third priority (10.6%).

Table 7. Ranking of Capital Improvement Priorities, 2025

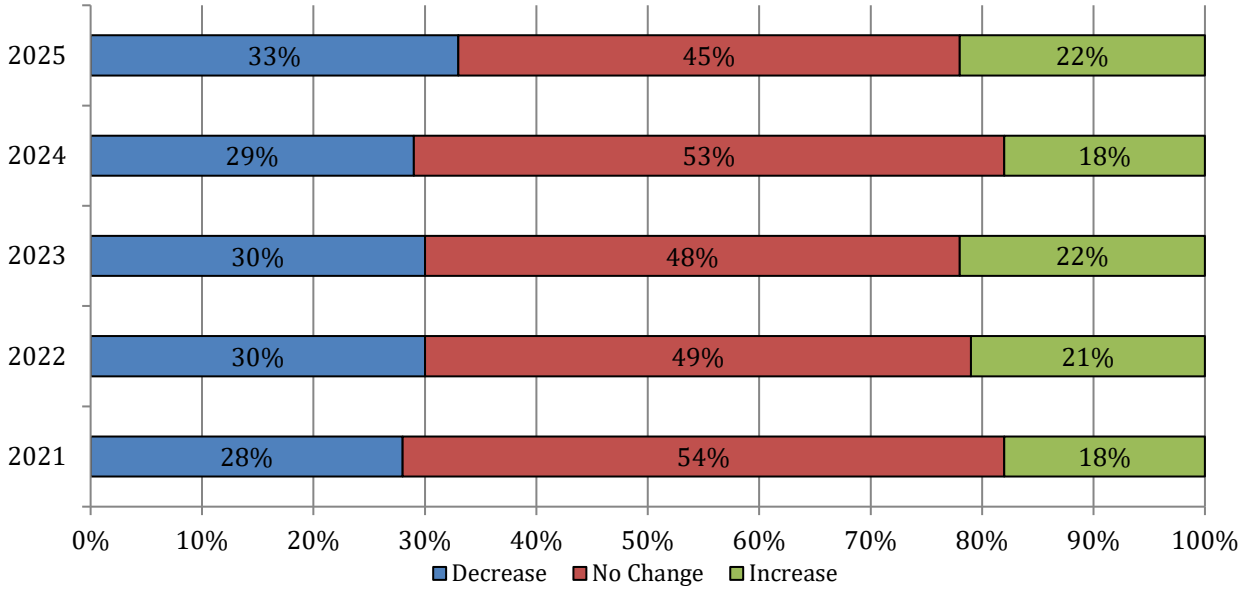
Capital Improvement Priorities	1st Priority *(n=361)*	2nd Priority *(n=359)*	3rd Priority *(n=350)*
	Percent (%)		
Traffic flow improvements	25.2	18.4	16.0
Reconstructing existing streets	23.5	11.7	13.7
Sustainable solutions are incorporated in the above projects	16.6	8.4	10.6
Improvements to existing parks	10.5	7.8	10.0
Off-street bike facilities (commuter) improvements	8.3	11.1	8.3
Improvements to existing recreational facilities (e.g. aquatic center, auditorium, etc.)	4.2	10.0	11.4
Energy-efficient upgrades to municipal buildings	3.3	7.2	10.0
Greenway trails (recreational) improvements	3.0	13.4	10.6
Storm water drainage improvements	3.0	11.1	8.9
Others	2.2	0.8	0.6

Property Tax Adjustment

The city levy for the next year is $10.30 per $1,000 of taxable valuation. This means that the City portion of the property tax on a $100,000 home in Ames is about $489 after rollback. When respondents were asked their view about adjusting property taxes next year, 45% indicated they would prefer no change, 33% suggested decreasing property taxes, and 22% suggested an increase in property taxes.

Figure 2 shows preferred property tax adjustments over the past five years. This year, the percentage of respondents indicating they would prefer a decrease in property tax increased by 4% (29% for 2024 and 33% for 2025). Twenty-two percent would accept an increase in property tax, which is also more compared to last year (18%). The percentage of "no change" decreased by 8% (from 53% in 2024 to 45% in 2025).

Figure 2. Trends in Preferred Property Tax Adjustments for Next Year



Resident Satisfaction with City Services

Respondents were asked to rate their level of satisfaction with nine services provided by the City of Ames. Responses were based on a scale of 1 to 4 (1 = "very dissatisfied", 2 = "somewhat dissatisfied", 3 = "somewhat satisfied", and 4 = "very satisfied") as well as a fifth option, "don't know." Figure 3 shows the level of satisfaction with city services continuing to be high. Fire & rescue satisfaction numbers climbed, but other categories remained stable or dropped slightly from 2024 results.

Figure 3 shows that in the past five years, the level of satisfaction was steady with only minimal changes. In 2025, services that remained the same as 2024 survey were Parks & Rec, CyRide, drinking water system, electric services, law enforcement services (five out of nine services). The satisfaction levels of public library services, sanitary sewer services, and public nuisance enforcement were slightly lower by 0.1 compared to 2024 survey.

Figure 3. Perceived Satisfaction Levels on Services, 2021-2025 (1=very dissatisfied; 4=very satisfied)

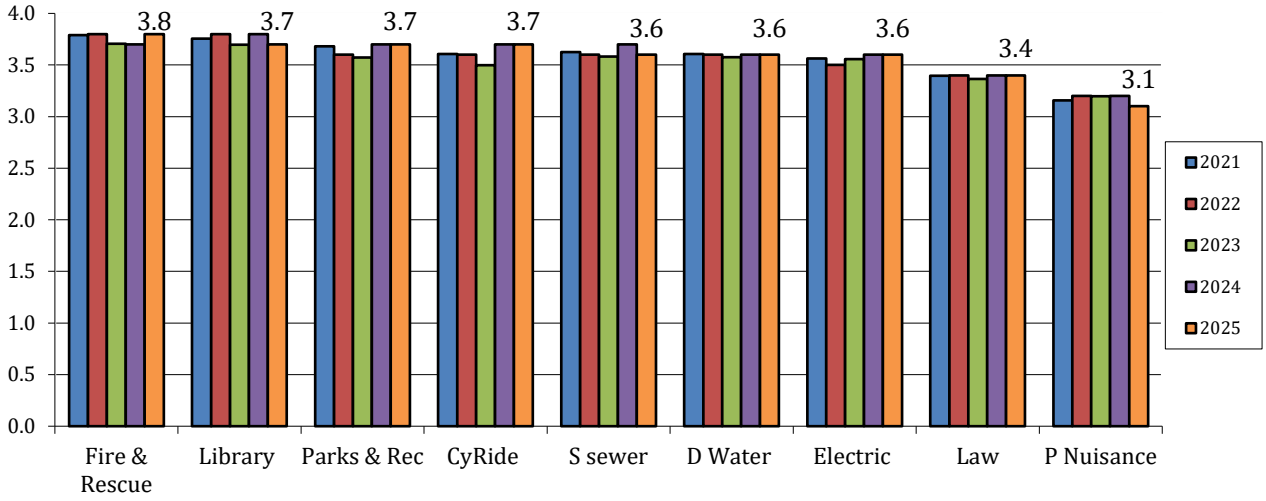


Table 8 summarizes respondents' satisfaction with City services. Overall, respondents are quite pleased with City services, as six of nine service areas received about 94% "somewhat or very satisfied" responses. Respondents were least satisfied with public nuisance enforcement services, with only 79% of respondents "somewhat or very satisfied," followed by law enforcement services (89%).

Table 8. Summary Table of Satisfaction with City Services (removing "don't know"), 2025

City Services	Very/Somewhat Dissatisfied	Very/Somewhat Satisfied
	Percent (%)	
Fire & rescue services (n=311)	1.0	99.0
Library services (n=334)	1.8	98.2
Parks & recreation services (n=398)	2.3	97.7
Electric services (n=365)	3.0	97.0
Sewer system (n=367)	3.8	96.2
CyRide bus service (n==305)	3.9	96.1
Drinking water system (n=408)	5.6	94.4
Law enforcement services (n=368)	11.1	88.9
Public nuisance enforcement (e.g. noise, over-occupancy, yard upkeep) (n= 314)	21.3	78.7

Comments on City of Ames Services

Respondents made comments that generally fell into one of two categories. The first being overall satisfaction with the City's services, and the second being critiques or improvement for specific services. Of those who claimed City services in Ames were satisfactory, comments include:

- "In general, Ames provides excellent services."
- "Think we enjoy living in Ames for the City takes care of us citizens"
- "I am proud to live in Ames- Ames is a great place to live and work! All my encounters with the City of Ames services have been positive."

Of those who were unsatisfied, topics they mentioned ranged from property and housing enforcement to police and emergency services. Several respondents complained about the appearance and upkeep of properties. Another mentioned the synced leases by landlords that leave people homeless for several days. Others complained about unsatisfactory services from the police or the desire for more funding for them and emergency services.

Most other comments highlight a specific City service with issues or suggestions. Some respondents stated that they are mostly satisfied but still had a recommendation for improvement. Topics include streets, traffic, water, CyRide, bike trails, and other miscellaneous issues.

- "CyRide that reach far west Ames (especially purple) should offer a wider variety of times in the middle of the day."
- "I don't like how we're switching four-lane roads to two to accommodate a bike line, because so few cyclists utilize them. 16th St. and Duff St. are nightmares, I go through it multiple times a day, and in all these years I have only seen 3-5 cyclists."
- "Parks + Rec. swim lessons fill quickly. Sometimes hard to get a spot."

- “Very concerned about people sleeping in public spaces + the safety issues that it brings.”
- “We could use more paved bike trails.”

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Police Department

When respondents were asked if they ever interacted with the Ames police department in the last 12 months related to an investigation, traffic, accident, etc., less than a quarter (19%) said yes (n=78). Of this, 55% were non-student residents and 45% were ISU students.

Respondents were presented with eight possible Ames police department outreach events and were asked to indicate if they have attended any of those events. Table 9 shows that just over a quarter (27%) have attended training or education program, followed by National Night Out (22%), and Donuts in the Park (17%). The rest were attended by less than 15% of the respondents. Comparing the non-ISU residents and ISU students, more non-ISU residents attended a Training or Education Program (32%) compared to an ISU student (10%). Only 7% of the ISU students attended the Citizen Police Academy compared to non-ISU residents (12%). There were no ISU students who reported attending National Night Out, compared to the 15% non-ISU residents who reported attending. However, there were more ISU students (33%) who attended Shop with a Cop than non-ISU residents who attended (21%).

A sizeable number of respondents mentioned other events or situations where they interacted with the police that were not listed in the survey. In analyzing the responses, there may be confusion between the Ames Police and Iowa State University public safety officers. Other interactions include:

- Accident
- At ISU campus events
- At my dorm in the past there was a donut event where the cop told us about different parts of law enforcement in Ames
- College orientation
- Destination Iowa State
- Event planning
- Events at Iowa State
- Iowa State Career Fair
- ISU CJ Department Events
- ISUPD Dog Therapy Event
- Service clubs' presentations
- Speed violation
- StuGov!
- Traffic stop
- Trinity CHR reformed Church Trunk or Treat

Table 9. Outreach Events interacting with Ames Police Department, 2025

Outreach Event *(n=64)*	**Total**	**Non-ISU Resident** *(n=34)*	**ISU Student** *(n=30)*
	Percent (%)		
Training or Education Program (n=17)	27	32	10
National Night Out (n=14)	22	15	
Donuts in the Park (n=11)	17	21	13
Coffee with Cops (n=7)	11	12	10
Citizen Police Academy(n=6)	9	12	7
Shop with a Cop (n=5)	8	21	33
Other (n=18)	28	21	37

Thinking about priorities for law enforcement, the first three priorities for the law enforcement residents would like to see emphasized were Traffic Enforcement in High Accident Areas (first priority, 67%), followed by Safety Programming and Training (Active Shooter, Scams, Alcohol regulations, etc.) (second priority, 65%), and lastly, Residential Patrolling (45%) as the third priority. (Table 10)

Table 10. Three Priorities for law enforcement, 2025

Priorities (n=441)	**Percent** (%)	**Priority**
Traffic Enforcement in High Accident Areas (n=294)	67	1st
Safety Programming and Training (Active Shooter, Scams, Alcohol regulations, etc.) (n=288)	65	2nd
Residential Patrolling (n=198)	45	3rd
Police Outreach (n=165)	37	
Animal Control and Sheltering (n=105)	24	
Business District Patrolling (n=100)	23	
Retail Alcohol Monitoring/Enforcement (n=99)	22	
Parking Regulations (n=29)	7	

Table 11 shows the five-year trends for Police Department activities that should receive "more emphasis/ more priority" (for 2025 survey). It is important to note that the wording and options for the Police section part of the survey was updated in 2024, so the five-year data reflects different options provided to the survey takers.

The following are the noticeable changes by year.

- The two new activities added to the 2024 survey remain the highest priorities for 2025. Those two were traffic enforcement in high accident areas and safety programming and training (Active Shooter, Scams, Alcohol regulations, etc.).
- Although remaining tied for the second priority (63%) for the 2024 survey, Residential Patrolling dropped to third with a significant decrease (45% in 2025).
- Parking Regulations remained the last in the priority list, however, it still saw a decrease as a priority compared to 2024 (11% in 2024 to 7% in 2025).

Table 11. Trends in "More Emphasis" for Police Department Activities

Police Department Activity	*"More Emphasis" (%)*				
	2021	*2022*	*2023*	*2024*	*2025*
Traffic Enforcement in High Accident Areas	11	10	17	66	67
Safety Programming and Training (Active Shooter, Scams, Alcohol regulations, etc.)				63	65
Residential Patrolling	19	13	21	63	45
Police Outreach				40	37
Animal Control and Sheltering	15	15	18	23	24
Business District Patrolling	8	8	10	22	23
Retail Alcohol Monitoring/Enforcement	19	23	22	23	22
Parking Regulations	5	5	9	11	7

Comments on Police Department

One-third of the comments revealed satisfaction with the police department with comments noting officers do a great job, are a great resource, or have had good interactions with them. A couple of comments mentioned the need for continued or increased funding.

- I view our Police as protections of our social order. They do it well in Ames.
- My experience with the Ames Police Dept. about 3 years ago when I was the victim of credit card fraud was wonderful, they helped me very much."
- No interaction with police services for many years... yet very grateful for their services and professionalism."
- Thank you for keeping our community safe!

- They are very good! The Facebook page is very helpful too - w/ timely information.
- We have an outstanding police department who go way above and beyond with all that they do. They are transparent and have many outreach events. I just wish there were more of them.
- Keep it growing. Retain them and make sure your salary schedule is in line with the area. Make sure they are funded fully with the best equipment."

Some common complaints were about the need for better training, over policing or being too strict, or accounts of harmful interactions with police officers or the department.

- Community policing (I think it's called) Training in sensitivity & profiling I don't think I have seen any foot/cycle/horse patrols anywhere outside of a special city event.
- De-escalation training
- I think they focus too much on petty stuff honestly sometimes, but way better than ISU PD.
- It seems the P.D. is exceptionally large - a disproportionate amount of money is spent on it. I can't believe the number of P.D. vehicles at the lot by the station. I once assault rifles being unpacked outside the station?? Do we really need so many weapons in what seems like a safe city? Of course, safety is important, but do we need so many police?
- Mixed experiences depending on which officers respond. had a weird interaction w/ officer re: parking ticket. I wanted to take it + leave but he wanted me to answer a trivia question. Felt very condescending + kind of creepy (am female).

Other complaints focused on increased enforcement and action regarding traffic (speeding and parking), drugs and alcohol, gun violence, and public safety

- Speeding on Lincoln Way, South 4th, South 16th between University + Duff, and Mortenson needs to be cracked down on whether ISU students are here.
- I'm very concerned about the current "carrying" laws and young people here, mix in booze, competitive events, etc. + trouble will follow.
- I have observed serious issues with people running red lights throughout Ames, but especially on Lincoln Way around ISU. As a high pedestrian stretch of road, I look to the Ames Police Department to do more to reduce reckless driving behavior in this part of town.
- I think they should focus less on parking issues and more on the safety of the town.
- One of my biggest concerns in the US is the potential risk of an encounter of an active shooter to any member of my family and friends. Unfortunately, I don't know what I can do to help mitigate this problem.
- People who park in handicapped places + leave when cops come because they have no permit (pub. lib)

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Figure 4. Comments on Police Department

Fire Department

Survey respondents reported their satisfaction with Ames Fire Department activities. Table 12 shows respondents' satisfaction ratings. For each activity, at least 55% of survey respondents responded with "Don't know" (which was excluded in the analysis in Table 12). All of the respondents were somewhat/very satisfied with extinguishing fires (100%), followed by emergency response time (98.4%), then Emergency medical responses (98.1%), and finally Fire prevention activities and community outreach (96.5%).

Table 12. Satisfaction with Fire Department Activities ("don't know" removed), 2025

Fire Department Activity	Very/Somewhat Dissatisfied	Somewhat/Very Satisfied
	Percent (%)	
Extinguishing fires (n=130)	0	100
Emergency response time (n=186)	1.6	98.4
Emergency medical responses (n=160)	1.9	98.1
Fire prevention activities and community outreach (n=202)	3.5	96.5

Comments on Fire Department

Out of the 61 respondents who left a comment on the fire department, 48% said they had never interacted or had to use the fire department's services.

- Fortunately, we've never needed to call them!
- Haven't had to use. I hear sirens so am assuming their response time is adequate?
- I thankfully have not had to call or use the fire department.
- Thankfully, they never needed them for a real emergency.

59% had good things to say, whether there were overall satisfaction and compliments, or specific comments on fast response time or good outreach and events. There was some overlap with the comments that had never used the fire department but still had a good perception of it.

- Thankfully, I have not had to have the fire dep. come to my house. I have taken my grandkids to open house\educational events at the fire station + they loved shooting the hoses + climbing in the fire trucks. The fire people around here seem nice!
- Loved the Fire Safety event put on by the Fire Department for the community. My child was very engaged and learned a lot!
- The Ames Fire Department consistently delivers outstanding service. The leadership—Chief Higgens and his deputy chief set a strong example through their professionalism, responsiveness, and accessibility. The firefighters themselves are reliable, respectful, and bring a sense of calm competence to every interaction. This is a well-leading and well-supported department.
- Their response was excellent when a car ran into our house.

- As an RA, I find the fire department SUPER helpful and great to work with!
- Great interactions with youth.
- I have used city ambulances a couple times and response time mostly very good.

Other comments mentioned that they would like to see more stations or there should me more emphasis on outreach.

- Relocation of fire station #2 is badly needed. A fourth station in northern Ames would be great.
- See FD staff at grocery store- an opportunity for outreach.
- I would like to see more promotion for the fire/EMS here in Ames not just during fire prevention week.

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Figure 5. Comments on Fire Department

Ames Electric Services

Survey respondents were asked questions regarding Ames Electric Services, including questions about power outages, satisfaction with various aspects of the Electric Services department, and the SunSmart Ames project. Of the 464 total respondents only 96% (n=445) respondents answered this question. Of those who responded, 23% said they don't know (n=102). Combining the "yes" and "no" responses only, 88% of the respondents have electricity in their homes provided by the city in 2025.

The number of respondents who have experienced a power outage fluctuates yearly and is nearly always connected to weather conditions. Table 13 demonstrates this fluctuation; In 2021, over 80% of those surveyed reported experiencing an outage due to the derecho in August 2020. This year marked a significant decrease in those who experienced a power outage, decreasing by 18% since 2024, down to 30%. There was a slight decrease in those who experienced a power surge, decreasing by 4% since 2024, down to 11%.

Table 13. Respondents' Experience with Electric Service Interruption

Interruption	"Yes" (%)				
	2021	*2022*	*2023*	*2024*	*2025*
Experienced power outage	80	43	53	48	30
Experienced power surge which affected computer operations	24	12	18	15	11

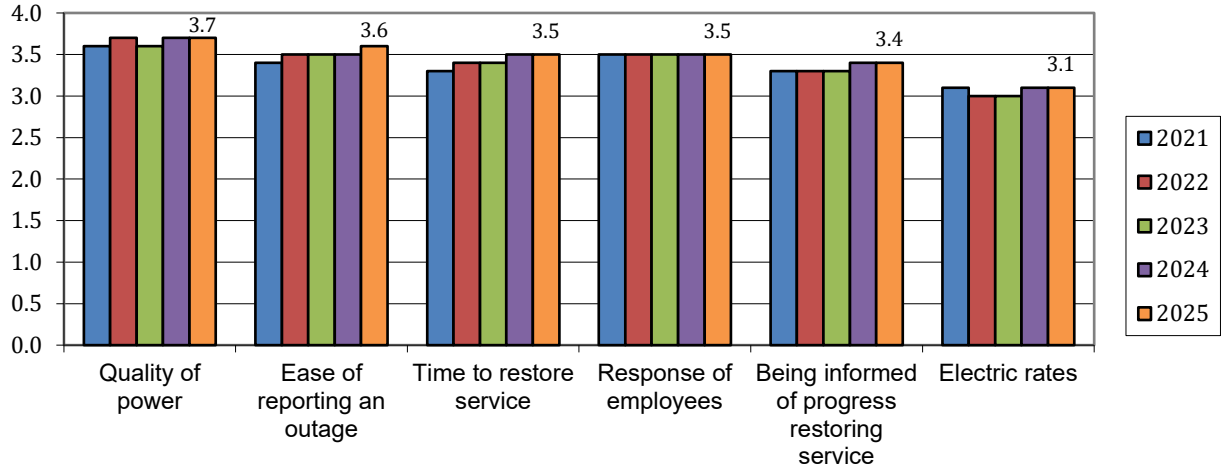
Table 14 shows satisfaction rates with Electric Department services. "Does Not Apply" responses were excluded in this analysis. Ninety-six percent of Ames customers were somewhat or very satisfied with the quality of power, and 97% were satisfied with the response of employees. There was also a high rate of satisfaction with ease of reporting an outage (94%), response of employees (94%), time to restore service (92%), and being informed of progress restoring services (89%). 21% of respondents reported being very/somewhat dissatisfied with electric rates.

Table 14. Satisfaction with Electric Department Services, 2025

Electric Service	Very/somewhat dissatisfied	Somewhat/ very satisfied	Average
	Percent (%)		
The quality of power (n=317)	3	97	3.7
Ease of reporting an outage (n=225)	6	94	3.6
Response of employees (n=204)	6	94	3.5
Time to restore service (n=232)	8	92	3.5
Being informed of progress restoring services (n=241)	11	89	3.4
Electric rates(n=313)	21	79	3.1

Figure 6 shows the five-year trends in satisfaction with the Ames Electric Department. The satisfaction levels have remained constant across each category over the five-year period, with variations from year to year. Each category stayed the same in 2025, other than "ease of reporting an outage" which only increased by 0.1 point.

Figure 6. Satisfaction with City Electric Department activities, 2021-2025



Respondents were asked to gauge their interest in participating in the SunSmart Ames community solar farm (https://www.CityOfAmes.org/Solar). Ames Electric Services established a 2MW solar farm to provide renewable energy to customers. Ames Electric Services customers may purchase shares of the project at $240 per share" and receive monthly credit on their utility bill for 20 years.

Only 7% of respondents indicated that they are participating in the project. The survey then asked

for feedback on why they are not participating. Of those not participating, 50% specified that their stay in Ames is short-term, 29% responded that it was too expensive, and 8% stated they were uninterested.

Other reasons (26%) for not wanting to participate in the program include not knowing enough about the project or not being aware of the program, not qualifying for the project because they are still living in an apartment, old age, not cost effective, apathy, and not thinking it's a sound-long-term project.

Comments on Ames Electric Service

Forty-one survey respondents left comments about the Ames Electric Service, with almost half being about overall satisfaction or having no issues with their electric services.

- Have always been a great service, they just helped me last night.
- I love Ames Electric Services and its solar initiative!
- I was very impressed with the customer service when setting it up for the first time.
- Love the electric price in Ames. I just hope they can meet the power demand in the next 30 years. I found out that over 10 years the power pack was too expensive for me.
- Overall good services
- I really appreciate the approach in Ames to efficient lighting! Dark sky fixtures and adding solar you folks are the best!!!
- We are so fortunate to have such a responsive crew. They are highly effective often in extremely poor weather conditions. Thank you :)

Many other respondents used this question to provide comments about SunSmart, due to a previous SunSmart question being directly above. Ten respondents commented positively about the program, many saying they admire it.

- I would participate in SunSmart Ames if I knew I would be staying here after college! That is a wonderful program.
- Seems like a good opportunity
- SunSmart Ames is such a cool project, and if I were in town long-term, I would absolutely participate.
- This is so cool!

There were a few complaints requested about SunSmart improvements and miscellaneous issues.

- [SunSmart] Seems somewhat expensive.
- Renewable energy initiations allow people to feel better about themselves while the only actual "Real" result they produce is increasing the cost of energy rates.
- When I first bought my Ames home, I was auto enrolled in the program where Ames can control your AC, but I knew nothing about it. Come summer my AC was switching off and it took me a while to figure it out, and it was incredibly unsettling. I called and asked for it to be disconnected--and the tech even showed me when he came out that he was completely

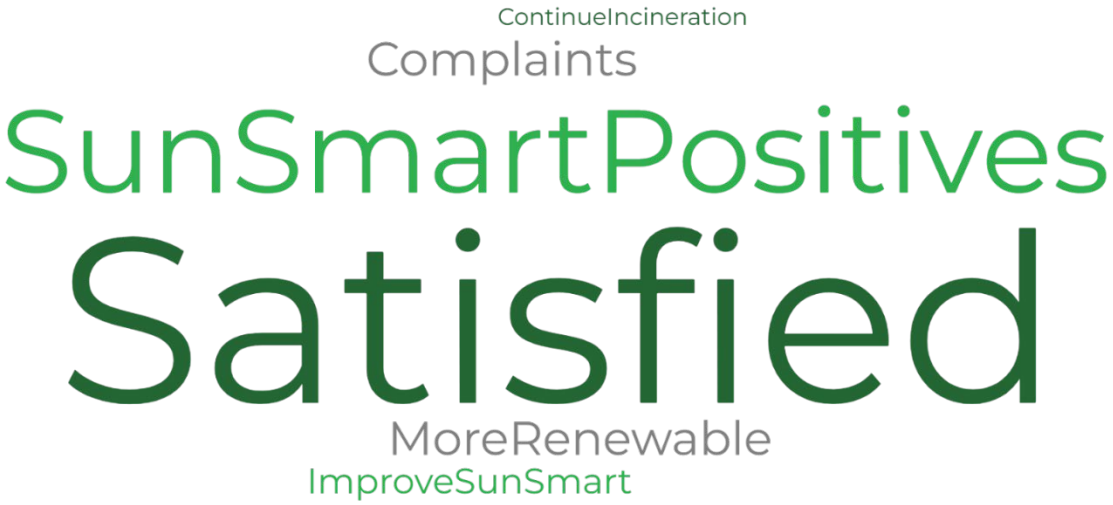
cutting the wires, which made me feel back in control, but I really wish I would have been asked vs. forced.

Lastly, a few people requested that Ames continue to use and improve renewable energy, specifically solar, and their trash incineration practices.

- I want more community solar.
- I would like to see solar become a larger part of electricity generation in Ames.
- Continue increasing the renewable energy in the area, though could we find a clean thing to mix with the garbage, like bio diesel from algae or hydrogen in the power plant?
- I hope City continues to provide electricity via trash incineration to reduce landfill issues, power has rarely failed here even when neighboring towns have outages.

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Figure 7. Comments on Ames Electric Services



Drinking Water Service

Of the respondents who use City of Ames drinking water and sanitary sewer services, the majority reported never having problems such as too much pressure (93%), soft water (91%), rust (83%), disagreeable taste or odor (80%), too little pressure (74%), sediment or cloudy appearance (76%), and hard water (74%).

Figure 8a shows the frequencies of water service problems as reported in 2025. Most respondents who have experienced water problems indicated they had problems once or twice in the past year. Too much pressure and soft water had the least number of reports. Sediment or cloudy appearance and too little pressure had the highest number of reports at each frequency, except at 7+ problems in the past year, where hard water had the most (10%). Figure 8b shows the percentage of respondents reporting no water problems for the past five years (2021 to 2025). Historically, Ames residents are pleased with their water, with the few issues in too much pressure and soft water, and the most within too little pressure and hard water.

Figure 8a. Frequencies of Water Service Problems, 2025

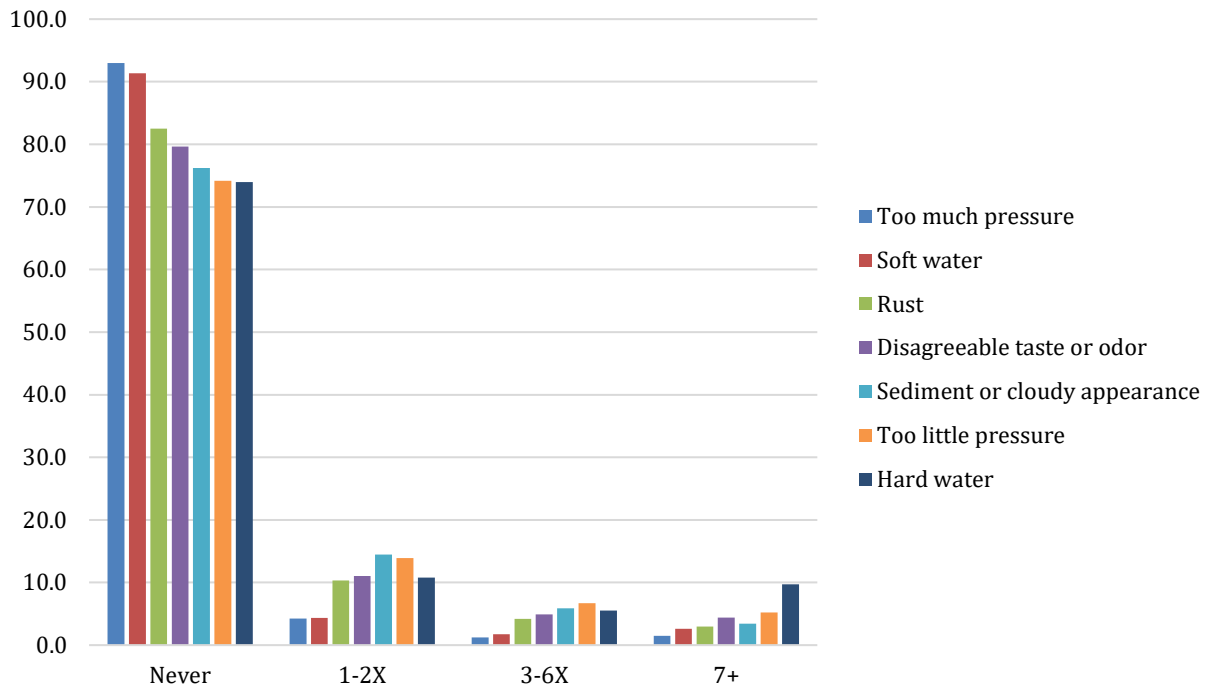
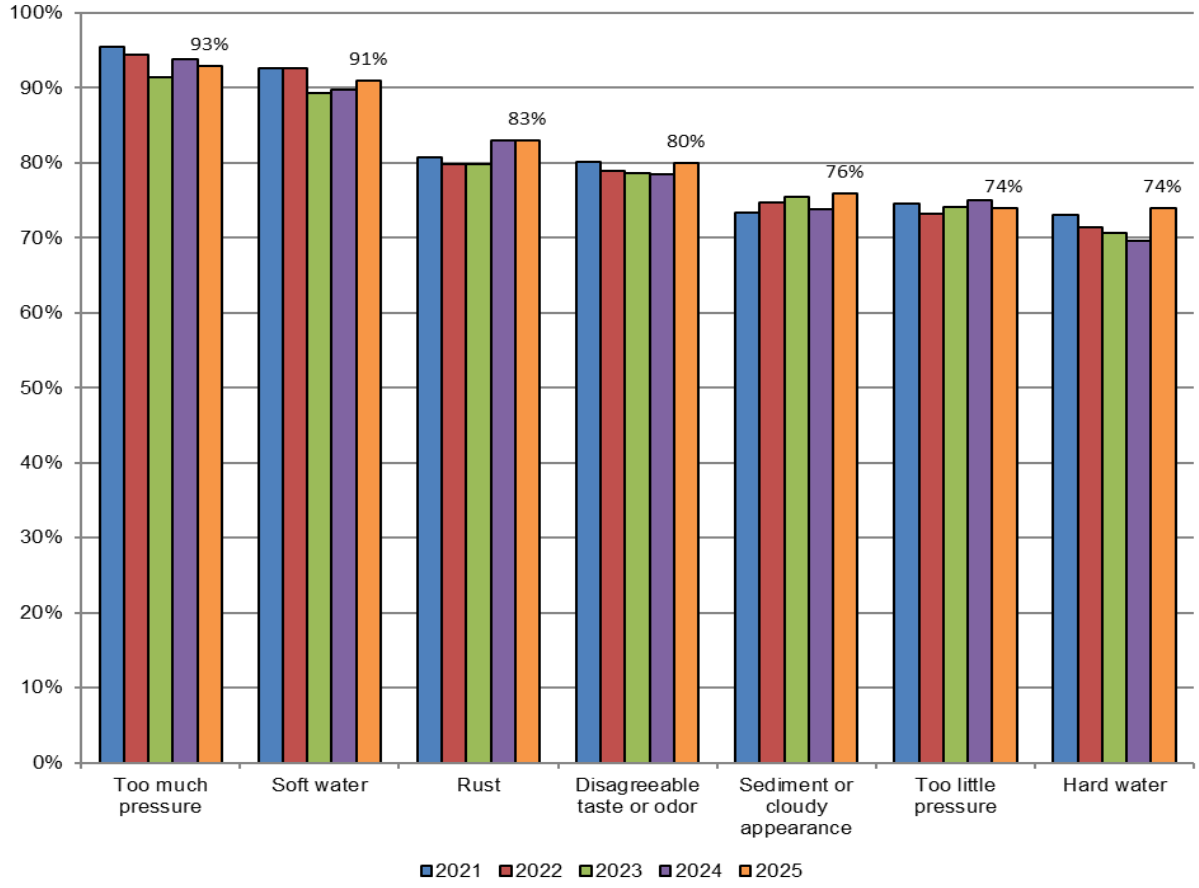


Figure 8b. Respondents Reporting No Water Service Problems, 2021-2025



Comments on Drinking Water Services

Most comments about drinking water indicated they were pleased with the quality and taste, with many saying it's great, good, excellent, or the best. Others just commented on the pleasing taste of the water or reported no issues.

- Great quality!
- Ames has some of the best water. We are very satisfied with it.
- Ames has the best water. We get spoiled with how good it is.
- Award winning water!! Hooray for Ames!
- I love the quality of Ames drinking water.
- Perfect almost always
- It's the best in Iowa for a reason!
- Best tasting water, I have ever had.

While there were many positive comments, respondents also shared their concerns about hard water and its residue and build-up, some who do not like the taste or believe the quality is poor,

issues with hydrant flushing, worries about pollution, or comments about temporary issues that have been resolved.

- Although Ames has some of the best tap water/drinking water, I think it would be beneficial to test for PFAs and other potential contaminates on a regular basis at multiple locations around the city and make this data available for the public if it isn't already.
- I always have sediment in the bottom of my water bottle after filling from the tap.
- I think I'm an outlier here, but I do not like the taste of Ames water. I can't drink it unless it's been iced.
- In the last 5 years, the water in our neighborhood runs reddish/brown more often. Leaves pinkish red stains in bathtub, sinks, washer, some clothes. it keeps getting worse over time. :(
- Significant rust after hydrant flushing; had to run enough water that increased my monthly bill significantly.
- Water is really hard and builds up on our clothes. Still, we love the taste.
- We just had truly little to no water coming from the taps once and it was resolved within a day.

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Figure 9. Comments on Drinking Water Service

Water and Pollution Control Department

Survey respondents were asked to provide their level of satisfaction with water quality and rates on a scale of 1 – Very Dissatisfied to 4 – Very Satisfied. Respondents could also choose "Does not apply." The satisfaction rates are reported in Table 15. 92% of those surveyed were satisfied with water quality, 82% with water rates, and 79% with sewer rates.

Comparing this data to 2024, it remains steady but had a 3% increase in dissatisfaction with water rates and a 6% increase in dissatisfaction with sewer rates. Customer satisfaction is still very high among all three categories. Water quality ranked highest with an average score of 3.6 out of 4, indicating high satisfaction level.

Table 15. Satisfaction with Water & Pollution Control Department Services, 2025

Service	Very/Somewhat Dissatisfied	Very/Somewhat Satisfied	Average
	Percent (%)		
Water quality (n=402)	8	92	3.6
Water rates (n=354)	18	82	3.1
Sewer rates (n=353)	21	79	3.1

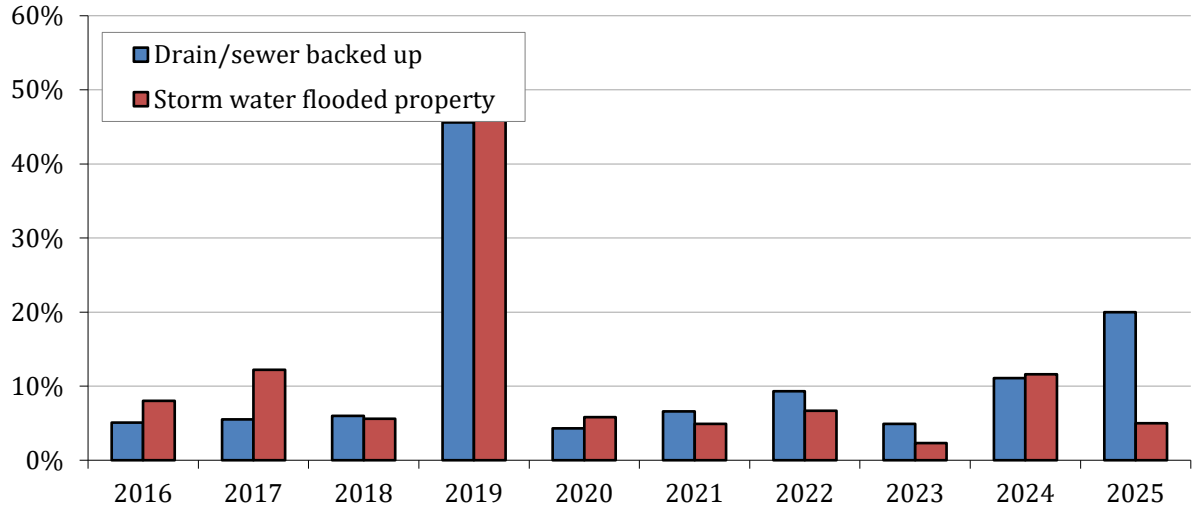
*"Does not apply" excluded when calculating percentages for "very dissatisfied" to "very satisfied."

Figure 10 shows trends in the number of people experiencing problems related to the City's sewer or stormwater system over the past decade. Generally, fewer than 10% of respondents experienced back-up or flooding problems. Previous major weather events have caused these numbers to change in certain years. For example, in 2017 and 2019.

This year, a significant number of respondents (20%) experienced drain or sewer backup events on their property, compared to 11% in 2024. Of the 87 people with drain backup problem, only 10 reported the issue to the city.

The survey also asked respondents if they had experienced stormwater flooding onto their properties from the street in the past year. Fewer (5%) reported stormwater flooding compared to backups. Only two of the 20 respondents who experienced flooding reported the problem to the City.

Figure 10. Respondent's Experience with City Sewer System Problems, 2016-2025



Comments on Water and Pollution Control

There were 35 comments connected to the Water Pollution and Control section. Comments range from topics on stormwater management, satisfaction, costs, and garden watering, communication about water, and water quality.

Several respondents commented that they were satisfied or had no issues. One respondent mentioned an excellent notification for hydrant flushing in their neighborhood. Another recalled when Public Works went "above and beyond" when fixing their sump pump.

However, there was some concern expressed about Ames' water rates. One comment said, "Everything is getting more expensive, and income is staying the same it's getting harder to pay bills." Another said, "Water rates keep increasing!"

Some respondents highlighted poor stormwater drainage on or near their property, or in spots observed throughout Ames. "My back yard is next to a drainage area. I am used to occasional high-water runoff." Another said, "Stormwater backs up on the driveway of the alley. City did some mitigation years ago when it encroached on the garage. It is only a minor nuisance now."

Some respondents reported poor water quality, "Iowa's cancer rates continue to rise. What can be done now to reduce these mortality rates? The DNR regularly reports wastewater spills. What can be done to protect our water quality safety + also reduce these spills?" A few other respondents mentioned unsatisfactory options for watering their garden or yard.

Others mentioned problems with City communication about water, "Need to be more communicative about stormwater issues and why we are increasing rates - benefits of stormwater

projects for resilience, minimizing long term & immediate risks, cumulative impacts of system improvements- be more like the electrical services."

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Figure 11. Comments on Water and Pollution Control Services

Neighborhood Nuisance Enforcement

Table 16 illustrates survey respondents' satisfaction with the City's neighborhood nuisance enforcement efforts for different violations. Over half of respondents reported "Don't know" for each violation, ranging from 57% for outdoor storage and yard upkeep to 79% for over-occupancy. These individuals were excluded from the calculated satisfaction percentages.

Among those who expressed opinions regarding their satisfaction, the majority reported being "somewhat satisfied" to "very satisfied" with each enforcement effort: dangerous structures (73%), front yard parking (66%), noise limits (64%), outdoor storage (64%), over-occupancy (64%), and yard upkeep (62%).

When satisfaction level was compared against the respondents' geographic residences, the level of satisfaction was the same regardless of where a respondent lives for all nuisance ordinance enforcements.

Table 16. Satisfaction in Neighborhood Nuisance Enforcement, 2025

Nuisance	Very/Somewhat Dissatisfied	Very/Somewhat Satisfied	Average
	Percent (%)		
Dangerous structures (dilapidated, unsecured, holes, collapsing) (n=160)	27	73	2.9
Front yard parking on residential properties (n=144)	34	66	2.9
Noise limits (n=175)	36	64	2.8
Outdoor storage on property (junk cars, tires, furniture, garbage (n=189)	36	64	2.8
Over-occupancy in rental property (n=94)	36	64	2.8
Yard upkeep (overgrown vegetation) (n=191)	38	62	2.8

Comments on Neighborhood Nuisance Enforcement

Of the 51 respondents who commented on neighborhood nuisance enforcement, 14 reported having no issues. One respondent said, "I am glad the City has such ordinances and that they are enforced. None have been an issue yet where I live." Another said, "I've never submitted a report."

The rest left comments with various concerns. Most concerns were about property maintenance such as yard upkeep, garbage, junk, or building maintenance and/or the lack of enforcement.

- Need to put some teeth behind the enforcement of poorly maintained properties with slum lords who can do so much better. Hope this changes or I will consider another. Never been impressed by the realtors, property mgrs., etc., and landlords.
- Rental ordinance enforcement is nearly nonexistent. You should not rely on see-click-fix. Mowing vegetation overgrowth, sidewalk shoveling are huge issues with rentals.
- The appearance of rental properties on Lincoln Way is very poor.
- The apt complex directly north of our property continues to accumulate garbage on our property. Their dumpster isn't adequately large enough for their residents, and residents continue to just throw garbage down the hill onto our property.
- A house has been abandoned in our neighborhood for several years. Racoons and other animals are living inside it. City inspections have said they can't do anything about it.
- Did not continue/take further even though the issues did not stop.

Other complaints revolved around noise such as dog barking or fireworks, parking, junk cars, and overoccupancy.

- Fireworks & parties in campus town while visiting a friend I don't even call these things anymore.
- I am not aware of noise limits - maybe people could stop lawn mowing and especially leaf blowing after a certain time.
- Reported one major 'Over Occupancy' and was ignored: no call back/no response.

Several respondents complained about overenforcement, believing violations or fines are too strict or reported too often.

- I'm not, nor never will be, a fan of the "City of Ames HOA ordinance" that was recently passed. Someone's overgrown vegetation or old shed is not a nuisance to someone else.
- I've known people to be charged because the grass in their lawn was slightly too tall and fined even after shoveling their sidewalk to their best extent during the snowstorms these past years. It's a bit ridiculous.
- Overgrown lawns are such a pointless nuisance ordinance. Perfect 1950's-esque lawns are asinine in the first place. The City should not waste their time caring for what people do on their own property unless it poses an imminent hazard to other people.

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Figure 12. Comments on Nuisance Enforcement

Street Maintenance

Residents were given the opportunity to rate street maintenance using a four-point scale from "very poor" (1) to "very good" (4) in several different aspects such as snow plowing or street sweeping. The average values ranged from 2.9 to 3.3, meaning the road services were rated from good to very good. "Good" and "Very Good" made up a large percentage of responses in all aspects, with the least satisfaction with snow plowing in neighborhoods (73%) and the most with street sweeping in business areas (94%).

Table 17. Road Service Ratings, 2025

Road Service	Poor/Very Poor	Good/Very Good	Average
	Percent (%)		
Street sweeping in business areas (n=322)	6.2	93.8	3.3
Snow plowing on major streets (n=433)	9.9	90.1	3.3
Appearance of medians and parkways (n=427)	10.3	89.7	3.2
Surface condition of major streets (n=428)	13.3	86.7	3.1
Maintenance of bike path system (on street lanes & paths) (n=345)	13.6	86.4	3.1
Street sweeping in your neighborhood (n=359)	13.6	86.4	3.1
Condition of streets in your neighborhood (n=433)	18.5	81.5	3.1
Ice control at intersections (n=419)	20.0	80.0	3.0
Snow plowing in your neighborhood (n=429)	27.3	72.7	2.9

Figures 13a and 13b compare the respondents' ratings of the quality of street maintenance over the past five years. Seven out of nine street maintenance features had an average score higher than 3.0. Historically, ice control at intersections and snow plowing in neighborhoods have had the lowest scores, however ice control has increased somewhat over the years, and snow plowing has slightly improved from last year.

In 2025, six of the nine street maintenance features mentioned in Table 17 were viewed the same regardless of geographic residence. However, the following maintenance features were rated highest by the following residents: snow plowing in your neighborhood (northwest residents); snow plowing on major street (northeast residents); and street sweeping in your neighborhood (southwest residents).

Figure 13a. Quality of Street Maintenance Features (2021-2025)

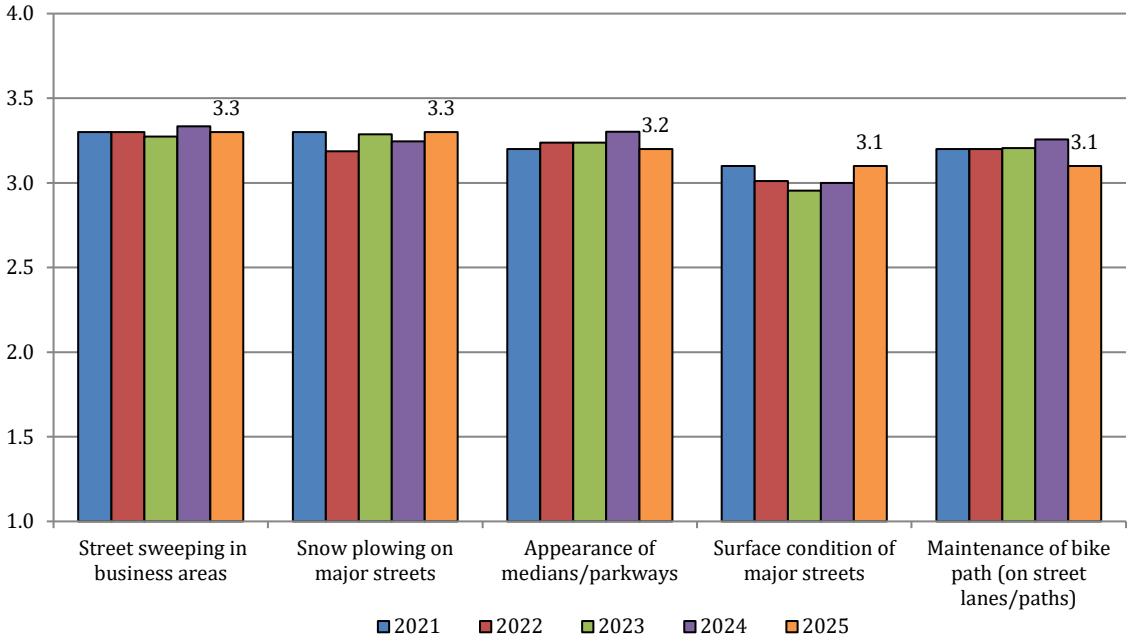
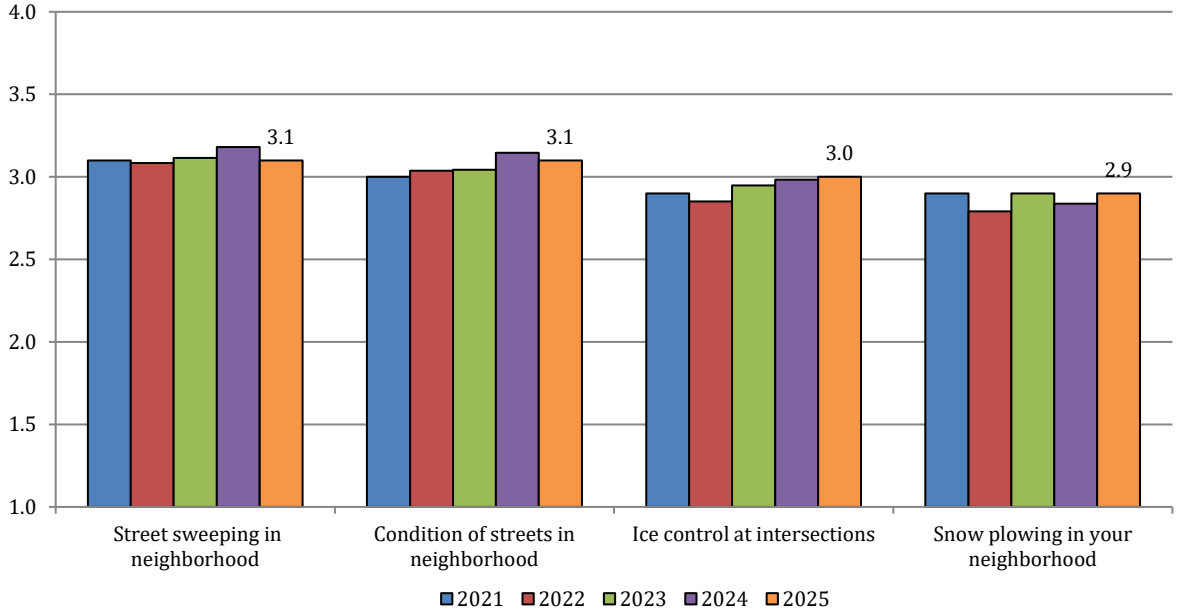


Figure 13b. Quality of Street Maintenance Features Continued (2021-2025)



The survey also asked respondents to rate the effectiveness of coordination between traffic signals. Table 18 shows that when categories were combined, 54% of respondents perceived that the traffic signal coordination was "often and/or almost always" effective, compared to 37% who perceived the coordination "rarely to sometimes" effective. This is a slight decrease in effectiveness from last year. 8% indicated they don't know.

Table 18. Signal Coordination Effectiveness (n=443), 2025

	Percent (%)
Often effective	33
Sometimes effective	29
Almost always effective	21
Don't know	8
Rarely effective	8

Comments on Traffic Signals

Comments on traffic signals tended to fall under three categories: a specific traffic issue, a specific road or intersection, or a specific issue on particular road or intersection. Traffic issues mentioned included timing and coordination of lights, turning arrows, crosswalks, turning lanes, and road conditions.

- I have never lived in a town with more stop lights where the untimed light creates way too much traffic. These factors lead to an already taxed number of vehicles. Why??
- I know they are coordinated but many times it doesn't seem that way. Strive for consistency in left turn signals ... they seem to differ in various areas
- Our crosswalk policy and codes are archaic for a population of this size but so is the rest of Iowa. Cars don't have to yield to pedestrians according to the police.
- New road on West 24- nice road but top surface terrible.
- We need more proper turn lanes.
- Some intersections the signal from yellow to red is very fast.

The most common streets with issues, and with their intersections, were Lincoln Way, Grand Avenue, Duff Avenue, and 13th Street. These are the biggest arterials in Ames.

- You must always stop at traffic lights everywhere, particularly on Lincoln Way and Duff Ave. In Cedar Falls, we had roundabouts instead so rarely had to wait at traffic lights, and when I worked in downtown Waterloo, all the traffic signals were well-timed.
- I often get stopped by red light repeatedly on Grand Ave.
- I wish the Hyland-Ontario/13th St. intersection were a bit quicker for people turning left from Hyland.
- Lincoln Way at sometimes during the day, it is impossible to drive through two green lights. I must stop at every single traffic light due to lack of coordination.
- Streetlights need to be synced on Duff. The flow of lights is inefficient and impairs the flow of traffic.

While various intersections along these streets were mentioned, the most common was the

intersection of 13th Street and Grand Avenue, with many complaining about turning left and the lack of turning lanes or arrows.

- We really need a green arrow system on 13th and Grand. I'm afraid of turning to the left to get to North Grand Mall. It feels unsafe.
- They added a Left turn arrow on 16th and Grand which has been AWESOME, and my next suggestion is putting a Left turn arrow for 13th and Grand because when on 13th St., turning Left onto Grand is very slow and often dangerous and would benefit greatly.
- There needs to be a left signal sign at the intersection of Grand Ave and 13th Street. The road is weirdly elevated, and it is difficult to see oncoming traffic when turning left, so a green arrow light would be very effective there.
- Put a left turn arrow on 13th + Grand eastbound.
- I hear this is in the works already, but a solution to the traffic issues on 13th/Grand would be appreciated. (Left Turns)

There were a few respondents that reported they had no issues, “No issues,” “They are very functional,” and “work well overall.” Lastly, there were a few that had miscellaneous comments or complaints, “They do not make sense,” “State + Mortensen can be a huge back up during am/pm commute,” and “Medians & side streets with rain gardens are always beautiful! :) excellent job on these.”

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

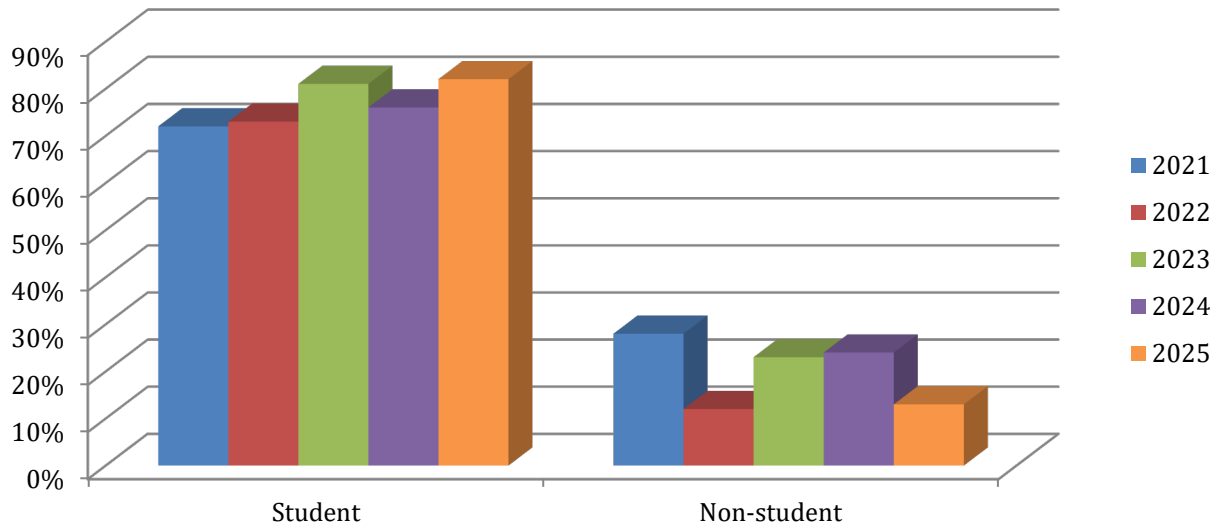
Figure 14. Comments on Traffic Signals

CyRide

CyRide is the community-wide transit system serving both Iowa State University and Ames. It is funded through the City of Ames (from property taxes), ISU administration (from the general fund), and ISU students (from student fees).

Figure 15 shows the difference in ridership between those identifying as students and non-students. Among those respondents who used CyRide at least once a week, 82% were students. 13% were non-students, which is a 9% decrease from last year. Within the past five years, more students have been riding the bus and fewer non-students have been.

Figure 15. Use CyRide at least once a week, 2021-2025



In 2025, 46% of survey respondents reported some weekly use of CyRide, which is a little higher than last year (42%), but the same as previous year. In the past five years, CyRide has averaged around 44% ridership (between 42% and 46%). In 2025, 54% of respondents reported they never rode the bus.

Those who use CyRide once a week decreased by 2% from last year, two to six times a year increased by 2%, seven to ten times stayed the same, and more than ten times increased by 3% (Table 19).

A correlation was found between resident demographics and CyRide usage. CyRide users are mostly younger (under 48 years of age) and have stayed in Ames for a shorter period (average 6 years). The non-CyRide users were older (average age 54) and have lived in Ames longer (average 25 years). The majority of those who used CyRide were students (84%) and mostly renters (87%).

Table 19. Respondents' weekly CyRide usage, 2021 - 2025

Weekly Use	*2021*	*2022*	*2023*	*2024*	*2025*
	Percent (%)				
Never	56	56	54	58	54
2 to 6 times	25	18	19	16	18
7 to 10 times	8	12	13	13	13
More than 10 times	5	7	10	7	10
Once a week	6	7	4	6	4

When respondents were asked what would make them consider using CyRide, if they are not currently using it, more than half (57%) said "nothing." Nearly one in five (18%) said they would use the service if it were more frequent on nearby routes. Additional factors that would encourage increased CyRide ridership included fare-free rides (17%), if service was provided to more areas of Ames (15%), if service is offered on my route longer during the day (12%), and if the fare when boarding the bus was lower (3%). (Table 20).

Table 20. Services that would make you consider using CyRide if not currently using this service (n=210), 2025

Considered Service (n=210)	**Number**	**Percent (%)**
Nothing	120	57
Service was more frequent on routes near me	37	18
The fare when boarding the bus was at no cost	35	17
Services were provided to more areas of Ames	32	15
Service was offered on my route longer during the day (earlier or later times)	25	12
The fare when boarding the bus was lower	6	3
Other (specify)	33	16

Other Responses to Consider Using CyRide

- A stop closer to us; extended hours of services
- Allow dogs.
- Fare rates are confusing.

- Fast passes?
- If I had mobility issues or the weather was bad, I would use it
- I still can drive a car.
- I walk or drive myself around.
- I would like to try it. We got a map when we moved here 5 yrs ago.
- If I could no longer drive myself
- If I didn't have a car, or the parking in Ames got even worse.
- It's very accessible on campus and in business districts, but less so in residential areas.
- Knowing rates/routes/times
- Lack of other transportation
- Less stops from areas to east Ames from West Ames
- Maps of routes provided to the community.
- Nearest stop to my house is 1.5 miles away- too far.
- Not a service I need.
- Perhaps when I cannot drive.
- I prefer driving myself.
- Retired- no commuting.
- shorter + more direct routes that don't involve transfers on campus.
- Stop closer to my P.O.E.
- Stop nearer my home.
- The route I would take has a bus switch + I get nervous I will mess it up.
- The routes that are in my neighborhood are indirect and take almost an hour to get to my destination.
- There is no CyRide that comes.
- There is one bus that goes by our house, it is useless for my travels to class.
- Unknown
- Use own car.
- Use a walker and it's hard to get to a bus stop. Unable to find services/qualify for services that help with this disability.
- We are a younger, more able age.

Comments on CyRide

There were 122 respondents who had extra comments about CyRide. The majority reported they were satisfied with the service or had something good to say about it.

- Bus drivers respectful and drive safely, parking for passengers with passengers and other drivers in-mind.
- CyRide is a great transit system! My husband and I use it daily (throughout the week) to get to and from campus. This is a huge benefit.
- CyRide makes it possible for me (and many others) to live in Ames without a car. The service is very consistent, and the buses are nice and clean. I love being able to have high-quality public transit.
- I love CyRide; I use the Orange Route every single day.

- My two-year daughter loves the CyRide and celebrates every time she gets to see a bus.
- A fair number of respondents reported complaints about CyRide, most about bus stops being too far away or buses not coming frequently enough. Others reported these reasons as to why they don't use CyRide, along with driving being more convenient or preferring to walk or bike to their destination.
- Bus number 7 usually is not available in the time frame I need a ride.
- Driving is just too much easier. I'm looking at a time when I will no longer be driving and hope I can get to + from bus stops. I have looked at schedules and time needed to travel versus driving and driving always wins- now.
- I do not have a CyRide come near my apartment.
- I wish more routes operated on weekends. Routes like Cardinal not running weekends makes it hard to move around campus then especially with so little parking.
- I would have to walk .5 miles to get to a bus stop. I doubt I would use it.
- It is faster for me to ride my bike than to take CyRide so I bike if the weather allows it. Because closest stop is ~10 min walks, I do not ride a bus in bad weather, either, because that is too far to walk (closest stop to walk is 10 min, otherwise stop is on the edge of my yard). I do occasionally ride the bus. I also bike for the exercise so would not bus in good weather anyway.
- It's concentrated to go to and from ISU. We are beyond this and therefore it is not useful to us
- The closest bus stop is roughly 1/2 mile away and my current health will not let me walk that far.

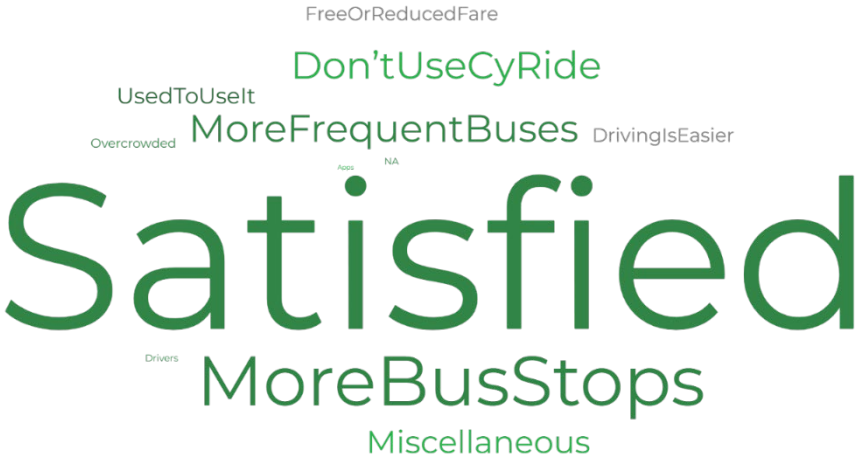
Even though many respondents reported not using CyRide, some still commended the service and believe it is beneficial to the community, "Cy-Ride is good for those that need to use it." Another said, "I love that we have CyRide and appreciate the service throughout Ames, do not ride it due to preferring the flexibility of my own vehicle." Even some that had a complaint, still admired the service, "Great- kind of sucks on the weekends though, and getting around Ames (lowkey)."

Some specific comments about bus stops focused on the lack of bus stops in neighborhood farther from campus, making it inconvenient for residents in those neighborhoods to use CyRide, or get to destinations in those areas. A few commented about buses being too crowded, the CyRide app needing improvement, they desire free or reduced fares, and some drivers braking too hard.

- "I strongly support CyRide as a service to the Ames community. I recall fare free was provided several years ago... I would encourage consideration for this again.
- If ISU students can ride CyRide by showing their ID for free because they pay student fees, then why can't the Ames school kids ride CyRide by showing their school Id's? Our parents pay our taxes so why can't our kids ride for free during the year?
- Lot of the drivers brake really hard.
- Orange route is usually overfull in the morning. It needs a good way to flexibly add buses when there's high demand. The rest has been fine, besides having difficulty finding a bus later at night last year when I had no car.
- They do a decent job, but I believe that Ames Ride App needs to be entirely reworked as it often bugs out.
- I would ride more if the fare when boarding was no cost.

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Figure 16. Comments on CyRide



Community Parks and Recreation

Two additional features for parks and recreation were added to this year's survey. These are "Overall quality of indoor aquatics" and "overall quality of outdoors aquatics".

Residents were asked to rate their level of satisfaction with various Ames Parks and Recreation features on a four-point scale from "very poor (1)", "poor (2)", "good (3)", "very good (4)" or "don't use." The individuals who did not use a park feature were excluded from the ratings in Table 21.

Parks and Recreation features continue to receive high satisfaction levels among those surveyed. When positive ratings of "good" and "very good" scores were combined, participants gave an overall satisfaction rate of 69% for the overall quality of indoor aquatics up to 99% for the overall quality of parks. The average rating ranges from 2.8 (indoor aquatics) to 3.5 (overall quality of parks, and overall quality of trails) on the 4-point scale.

Table 21. Users' Satisfaction with Parks and Recreation Features, 2025

Feature	Very Poor	Poor	Good	Very Good	Average*
	Percent (%)				
Overall quality of parks		0.7	47.1	52.2	3.5
Overall quality of trails		2.0	50.4	47.6	3.5
Overall quality of wooded/natural areas		6.4	44.7	48.9	3.4
Overall quality of recreational facilities (e.g. Homewood Golf Course, Gymnasium, etc.)		2.8	52.8	44.4	3.4
Variety of playground equipment in the parks	0.4	4.7	50.7	44.2	3.4
Overall quality of recreational programming	0.4	5.7	55.3	38.5	3.3
Overall quality of outdoor aquatics	2.1	9.6	42.9	45.4	3.3
Variety of recreational programming offered	0.4	8.1	53.8	37.7	3.3
Overall quality of shelters and picnic amenities	0.5	6.5	61.4	31.6	3.2
Number of restrooms in the parks	1.5	21.4	59.9	17.2	2.9
Overall quality of indoor aquatics	11.3	19.6	45.8	23.2	2.8

"Don't Use" excluded when calculating percentages & average for "very good" to "very poor."
*1=very poor; 2=poor; 3=good; 4=very good

Figures 17a & 17b show the ratings of the parks in the past five years (2021-2025). Table 17a shows the first five features rated the highest for 2025 (3.4 and above).

The highest rated parks features were "quality of trails", and "overall quality of parks" (with an average rating of 3.5, which is the same as 2024 ratings), followed by "variety of playground equipment in the parks," "overall quality of recreational facilities (e.g. Homewood Golf Course, Gymnasium, etc.)," and "overall quality of wooded/natural areas" (all rated as 3.4 for 2024, which the same as 2024 ratings except for the last feature (3.5 in 2024).

Two features, "variety of recreational programming offered," and overall quality of recreational programming" were rated the same as last year (3.3, respectively). "Overall quality of shelters and picnic amenities" satisfaction ratings decreased slightly from 3.3 in 2024 to 3.2 for the current year. The "number of restrooms in the park" remained the same and still has the lowest rating (2.9 in both years). Two new items added this survey year were: "overall quality of outdoor aquatics," and "overall quality of indoor aquatics," had among the lowest rank (3.3 and 2.8 average ratings, respectively). (Figure 17b)

Figure 17a. Rating of Parks and Recreation Features in the Past 5 Years (3.4+)

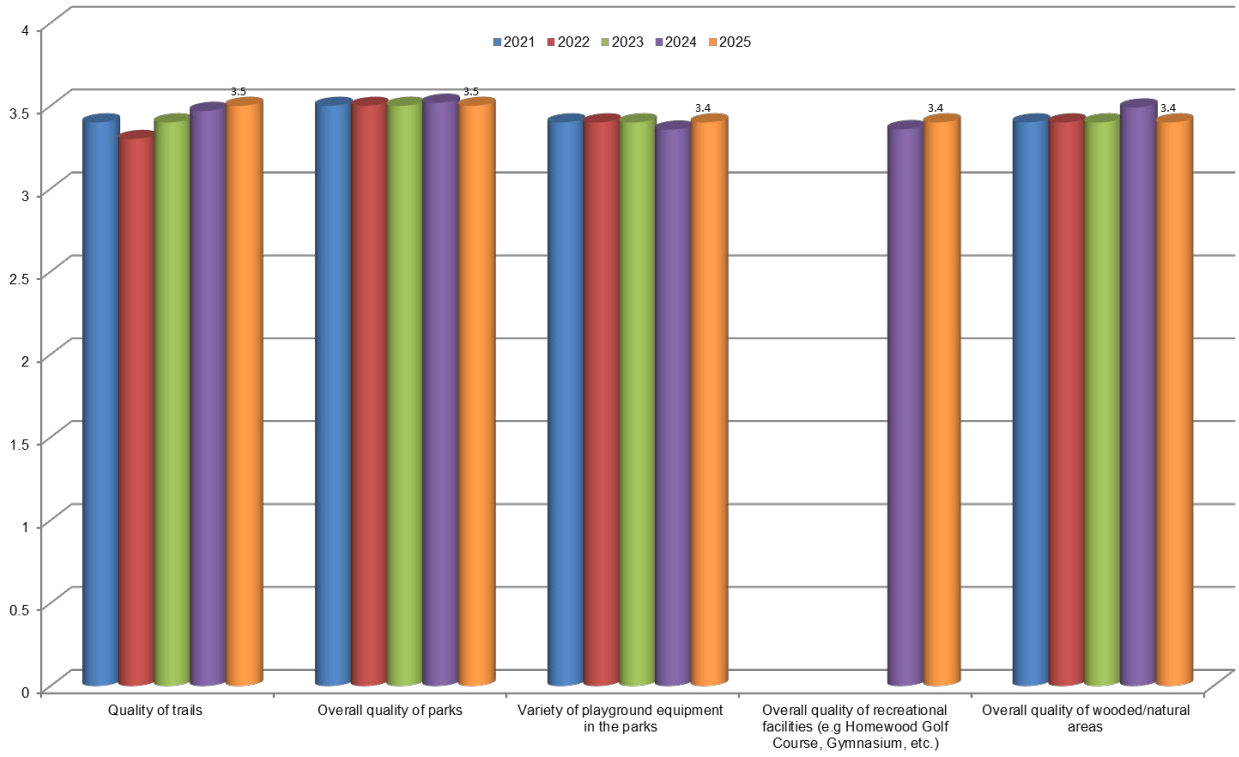
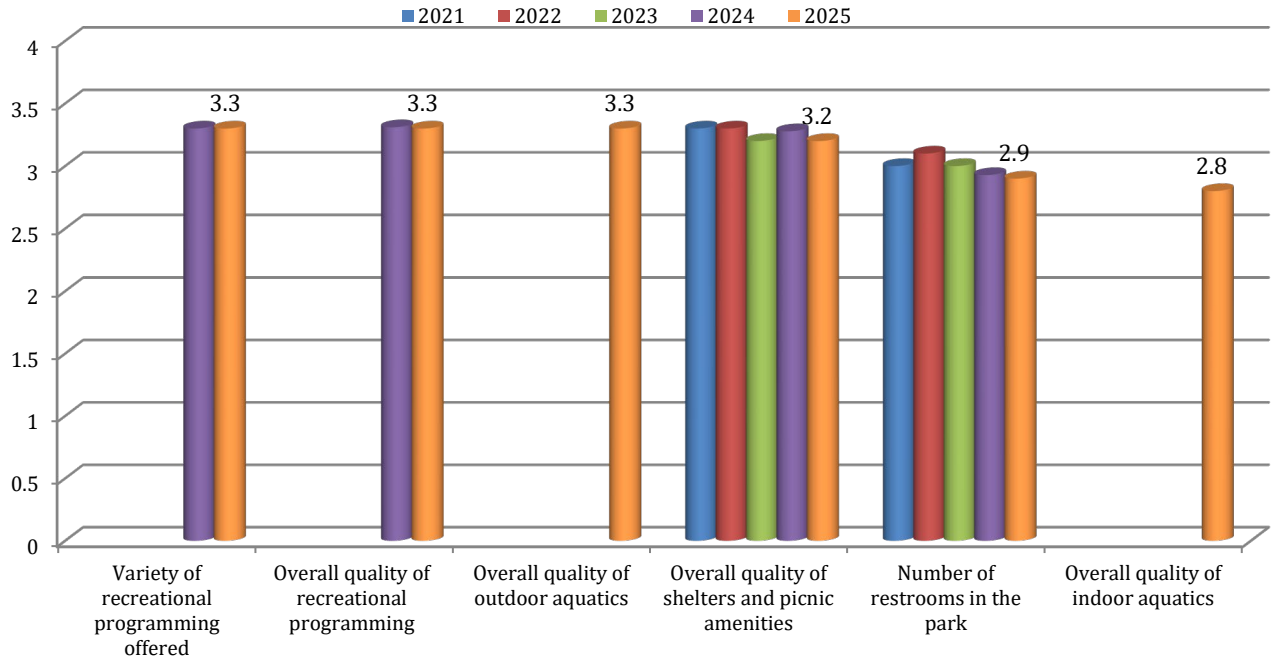


Figure 17b. Rating of Parks and Recreation Features in the Past 5 Years, (<3.4)



Comments on Community Parks and Recreation Services

Many respondents who left a comment on Parks and Recreation left positive comments. Some admired the overall parks and recreation system, while others commented on specific parks or services.

- Ada Hayden is a gem!
- Ames parks are wonderful. Love the pool for water walking and entertaining grandchildren.
- Areas I use - like Brookside - are always clean + well-kept.
- Do love the Furman aquatic center and look forward to the new indoor aquatic center.
- Homewood Golf Course is a fantastic resource in our community.
- I really enjoy going on runs around Ada Hayden and other parks around Ames. I appreciate that Ames has a lot of sidewalks and trails I can use for running.
- I love all the little hidden gems in the parks and so many different trails to hike!

Common critiques or complaints about parks and recreation revolved around improved swimming facilities, park maintenance and clean-up, and an improved trail system. Several responses focused on improving both indoor and outdoor swimming opportunities and creating a larger trail system through Ames.

- Could use more proactive cleanup/repairs instead of relying on citizen reporting
- It’s nice to get out to the local parks. I wish there were more natural forest trails away from traffic, but all in all I enjoy the outdoor spaces.
- Deteriorating Quality of habitats - invasive species.
- My only noticeable concern when using parks/trails is the trash littered everywhere.
- Please continue adding connection trails. Cyclists need safe ways to travel that don't involve riding in traffic, e.g. no bike lanes.
- Quality of kids’ swim lessons needs work. Please turn off sprinklers on the lazy river.
- I'd love to swim laps year-round in a 25/50 m pool. I hope the new indoor pool offers a lot of options for moderate-fast lap swimming too. Wish there was 50 m lap swimming during the day/evening, not just the crack of dawn.

Other topics covered in the comments were improved or expanded parks, bathrooms, costs, signage and information, and programming and activities.

- Better connection/organization of city bike trails. They seem to start/end randomly. Crossing signal/lower speed limit where bike paths crosses 13th near Stagecoach. Duff is not a "bike friendly" street.
- Greenbrier Park is right next to a bike trail, and it is also near the stadium. I think it would be beneficial if this park had a restroom. I know many people who walk on the trail nearby on a regular basis and think a restroom would be beneficial.
- I hope that people/families with low incomes have reduced or no fees.
- I would like to see more playgrounds and parks in north Ames.
- I would love for information to be more readily available! For example, posted trail routes and camping area :)

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix.

Figure 18. Comments on Community Parks and Recreations Services

Ames Public Library

Generally, survey respondents rated the Ames Public Library's features highly. The survey asked respondents to provide opinions on 13 features provided by the Ames Public Library. Table 22 shows the results. Many respondents indicated that they don't use the various library features. The least used library feature is the library newsletter - Page One; 75% of respondents indicated they don't use it.

On the 4-point scale, average scores of the 13 features of the library ranged from 3.3 (good) to 3.7 (very good).

The four highest rated features, with an average score of 3.7, were the welcoming atmosphere of the library, customer service, variety of available materials (books, movies, online resources), and the ease of asking questions of library staff by phone or email.

The feature receiving the lowest rating was waiting time for requests/holds (average score of 3.3).

Table 22. Users' Ratings of Ames Public Library Features, 2025

Library Feature	Very Poor	Poor	Good	Very Good	Don't Use*	Average*
	Percent (%)					
Customer service (n=295)	<1	2	15	48	35	3.7
Asking questions of library staff by phone or email (n=220)		1	14	34	51	3.7
Welcoming atmosphere (n=310)		2	20	47	31	3.7
Variety of materials available (books, movies, online resources) (n=295)		1	21	43	35	3.7
Use of library online resources (n=221)		<1	18	31	51	3.6
Bookmobile service (n=167)		1	13	23	63	3.6
Programs (Storytime, book discussions, lectures) (n=157)	<1		13	22	65	3.6
Internet/computer services (n=199)	<1	<1	17	27	56	3.6
Building accessibility (n=307)	1	1	25	41	32	3.6
Meeting/study rooms (n=223)		1	19	29	51	3.6
Availability of seating (n=258)		2	23	32	43	3.5
Page One – the library newsletter (n=112)	<1		12	13	75	3.5
Wait time for requests/holds (n=232)		5	26	21	48	3.3

*Don't Use response not included in calculating the average

Forty-two percent of respondents use the Ames Public Library as often as they would like to use it.

Of those respondents who use the public library, 44% were ISU students. Both students and non-students reported the same primary reasons: not having time, and acquiring materials from other sources, for not using the Ames Public Library. While 24% of Iowa State students listed parking as a barrier for not using the Ames Public Library more often, only 15% of non-ISU students listed that as a reason.

Table 23. Comparing Students & Non-students' Reasons for Not Using the Ames Public Library (respondents could choose multiple responses), 2025

Resident Status	I don't have time	I get materials from other sources	Parking (Transportation) is a problem	Other
	Percent (%)			
Iowa State University student (n=140)	61	39	18	19
Non-ISU student (n=111)	50	36	4	31

Other reasons mentioned for not using the Ames Public Library were:

- By non-student (n=34)
  - Parking cost (8X)
  - Doing other things – not a priority (2x)
  - Feels dangerous at times (2x)
  - Internet
  - Health
  - Wish for more hours (i.e. Friday nights)
  - It has become a homeless shelter. Get back to providing library services.
- By ISU students (n=26)
  - I use the university library (8x)
  - Parking is an issue (i.e. cost, availability) (4x)
  - I honestly had forgotten about public libraries as a resource; I used to be a member of my library back home and didn't think of applying for membership while I am living in Ames.
  - I use my library account through the apps Hoopla and Libby, but I'd really like to go to the library more often since it really is a wonderful space
  - We tend not to visit around cold/flu season.
  - I'm not as aware of the resources the library has to offer besides book check-outs. I would like to learn more and start going more frequently!
  - It doesn't come to mind typically as a resource
  - It's not advertised well. I forgot that it has resources and programs available
  - Not enough space in study rooms, uncomfortable chairs in study rooms
  - Possible lack of seats

Comments on Ames Public Library

One hundred twenty-eight (128) respondents had additional comments about the Ames Public Library, with 64% having an overall positive opinion. Of those who had positive comments, they either had a general admiration of the library or specifically admired the resources and services, the staff, the environment, or the programming. Here are some examples:

- Welcoming community, I have been able to make use of their online resources as well. Good place to study because of the outlets on the tables. Also, nice that there are separate areas for children/teens/college students.
- We have an amazing library & library staff- a great asset to our community.
- Very nice places, especially for children, love the layout of the library. I think it's very pretty, decent size, and there are very cool activities/projects to do at the library that they give you access to.
- One of the most important third spaces available to the community. It is absolutely irreplaceable and should receive all the funding it requests and then some.
- LOVE the public library! I wish I had more time to hang out there and use the resources - such a wonderful place to be.
- Library staff have been super helpful in answering questions and suggesting resources and recommending books to me and my kids. I very much appreciate the variety of options to get involved and be connected at the library.
- I love the Bookmobile as a college student!
- I ADORE the library. It's great for meeting with friends in the summer & refilling my water bottle while taking walks! I love playing mobile games downtown, and the library is a great central area.
- Great selection of books and always have good resources with a welcoming staff.

Some respondents reported that they do not use the library, some because they have no use for it or they use Parks Library instead.

- I don't have any reason to use it regularly.
- Never been. Parks are good enough
- Do not use it at all, but have heard good things about it

Several respondents either had comments or suggested improvements for the library that revolved around free or expanded parking, improving various resources or services, concerns about homeless and other library patrons, improved accessibility, or more hours. Here are a few examples:

- Accessibility is way more than just having a ramp.
- Audio books can sometimes be a 3-month wait time.
- I just wish there were more study rooms. I also wish the study rooms were more soundproof and had better chairs (the red rollie chairs in front of the computers instead of the hard metal chairs)
- Parking is very limited and what is available is pay to park.

- The library is no longer safe as it appears to be a homeless shelter instead of a library. No longer welcoming, I would not take my kids there.
- There are no available parking spaces for the public without a meter, which under the State of Iowa laws regarding public libraries there are certain requirements for public spaces based on population. There is also the standard of every other city or town in Iowa providing parking for patrons, however Ames does not. That is the main reason why I do not use the library, because it is not welcoming to all people.
- Too many mentally ill and homeless people use the library resources and do not follow the rules. There are people yelling, smoking, eating, and drinking on the library grounds and inside. It makes it feel unsafe and unwelcoming. It is not good to have kids walk past people huffing smoke.
- We disagree with the policy that allows minors to have library cards with no oversight from parents- I should be able to ask a staff member for help with my very young son's account without his permission.

For additional and specific comments, see the appendix

Figure 19. Comments on Ames Public Library

Information Dissemination (Communication)

The next section of the questionnaire focused on residential preferences for City of Ames communications. Respondents were asked to rate the usefulness of City communications sources on a three-point scale: 1- "not useful", 2 – "somewhat useful", 3 – "very useful," as well as "don't use." Table 24 shows the results. The most frequently used sources for local government information included the City of Ames website (www.CityOfAmes.org) (60%), and ISU Daily Newspaper (53%).

The least accessed government information sources were Threads - City of Ames, LinkedIn – City of Ames, X/Twitter – City of Ames, Nextdoor – City of Ames, KHOI Community Radio, and Ames Television/Cable TV 12. When asked about the degree of usefulness of those sources, the most helpful source was reported to be social media, including Facebook – City of Ames (average of 2.5 on a 1-3 scale), followed by City of Ames Web page (www.CityOfAmes.org), CitySide (utility bill insert), ISU Daily newspaper, Instagram – City of Ames, and KHOI Community Radio (average of 2.4 on a 1-3 scale, respectively). The City of Ames website was the most highly used source, and second in usefulness (2.4).

Table 24. Usefulness of Media Sources for Government Information, 2025

Media Source	Don't Use	Use	Use Average*
	Percent (%)		
Facebook - City of Ames (n=397)	55	45	2.5
City of Ames Web page (www.CityOfAmes.org) (n=395)	40	60	2.4
CitySide (utility bill insert) (n=395)	54	46	2.4
ISU Daily newspaper (n=397)	47	53	2.4
Instagram – City of Ames (n=396)	80	20	2.4
KHOI Community Radio (n=395)	85	15	2.4
Des Moines Register newspaper (n=396)	63	37	2.3
KASI/KCCQ radio (n=395)	81	19	2.3
Ames Tribune newspaper (n=393)	63	37	2.2
Ames Television/Cable TV 12 (n=397)	88	12	2.2
X/Twitter – City of Ames (n=393)	91	9	2.0
LinkedIn – City of Ames (n=395)	91	9	1.9
Nextdoor – City of Ames (n=396)	88	12	1.9
Threads - City of Ames (n=395)	93	7	1.6

*1=not useful; 2=somewhat useful; 3=very useful

Next, those surveyed were asked to choose up to three preferred communications methods for construction projects, programs, and meetings in their respective area.

Figure 20 shows that email (52%) is the first preferred method of communication, followed by hard copy letter (42%), and thirdly by social media (37%). Figure 20 also shows the least popular method of communication with the city regarding programs and projects. These methods are radio, local newspaper, and the City of Ames app.

When asked what other means of communication they prefer, the following items were mentioned: CitySide Newsletter (monthly newsletter, which is included with the utility bill), road signs, and the City of Ames app.

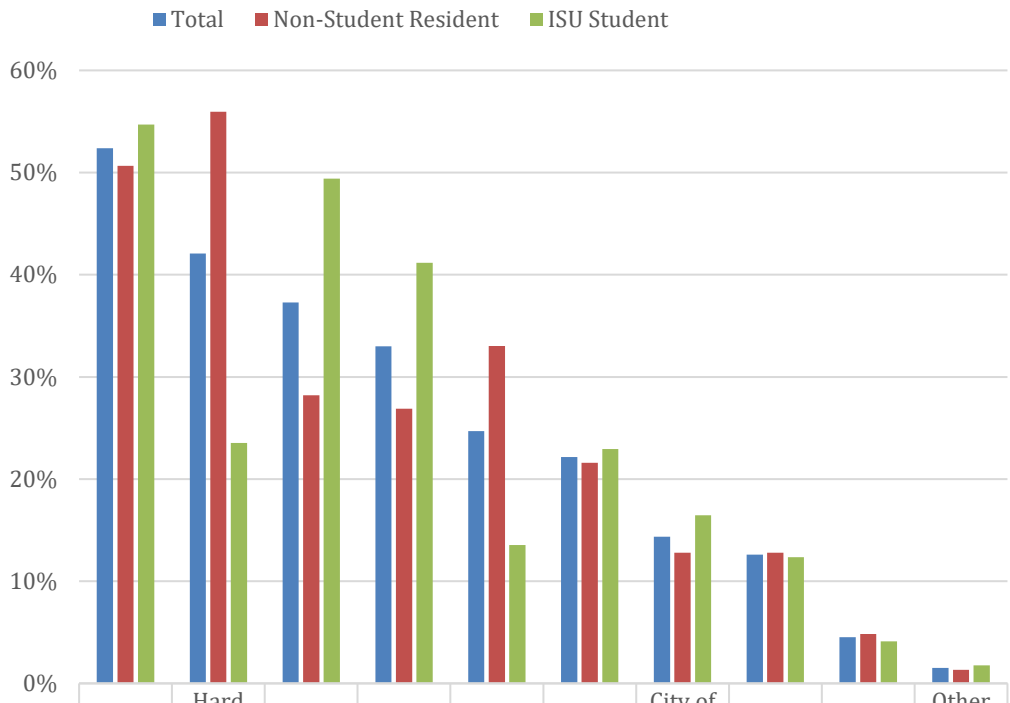
For ISU students:

- first preference was email (55%)
- second preference was social media (49%), and the
- third preference was website (41%).

For the non-student residents:

- first preference was hard copy letter (56%)
- second preference was email (51%), and the
- third preference was doorhanger (33%).

Figure 20. Preferred Method to Learn about City Services, Programs, or Projects, 2025, top 3



	Email	Hard copy letter	Social media	Website	Doorhanger	Text	City of Ames app	Newspaper	Radio	Other (specify)
Total	52%	42%	37%	33%	25%	22%	14%	13%	5%	2%
Non-Student Resident	51%	56%	28%	27%	33%	22%	13%	13%	5%	1%
ISU Student	55%	24%	49%	41%	14%	23%	16%	12%	4%	2%

Figures 21a and 21b illustrate trends in the perceived usefulness of City communication sources over five years. In last year's survey (2024), six news sources were added: Facebook-City of Ames, Instagram-City of Ames, X/Twitter–City of Ames, Nextdoor-City of Ames, Threads–City of Ames, and LinkedIn–City of Ames.

Table 21b shows the usefulness of six sources that had the lowest usefulness ratings (below 2.3 and below). The four sources with significantly decreased scores were X/Twitter – City of Ames; LinkedIn – City of Ames; Nextdoor – City of Ames; and Threads - City of Ames. Those have an average score of 2.0 and below.

Figure 21a. Usefulness of News Sources Over the Past 5 Years (Users only)

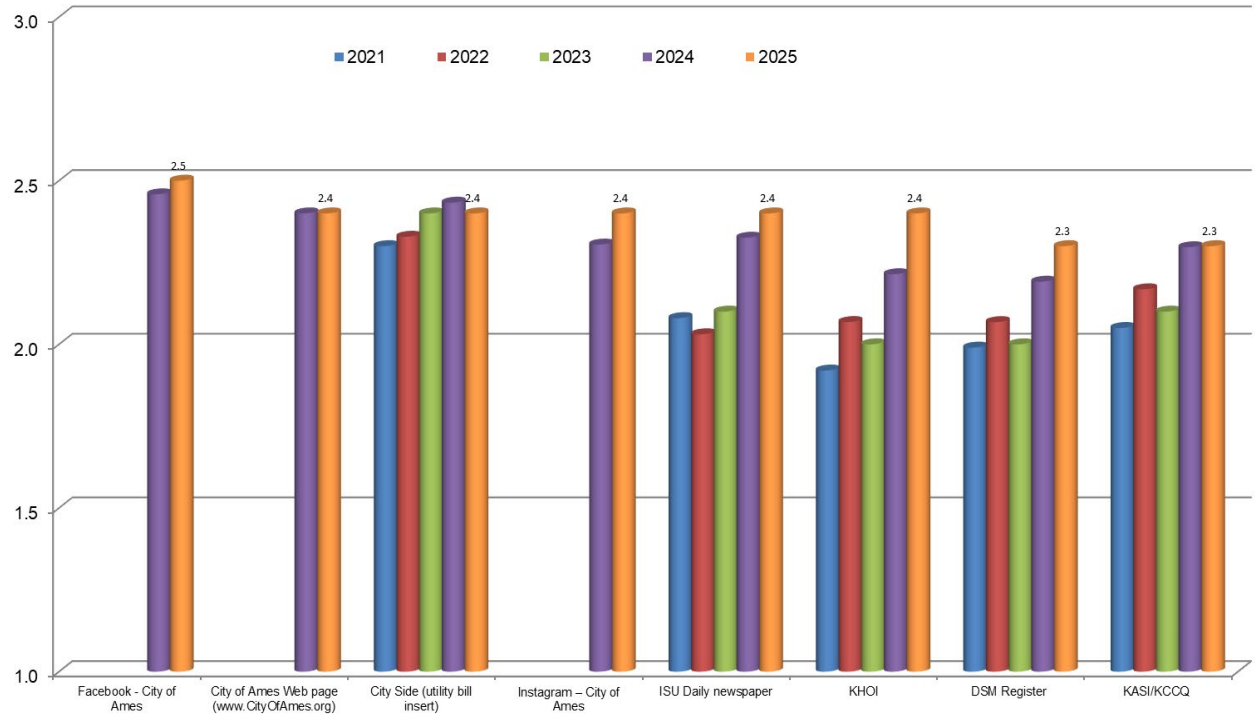


Figure 21b. Usefulness of News Sources Over the Past 5 Years (Users only) (continued)

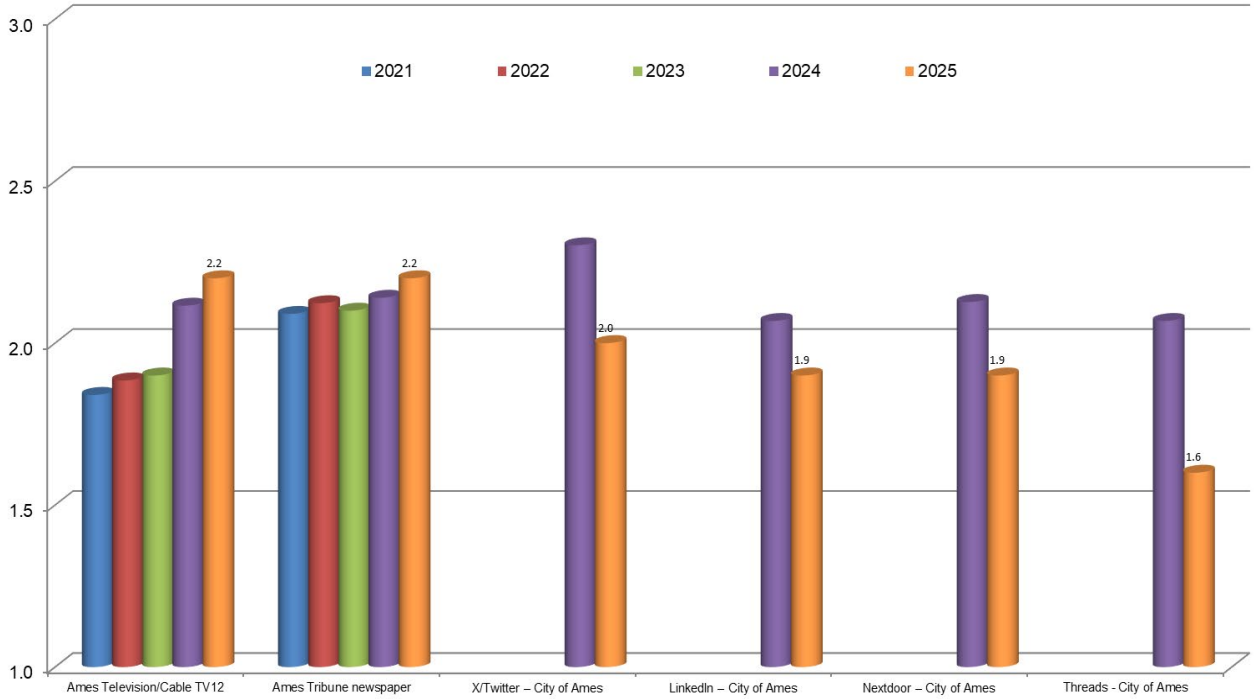


Table 25 indicates the usefulness of various communication tools based on the respondent's residency status. None of the primary sources were rated equally by both ISU students and non-student residents. The average scores between non-student residents and ISU students were different.

-

Average values of these three communication tools were rated higher by the non-student residents: Facebook- City of Ames, CitySide (utility bill insert), and KASI/KCCQ radio. The rest were rated higher by the ISU students. Three communication tools had significantly rated higher by students were ISU Daily newspaper, Des Moines Register newspaper and Ames Television/ Cable TV 12.

Table 25. Usefulness of News Sources for Non-student and ISU Students

Information Sources	Non-student Resident	Student
	Average	
Facebook - City of Ames	2.52	2.46
CitySide (Utility bill insert)	2.44	2.33
City of Ames Web page (www.CityOfAmes.org)	2.40	2.51
KHOI Community Radio	2.37	2.32
Instagram – City of Ames	2.23	2.45
KASI/KCCQ radio	2.23	2.43
Ames Tribune newspaper	2.20	2.36
ISU Daily newspaper*	2.16	2.52
Des Moines Register newspaper*	2.12	2.51
Nextdoor – City of Ames	1.83	1.94
Ames Television/Cable TV 12*	1.82	2.34
X/Twitter – City of Ames	1.79	2.14
LinkedIn – City of Ames	1.67	2.04
Threads - City of Ames	1.54	1.73

*Statistically significant at .05 levels

Note: Average was computed using these values: 1= "not useful"; 2= "somewhat useful"; 3= "very useful"

This is the second year the respondents were asked about their willingness to use a City of Ames app that supplied City news, construction projects, programs and meetings. This year more respondents said "Yes" (62% compared to last year (57%)). Comparing the non-student residents to ISU students, more (60%) of the non-student residents are willing to use the City of Ames app. While only 40% of the ISU students would use it. This trend is the same as last year.

Human Services Agency Funding (ASSET)

New questions related to human services agency funding (ASSET) were asked this year. Fifteen ASSET funder services were identified, and respondents were asked if they ever use those services. A follow-up question was also asked if they think the City should provide less, the same, or more funding to those 15 individual ASSET services.

The three main services and their respective components are the following:

Mental health and substance use disorder needs

1. Community-based and outpatient mental health services
2. Outpatient mental health/substance abuse emergency services or crisis intervention services
3. Awareness and education about suicide prevention and treatment
4. Substance-use prevention and treatment

Basic needs

5. Housing and emergency sheltering
6. Housing cost-assistance programs including utility assistance
7. Food assistance for nutritious perishables and staples
8. Quality childcare assistance programs, including daycare and licensed in-home facilities
9. Medical and dental services
10. Financial literacy and educational programs
11. Transportation programs
12. Legal assistance
13. Disaster response

Youth development services and activities

14. Skill development and enhancement
15. Summer enrichment/prevention of loss learning

Table 26 shows that some respondents have used human services under ASSET. The highest human services used by the respondents were under "basic needs" category specifically transportation program (16%) and medical and dental services (13%). Only 1% used legal assistance and disaster response.

When asked if the City should spend less, same, or more on ASSET human services, the majority wanted the City to spend the same or more on those services. This is based on a scale of 1-3 (1 being less, 2 as the same, and 3 as more spending). The ratings given by the respondents ranged from 2.1 (legal assistance) to 2.4 (7 out of 15 identified services/activities). These were "Community-based and outpatient mental health services," "Outpatient mental health/substance abuse emergency services or crisis intervention services," "Substance-use prevention and treatment," "Housing and emergency sheltering," "Housing cost-assistance programs including

utility assistance," "Food assistance for nutritious perishables and staples," and "Quality childcare assistance programs, including daycare and licensed in-home facilities."

Based on the three major categories (mental health and substance use needs, basic needs, and youth development service and activities), only 2% to 5% of the respondents have used those services. In terms of funding allocations, majority indicated they want the same funding (average ranged from 2.2. to 2.4) (Table 26)

Of the 16% who had used the transportation program, 90% were ISU students, only 10% were non-student residents. However, there were less students (61%) who used the medical and dental services compared to non-student residents (39%).

Table 26. Use and funding allotment of ASSET human services

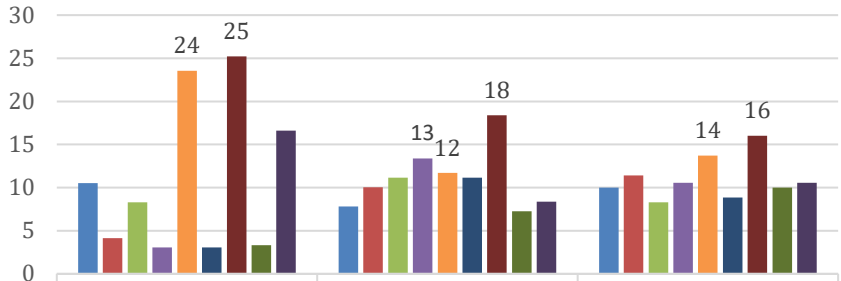
ASSET Category	ASSET Human Service	Have used the service (%)	Spend less or more? (Average)	Have used the service (Section %)	Spend less or more? (Section Average)
Mental health and substance use disorder needs	1. Community-based & outpatient mental health services (n=307)	6	2.4	4	2.4
	2. Outpatient mental health/substance abuse emergency services or crisis intervention services (n=310)	3	2.4		
	3. Awareness & education about suicide prevention and treatment (n=308)	5	2.3		
	4. Substance-use prevention and treatment (n=305)	2	2.4		
Basic needs	5. Housing and emergency sheltering (n=313)	3	2.4	5	2.3
	6. Housing cost-assistance programs including utility assistance (n=313)	3	2.4		
	7. Food assistance for nutritious perishables and staples (n=313)	5	2.4		
	8. Quality childcare assistance programs, including daycare and licensed in-home facilities (n=311)	1	2.4		
	9. Medical and dental services (n=314)	13	2.2		
	10. Financial literacy and educational programs (n=307)	3	2.3		
	11. Transportation programs (n=306)	16	2.1		
	12. Legal assistance (n=302)	1	2.1		
	13. Disaster response (n=304)	1	2.2		
Youth development service and activities	14. Skill development and enhancement (n=303)	2	2.2	2	2.2
	15. Summer enrichment/prevention of loss of learning (n=304)	2	2.2		

Using the 15 human services listed, respondents were asked to rate the services in terms of priority (highest priority, 2nd highest priority, and 3rd highest priority). Only the first nine services were given priority by the respondents.

The first highest priority ratings were given to: food assistance for nutritious perishables and staples; and housing and emergency sheltering. They were rated as first priorities by 25% and 24%, respectively. Food assistance for nutritious perishables and staples was rated was also rated as 2nd and 3rd highest priorities by 18% and 16%, respectively, by the respondents. (Figure 22)

Of the respondents who gave the highest priority ratings for the following two ASSET services 1) food assistance for nutritious perishables and staples services, and 2) housing and emergency sheltering services were mostly non-student residents (59% and 65% by non-student residents, respectively).

Figure 22. Priority Ratings of ASSET



	Highest priority	2nd highest priority	3rd highest priority
Mental health and substance use disorder needs 1. Community-based & outpatient mental	11	8	10
Mental health and substance use disorder needs 2. Outpatient mental health	4	10	11
Mental health and substance use disorder needs 3. Awareness & edu about suicide	8	11	8
Mental health and substance use disorder needs 4. Substance-use prevention & treatment	3	13	11
Basic Needs 5. Housing and emergency sheltering	24	12	14
Basic Needs 6. Housing cost-assistance programs	3	11	9
Basic Needs 7. Food assistance for nutritious perishables	25	18	16
Basic Needs 8. Quality childcare assistance programs	3	7	10
Basic Needs 9. Medical and dental services	17	8	11

Sense of Community

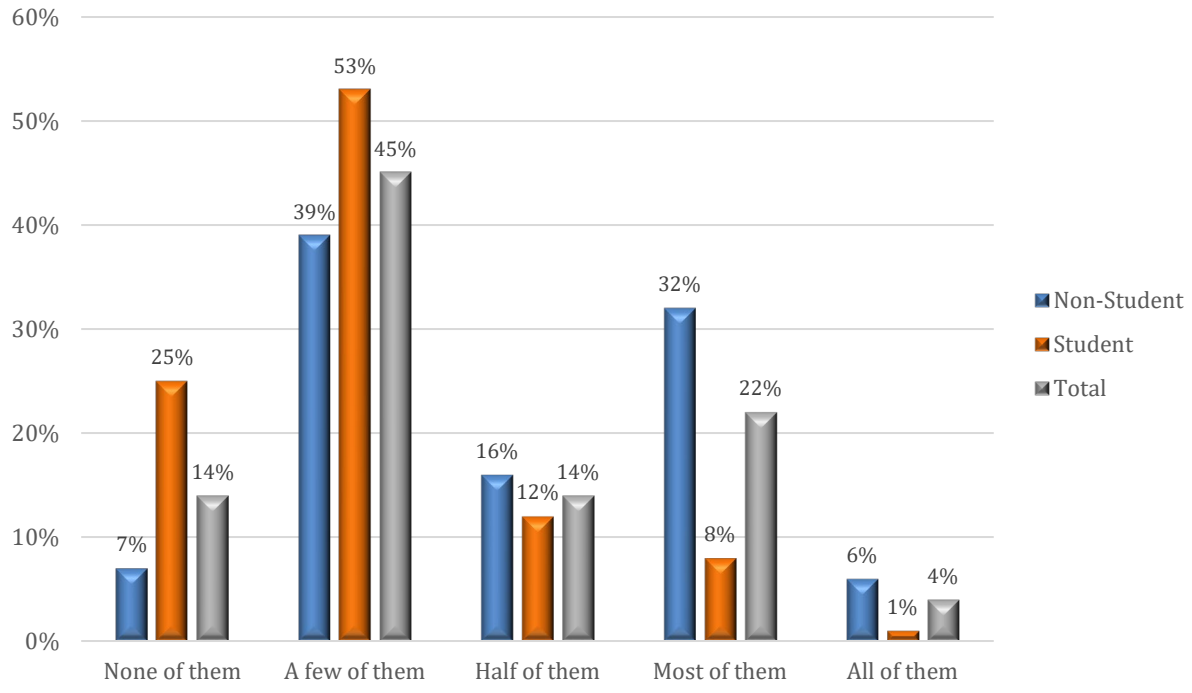
The survey included a question asking about the respondent's perception of connection with the community. Sense of community is a feeling that members have of belonging, a feeling that members matter to one another and to the group, and a shared faith that members' needs will be met through their commitment to be together (McMillan, 1976) https://pdfs.semanticscholar.org/e5fb/8ece108aec36714ee413876e61b0510e7c80.pdf.

A clear and empirically validated understanding of sense of community can provide the foundation for lawmakers and planners to develop programs that meet their stated goals by strengthening and preserving community.

Figure 23 shows that in 2025, 40% of respondents reported knowing at least half of their neighbors. This is a slight increase from 37% in 2024. Comparing students to non-student populations, 54% of the non-students reported knowing at least half of their neighbors, compared to 21% of students.

This year, 7% of non-student respondents reported that they didn't know any of their neighbors, compared to 25% of the student population. Overall, students are more likely to know none to a few of their neighbors and non-students are more likely to know half, most, or all of them.

Figure 23. Neighbors You Know, 2025

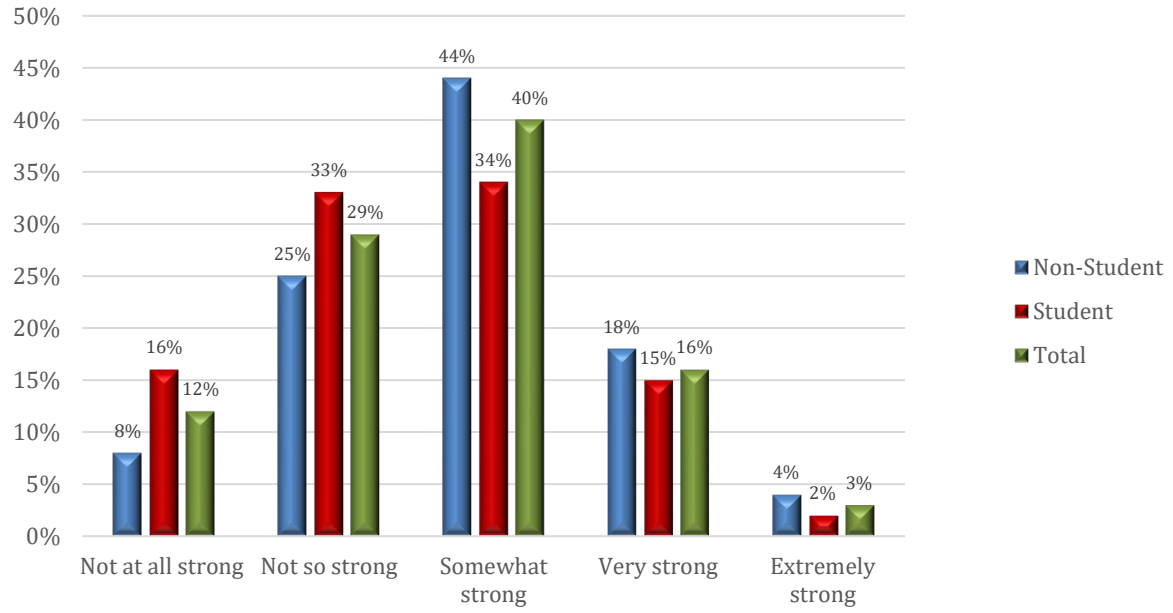


On a scale of 1 to 5 (1 – "not at all strong" to 5 – "extremely strong"), respondents were asked to rate their perceived level of sense of community in their neighborhood. Overall, the most common answer was "somewhat strong" (40%), with 41% responding with "not so strong" or "not strong at all" and 19% responding with "very strong" or "extremely strong". Comparing students and non-students, students had 16% more responses for "not all strong" and "not so strong" than non-students. Non-students had 10% more responses for "somewhat strong". Non-students had more responses for "very strong" or "extremely strong," but only by 5%.

On a scale of 1 to 5 (1 - "not at all strong" to 5 – "extremely strong"), the strength of the sense of community was viewed differently by some demographic groups:

- Household income: no difference
- Employment: no difference
- Length of residence: Long-term residents had stronger sense of community than short-term residents
- Age: no difference
- Residence: no difference
- Gender: no difference
- Race: no difference
- ISU student vs. non-student residents: higher for non-student residents
- Home ownership: higher for homeowner
- Education: no difference

Figure 24. Sense of Community in the Neighborhood, 2025



Respondents responded to a series of statements regarding community involvement. Table 27 summarizes the responses. When asked if "issues facing my community are important to me," 95% agreed (somewhat agree/strongly agree), which increased from 86% in 2023. Nearly 70% of the respondents indicated that they were knowledgeable about issues facing their community, which

significantly increased from 49% in 2024.

As for actionable community involvement, 54% currently support non-profit(s) with financial contributions, 51% are engaged in addressing community issues, 37% currently volunteer for non-profit organization, 19% served or considered serving on a community board or commission, and 11% currently volunteer on a board or commission of an Ames organization. Of respondents, 16% reported language barriers making it difficult to be involved.

Table 27. Community Involvement, 2025

Community Involvement Statements	Strongly/ Somewhat Disagree	Strongly/ Somewhat Agree	Average
	Percent (%)		
Issues facing my community are important to me (n=358)	5	95	3.4
I am knowledgeable about the issues facing my community. (n=353)	31	69	2.8
I currently support nonprofit organization(s) with financial contributions. (n=334)	46	54	2.6
I am engaged in addressing the issues of my community. (n=335)	49	51	2.5
I currently volunteer for a nonprofit organization serving Ames (n=322)	63	37	2.1
I served or considered serving on a City Board or Commission (n=313)	81	19	1.6
Language barriers make it difficult to be involved in the community (n=316)	84	16	1.5
I currently volunteer on a Board or Commission of an Ames organization (n=311)	89	11	1.4

Table 28 shows the demographic characteristics of the respondents who were likely to be involved in community activities.

- Residents ages 45 to 64 were more likely to feel knowledgeable about community issues. Ages 65 to 74 were reportedly more engaged in addressing community issues. Ages 75+ were more likely to financially support a non-profit organization.
- Long-term residents were more likely to report that community issues are important to them, they are knowledgeable about community issues, they financially support non-profit organizations, and they currently volunteer on a board or commission of an Ames organization.
- Gender had no significance in community involvement.
- Respondents with a household income of $200,000+ were more likely to report that they are knowledgeable about community issues and that they served or considered serving on a city board or commission. Respondents with a household income of $75,000 to $99,999 were more

likely to report financially supporting a non-profit organization.

- As compared to renters, owners were more likely to report that community issues are important to them, they are knowledgeable about community issues, they financially support a non-profit organization, and they volunteer for non-profit organization serving Ames.
- Those residing in Northeast Ames were more likely to report that they financially support a non-profit organization.
- Respondents that were non-white were more likely to volunteer on a board or commission of an Ames organization.

Table 28. Community Involvement by Demographic

Community Involvement Statements	Demographics						
	Age	Length of Residence	Gender	HH Income	Home ownership	Geographic Residence	Race
Issues facing my community are important to me (n=358)		Long term*			Owner*		
I am knowledgeable about the issues facing my community (n=353)	45 to 64**	Long term**		$200,000+*	Owner**		
I am engaged in addressing the issues of my community (n=335)	65 to 74*						
I currently support a nonprofit organization with financial contributions. (n=334)	75+ **	Long term**		$75,000 - 99,999**	Owner**	NE*	
I currently volunteer on a Board or Commission of an Ames organization (n=311)		Long term*					Non-white*
I currently volunteer for a nonprofit organization serving the City of Ames (n=322)					Owner*		
I served or considered serving on a City Board or Commission (n=313)				$200,000+*			
Language barriers make it difficult to be involved in the community (n=316)							

** significant at .001 level
*Significant at .05 level

Sense of Belonging

The survey asked respondents to indicate their level of agreement with six statements regarding community integration and sense of belonging to the Ames community. Respondents were asked to respond to six statements on a 4-point scale (1 – "strongly disagree," 2 – "somewhat disagree," 3 – "somewhat agree," 4 – "strongly agree") as well as the option "don't know." Table 29 shows the results.

Respect and a sense of belonging were the most common reported feelings. Of the respondents, 96% felt that they were treated with respect in Ames, followed by 90% feeling that they belong in this town. This is an increase from 2024 (86% respect and 80% belonging), but it is very similar to 2023. 86% of 2025 respondents felt valued as an individual in the Ames community.

Most respondents indicated that they agree (somewhat to strongly agree) that Ames has the social infrastructure for community integration, such as:

- There are one or more organizations in this town where respondents feel they belong (86%)
- Ames has a strong commitment to diversity, equity, and inclusion (86%)
- Ames is a place where they could perform up to their full potential (86%)

All of the above statements have increased in those who agree since 2024, (73%, 72%, and 72%).

The average value shown in Table 29 ranges from 3.1 to 3.4, indicating that most respondents agree that they belong in the community and there are opportunities for integration. However, there are still a percentage that disagree with these statements.

Table 29. Community Integration and Sense of Belonging, 2025

Community Integration and Sense of Belonging Statements	Strongly/ Somewhat Disagree	Somewhat/ Strongly Agree	Average
	Percent (%)		
I am treated with respect at this town (n=362)	4	96	3.4
I feel I belong at this town (n=361)	10	90	3.3
I have found one or more organizations in this town where I feel I belong (n=333)	14	86	3.3
Ames has a strong commitment to diversity, equity, and inclusion (n=317)	14	86	3.2
I feel Ames is a place where I could perform up to my full potential (n=356)	14	86	3.2
I feel valued as an individual in the Ames community (n=345)	14	86	3.1

Table 30 shows that there are some differences in the integration/sense of belonging measures by demographic characteristics of the respondents.

- Residents aged 65 to 74 were more likely to report that Ames has a strong commitment to diversity, equity, and inclusion. Those aged 75+ were more likely to report that Ames is a place where they can perform up to their full potential.
- Long term residents were more likely to report that they feel valued as an individual and they feel like they belong. Short term residents were more likely to report that they have found one or more organizations where they feel like they belong.
- Both females and homeowners were more likely to report that Ames has a strong commitment to diversity, equity, and inclusion, and that Ames is a place where they can perform up to their full potential.
- Those with a household income of $125,000 to $149,999 were more likely to report that Ames is a place where they can perform up to their full potential.
- Those in the Northeast region of Ames were more likely to report that they feel like they belong and that Ames is a place where they can perform up to their full potential.

Table 30. Community Integration and Sense of Belonging Demographic

Community Integration and Sense of Belonging Statements	Demographics						
	Age	Length of Residence	Gender	HH Income	Home ownership	Geographic Residence	Race
I feel valued as an individual in the Ames community (n=345)		Long-term*					
I feel I belong at this town (n=361)		Long-term*				NE	
Ames has a strong commitment to diversity, equity, and inclusion (n=317)	65 to 74*		Female*		Owner*		
I am treated with respect at this town (n=362)							

I feel Ames is a place where I could perform up to my full potential (n=356)	75+*		Female*	$125,000-$149,999*	Owner**	NE	
I have found one or more organizations in this town where I feel I belong (n=333)		Short-term					

** significant at .001 level
*Significant at .05 level

What could be done to enhance your sense of belonging as an Ames resident?

The survey asked respondents to answer the following open-ended question, "What, if anything, could be done to enhance your sense of belonging as an Ames resident?" More than 100 respondents provided answers to this question. The question's wording asked about the reader's sense of belonging in Ames rather than in general or universal terms.

The most common response was a mention of more or improved community events and activities.

- Better advertising of opportunities and activities for meeting and engaging with people with similar interests
- Maybe make it a more happening place by inviting people for group meets for games and stuff. Have more public events.
- More communication about community events
- More opportunities for social gatherings at parks
- IMPROVE PARKING FOR COMMUNITY EVENTS. IF IT'S GOING TO BE A HASSLE TO PARK. I PROBABLY WON'T GO.

Thirty-one percent (31%) of respondents made comments revealing no improvements to be made regarding their sense of belonging. These responses either mentioned that they already feel like they belong, have no interest or don't need help in feeling more belonging, nothing can be done to improve it, or do not know what could be done.

- Nothing that I'm aware of because I feel I belong.
- Nothing really; I am an Iowa State student from Chicago, and I want to live in a big city when I'm done with school. There is nothing wrong with Ames; it is just not my end goal of a living place.
- Not interested. Too much time commitment to job, family, activities. Don't need the

community to make me feel a sense of belonging.
- I am not sure.

Along similar lines, some people responded that their sense of belonging could be improved by personal actions such as attending events or putting more effort into engaging with the community.

- Volunteer as I have in the past
- Join activities at the library and meet people at the parks.
- I should utilize more of the community events that happen in Ames.
- Engaging more

There were opposing viewpoints regarding diversity, equity and inclusion. Twelve responses that mentioned the need for more inclusion, of various types, and six responses that particularly opposed DEI.

Pro-Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

- Stand with the LGBTQIA+ community and our immigrant community.
- Increase education on language barriers, meaning not necessarily teach people more English, but rather create ways in which they can better understand each other
- More diversity visibility
- More senior inclusion

Anti–Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

- The diversity and equality thing is a waste of time. Each person is valuable
- Less DEI. The city spends a lot of time and money on DEI and it is not necessary. Liberal indoctrination. People who are more conservative are not valued in Ames
- Get rid of DEI
- DEI should be eliminated as a city commitment.

Another topic of comments was improved viewpoints and actions from the government. Most of these comments mentioned improvements in the city, but a couple blamed their lack of belonging to higher levels of government. As for city improvements, respondents mentioned a lack of tolerance of conservative viewpoints and more care and communication from city officials.

Some examples are, “A new mayor and city council would be a good start” and “Get city officials to care about more people or at least pretend. Don't be so difficult to contact and communicate with.” Some respondents reported a need for improved resident relations such as nicer people or a stronger connection between permanent residents and the ISU population, “I would like more integration between the student body of ISU and the larger Ames community because I think they currently feel disjointed,” “Ames isn't as friendly as I'm used to coming from SW Iowa. People don't wave or say hi/hello when you speak to them.”

Lastly, some respondents pointed toward more concrete ways to improve their sense of belonging such as improved services and infrastructure, more businesses, or improved community spaces.

- Bigger parks, seatings and lights
- Bring more businesses to Ames!
- Honestly my main concern about Ames is just the lack of good food options. Sure there's a few decent restaurants, but I need a good fried chicken spot which Ames does not have. The addition of a good fried chicken spot would make me feel like I belong.
- Making Ames safer at traffic lights.
- More ethnic stores/grocery stores

To read the full comments, please see the appendix.

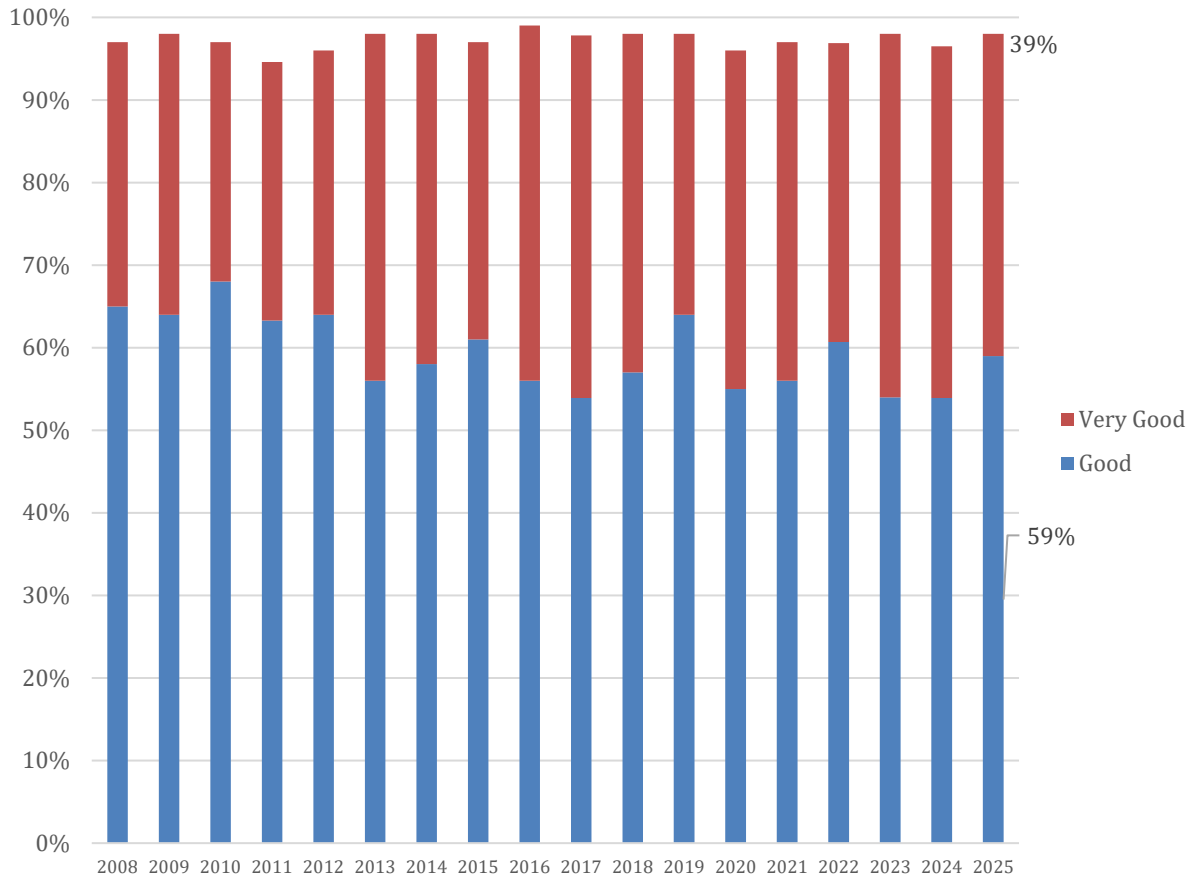
Figure 25. Suggestions for How the City of Ames Could Enhance Your Sense of Belonging

City of Ames Overall Service Quality

Every year, survey respondents are asked to give an overall evaluation of the quality of services they receive from the City of Ames and provide any additional comments. This year, 39% of respondents claimed that services received were "Very Good" a slight decrease from 2024, at 43%.

That change seems to be reflected in an increase for the "Good" category by 5% (54% for 2023 & 2024, respectively, then 59% for 2025). Combined, the "Very Good" and "Good" represent 98% of respondents' satisfaction with Ames services (97% in 2024) (Figure 25).

Figure 26. Trends in Overall Satisfaction with City of Ames Service Quality (good/very good)



Best Thing About Living in Ames

Respondents of this question described Ames welcoming community with great people and a strong sense of community. Of the 278 responses, the most notable aspects that make Ames a great place to live were: the people: parks, green spaces, trails, safety, Iowa State University, events and activities, the available amenities, the atmosphere, and the sense of community.

Comments included:

- Ames offers a high quality of life anchored by a strong sense of community. The residents are kind, grounded, and genuinely supportive of one another, which makes living here both comfortable and meaningful.
- Big enough to have most amenities but small enough to have good community
- The abundance of great amenities and choices and the general proximity to them, the academic culture and pride that the university supplies, and the small businesses that make Ames special.
- I love how safe Ames feels. I appreciate that I feel safe walking home alone as a young woman when I am in Ames.
- Most of Ames is walkable and there's a good number of nature/parks both in separate areas and integrated into the city.
- The calmness and serenity
- The parks and community events!

Other popular responses mentioned the size of Ames, available community services and resources, good government and leadership, a diverse population, and overall quality of life

- City services are fantastic
- I appreciate living in a healthy, attractive, and safe environment, which offers good quality amenities and is still affordable.
- Mixture of people: racial cultures, languages, backgrounds, religions, etc.
- Progression, responsiveness, + competent leadership + workers
- Small town with everything most people need.

Many respondents admired the different aspects of the transportation system in Ames and the ease of getting around. A few mentioned how close everything is, the ease of walking and biking, and the CyRide service.

- Affordable and accessible public transit
- Biking to work. The opportunity to live healthy, eat healthy, work healthy. Ames is walkable and not spread out.
- CyRide is a huge benefit to me and my family.
- Everything is very close together, walkable distance with very nice parks and downtown
- The transportation, while flawed, makes everything easier which is why it should be improved

Other miscellaneous reported aspects include the various businesses and restaurants, the water quality, the cleanliness of the community, downtown/main street, job opportunities, the schools, and affordability, among others.

For additional and more specific comments, please see the appendix.

Figure 27. Best Things about Living in Ames

Other Issues the City Should Focus On

The survey asked respondents if there were other issues that the City should focus attention on. The question resulted in 132 responses.

The two most popular issues were improvements in walkability, bike-ability, and issues with vehicular traffic. Some respondents requested an overall improvement for walkability, bike-ability, and safety for pedestrians and bikers, while some mentioned specific areas and streets that needed improvements. Many comments about traffic mentioned particular streets, such as Duff Avenue and the intersection of Grand Avenue and 13th Street.

Walking and Biking

- Bicycle infrastructure: more bikes = less traffic
- I am concerned about the street near me - a neighbor uses a scooter to get around + the street is uneven + I hope that condition doesn't tip him over (No Sidewalk)
- I honestly think the City should focus on making Ames more bike friendly to allow for safe commute options for people within the city that want to bike everywhere. It shouldn't just be on campus that is bike-friendly, it should be at least 70% of the town. I think a lot more people would be inclined to go out and do public events if there was an option between public transit and walking everywhere. It would also be more eco-friendly so please put in more bike paths in the city.
- Making the city more walkable and less dependent on cars

Vehicular Traffic

- Finding a way to make Duff more enjoyable for drivers.
- Getting thru Ames sucks. We need a NW beltway
- Left turn arrows at Grand/13th St. intersection
- They added a Left turn arrow on 16th and Grand which has been AWESOME, and my next suggestion is putting a Left turn arrow for 13th and Grand because when on 13th St. turning Left onto Grand is very slow and often dangerous and would benefit greatly.

Another popular topic was business and development; some respondents desired attracting or developing more businesses and food options. Others focused more on physical development such as housing developments or commercial developments on Lincoln Way and Duff Avenue.

- Lincoln Way & Duff need serious improvements, stop building apartments, hold developers and rental companies to high standards
- Developing a livelier main street. This means more apartments and townhouse in town, not at the edge.
- Finishing the Lincoln Way build out of empty lots west of Duff - Ugly & depressing looking!
- Promoting more local, unique shopping & dining options in Ames. With Jax closing I'll have to go to DM to shop. A consolidated fitness facility instead of pieces all over town

- Stupid growth. Quit developing Duff! Finish Main St area project that hasn't ever really started.

Many respondents voiced their concerns regarding homelessness, services for the unhoused, crime, housing issues, and the cost of living. Some of these comments tended to talk about several of these, due to the relation to the challenges.

- Homelessness- compassionate housing
- Long term approach for our growing # of homeless in Ames. Emphasis on Long term!
- Low-income housing that isn't apartments.
- Affordable home buying programs for low/med income earners that make too much for habitat but can't afford a decent home for their families.
- We have had an increased issue with gun violence in Ames + West Ames in particular. Crime in general seems to have increased since we moved here 14 yrs. ago. We need to find ways to ensure that Ames is a safe place to live.

Several comments desired a focus on improved city relations and communication with residents, ISU, and other entities. Another topic was taxes and public spending, which tended to talk about reducing them.

- Better coordination with county, city, and ISU - i.e. swimming pool and other community projects for everyone, leverage our tax dollars
- I commented on design review for a city street project. The council rep said, "thank you" But there was no response from city staff. → Very disappointing!
- Listening to the 80% of the public and not the 20% that scream + holler.
- Iowa property taxes or freeze them for retired citizens. Even Illinois does this. The city doesn't want retired citizens to live here.

Waste disposal and sustainability efforts were talked about several times by respondents. There were mentions of more focus on several aspects of sustainability and conservation. With waste disposal, some respondents talked about improving waste disposal services and dealing with littering.

- Free city-wide recycling at your door
- City-wide yard waste & junk removal pick-up days. Many don't have the proper vehicles to haul; they can’t take advantage of the days
- I believe that the city should focus on trash pickup in main areas; I see so much trash on the sides of roads and in the grass.
- Sustainability and green theories throughout the city. Education on waste effects and the impact that it can have on our children's generation.
- Moving farm fields away from waterways & implementing prairie strips & supporting no till Ag practices/more diversified crops
- More recycling/compost drop off locations, more climate change planning

Recreation and events as well as services, facilities, and utilities were topics that respondents want addressed by the city. A few examples are:

- Easier booking of recreational services (rec classes/pickleball courts)
- Give more social options for young adults in the community to keep them from moving away.
- Getting fluoride out of the drinking water
- They should bury more of the residential lines so the storms will not affect the house. Keep replacing the water pipes Keep up with maintenance

A few respondents focused on issues regarding streets and transportation such as parking, street maintenance, ice and snow, and transit.

- Get rid of parking meters throughout the city.
- Potholes
- Preschool busing. The only preschool option for those who need to utilize buses is Northwood. Would be awesome to extend the option to other schools.
- Snow removal from roads often comes at the expense of bike lanes, which are impossible to use in the winter. Bike commuting can happen year-round!

Figure 28. Other Issues the City Should Focus On

Sustainability

This is the second year the survey included as a section about respondents' knowledge, views, and priorities regarding the city's Climate Action Plan (CAP) and environmental sustainability actions and goals. Over the past six years, the City of Ames has been working to make the community more sustainable for future generations. First there was a data collection phase in which the city hired a firm to conduct a series of assessments on energy use and other baseline data. A CAP team was formed from citizens to represent and gather input from different groups across Ames. Then a CAP was created to develop climate action steps to move the community toward reducing carbon emissions and climate neutrality. The CAP was accepted by the Ames City Council in 2023.

To review the adopted plan, visit the following website:

www.cityofames.org/Resident-Services/Sustainability/Climate-Action-Plan-Dashboard

The first question in this section asked respondents if they were familiar with the City's CAP. Of the 396 people who responded to this question, 64 respondents (16%) said "Yes" they were familiar with the plan. This is slightly higher than last year (13%). The majority (84%) responded "No," they were unfamiliar with the CAP.

Next respondents were asked to select their top three climate action steps for Ames from a list of eight choices which included an open-ended "Other" category.

Most respondents agreed on the importance of two climate action priorities with "Waste-to-energy improvements/reducing waste emissions" receiving 273 responses (70%) and "Increase wind and solar generation as part of Ames Electric Services portfolio" receiving 258 responses (70%). The trend is almost the same as the previous year (2024). (Table 31).

The next group of priorities did not receive as much consensus. Most people felt the City should prioritize retrofitting existing buildings (35%) followed by net-zero (NZR) new construction (32%) and then retrofit municipal/City buildings (23%). Other climate action steps include electrifying the municipal fleet (non CyRide) (16%); and creating a Mayor's climate action plan leadership task force (14%). Additionally, 31 respondents provided other open-ended responses.

Table 31. Top Climate Action Steps for Ames, 2024, 2025

Climate Action Steps	*2024* (n=355)	*2025* (n=372)
	Percent (%)	
Waste-to-energy improvements/reducing waste emissions	**70**	**73**
Increase wind and solar generation as part of Electric Services renewable energy portfolio	**69**	**70**
Retrofitting existing buildings	**41**	**35**
Net zero and net zero-ready (NZR) new construction	34	32
Retrofit municipal/City buildings	24	23
Electrify the municipal fleet (non CyRide)	18	16
Create a Mayor's climate action plan leadership task force	15	14
Other	10	8

The "Other" suggestions for important climate actions included negative views toward the Climate Action Plan and concerns about the costs of these activities. There were seven responses. These comments included, "do not use any funds for this," "this is a wasteful use of money," "Last thing we need!" "Most of these are a complete waste of money and don't move the needle while making things more expensive. Wind doesn't work. Solar comes with many other impacts."

The remainder of the "other" comments were individual suggestions; a complete list of all the comments can be found in the appendix. Several were related to recycling, nuclear power, stormwater pollution, fostering and facilitating local climate research with ISU.

The last question in this survey section asked respondents to identify the biggest reason to commit to environmental sustainability. Four answers and a fifth "Other" open-ended response were provided. Table 32 summarizes the survey results.

Most respondents (63%) chose providing a sustainable environment for future generations as their biggest reason for having a commitment to environmental sustainability. Fourteen respondents (4%) indicated that environmental sustainability was not important to them.

"Other" comments were mainly divided mainly between three types of comments: a) responses in which respondents further defined their personal motivation for sustainability; b) remarks that expressed concern or skepticism over the focus on sustainability; and c) general comments.

Table 32. Biggest Reason to Commit to Environmental Sustainability, 2025

Reasons	Number of Responses (n=384)	Percent (%)
To provide a sustainable environment for future generations	242	63
For a better quality of life	69	18
To stabilize or reduce the cost of food and utilities, etc.	45	12
Environmental sustainability isn't important to me	14	4
Other	14	4

Among those with additional personal motivations, two respondents shared that they would like to see a commitment statement that was broader than just humans, including protecting and preserving plants, animals, nature, and natural resources. A third person felt that all three options provided were essential reasons for commitment to sustainability. Another person commented, "It is a balance of everyone doing their part to avoid climate change, and increased reliance on domestic energy sourcing."

There was a group of respondents who shared skepticism about the need (continue status quo) for sustainable action steps: "it's a scam" and "markets & legislature don't throw money at it."

Additional "Other" comments pointed towards the need for community sustainability: "Better quality & sustainable life now, & for future generations," "education," "I like fishing," "lower pollution," "to prevent an environmental apocalypse," and "we owe it to the earth - it's alive, too."

General/Additional Comments

Respondents were asked to provide any additional comments that they wished to share. Ninety-one (91) respondents answered this question. Comments revolved around positives about Ames and the Ames government, housing costs, roads and traffic, planning and development, critiques of the Ames government, comments on the survey, community programming and events, attracting businesses, infrastructure, homelessness, waste disposal and recycling, walking and biking, taxes, trees and green spaces, safety, city vehicles, and other miscellaneous topics.

Lots of comments were positive, both talking about Ames overall and city government and leadership. Examples of the positive comments include:

- Ames is a wonderful place to live and work! Thank you for all you do to make Ames a great community!
- I lived in a suburb of Chicago, in the city of Chicago, and in Story City, Iowa, before moving to Ames. In Ames, I found my nirvana. I feel very fortunate to have the opportunity to live in Ames and am hopeful that it will be my home forever. Thank you for all that you do!
- I moved to town last winter and so far am impressed with the intentionality & investment in the community (including this survey)! It feels like a very caring place.
- I wish to thank city staff and all city employees for their good work and for keeping this a good place to live
- One of the things I like most about Ames is all the ways it works to provide safety and stability, through cleanliness and constantly working to improve 'conditions' with inclusivity on the forefront.
- We love Ames. It is a very quiet, safe place. Great for raising kids and working. Not a lot of crime and no bad part of town. I feel safe anywhere in town. Love It.

Within the topics of housing, homelessness, planning and development, roads and traffic, attracting businesses, and infrastructure, these are a few examples of comments about improvements or critiques:

- Ames doesn't seem to attract a lot of new diverse types of business whether it be shopping or food. I'm not sure what can be done but the same group of people own the three or four local restaurants. We can't seem to attract any great restaurants. Lots of people go to Des Moines. Our grocery stores are lacking. It's either HyVee, Fareway (both companies I don't want to support) or Wheatsfield which is terribly expensive. Something like Trader Joes would be great. We don't attract a lot of clothing aside from chain stores. Just would be nice to get new businesses and not a bunch of part stores, Mexican food, and chain clothing stores.
- Big developers have way too much sway in this town. I don't think it’s a secret who they are
- I moved to Ames for clerical work at ISU in 1976. It was unaffordable then and still is. There's talk but no action to make affordable housing. Once you reach about age 25 you don't want roommates anymore. And then you realize how ownership is not a possibility. Ames needs to look at Ankeny for town home developments and ways to make them

affordable for builders and price them so lower to middle income ranges can own a home."

- It would be nice to keep the small university town feeling. Less construction of tall buildings. The downtown hotel would look "out of place" Also, CyTown will take away the ISU "campus feeling." It would be nice to make Ames more pedestrian friendly.
- It is distressing to see the homeless population increasing, and to see the public library and the old town areas being treated as "logical" places for them. The City of Ames needs to do a better job of serving the needs of all its inhabitants, and not just by creating a ghetto of the older parts of town for the needy.
- There is a lot of focus on expanding the city to the west through new construction, but not enough attention on the stormwater issues this creates downstream. New homes restrict the ability of the watershed to absorb water, and this leads to more water in the creeks. The creeks are essentially like "utility infrastructure" in a sense, so they need to be maintained better. Right now, the burden is being pushed onto property owners downstream! This leads to flooding.
- Housing prices are out of control. Affordable rent should be a huge push for anybody allowed to build rentals in Ames. $2k/month for a 3 bedroom is insane. Those landlords should be evicted from town unless they agree to lower rent prices.

Here are a few examples of the other miscellaneous topics mentioned:

- When can we get one brand of garbage truck in my block instead of five? Tears up the street, dirties the air, and makes us have trucks come one more day of the week. Please solve this and not just think about it.
- You've got to do something to ensure senior citizens can continue to be able to live here. Property taxes are rolling everyone - I understand - but hit retired fixed income people the hardest.
- The climate action plan is a ridiculous use of time and resources. We should not be investing in solar panels. If you are north of a latitude of Oklahoma they are not nearly as effective. Hard to believe they will offset carbon impact of their supply chain construction and installation.
- Please add proposed zoning change information more prominently on websites. It is very hard to find in meeting minutes.
- I think Ames is a great place to live but it is costly. I'm lucky to be able to afford to live here. Property taxes (+ home values) are high + discouraging to young families. I try to contribute to assisting library, Bridge Home, food bank, police funds etc., and plan to do more for animal shelter this year. There is a lot of private wealth in Ames that should be carrying more of the cost of arts, recreation, and extra-curricular public services. This survey is too long.
- I really like this town, and I wish more people felt the same way. I can't blame them though, the number of poor experiences I've had with city officials over the years is very discouraging. I get that a lot of students come and go, but they're still residents and many of them are looking to stay after graduation. They might if they were treated well their first 4 years here.
- I don't and won't use social media for information – the systems are too unsecured. I value our healthcare system in partnership with the City of Ames. Glad we have municipal electric services. Consider partnerships w/ ISU + Story Co. for expanded naturalized trails and connecting what ISU students want from community to make Ames a better place for them, or student recruitment as they contribute to property taxes through rentals.

- I appreciate the resources the library offers, but I've personally felt uncomfortable bringing my children to the library. There tends to be a crowd around and inside the library that creates an environment I don't always feel is safe or family friendly. Additionally, I've noticed a strong emphasis on certain political viewpoints, which feels unbalanced for a public institution meant to serve a diverse community. I hope the library can work toward creating a more welcoming and neutral space for all patrons.
- Thank you for this opportunity to share my opinions. I had no idea this program existed. You should publicize it so that even people who are not selected to participate are given that opportunity.

For other details on the additional comments, see appendix.

Figure 28. Additional Comments

APPENDIX 2025

Comments on Funding Allocation to Programs and Services

Don't know

- Don't Know
- I do not know. I am not informed enough to be able to offer a useful opinion.
- I don't have enough information to know the status of each.
- I don't really know much about funding
- I feel unqualified to answer funding allocation questions. I don't know enough. I also felt the questions were unfair by listing actual dollars instead of percentage of budget. I have no direct personal frame of reference to understand $12 million as anything other than more-money-than-I-understand.
- I'm not familiar enough to comment on it.
- This is hard since I don't know what these services need
- This is hard to answer without further context about why or how more funds would be used, or how less would impact current services.
- This is hard to evaluate without knowing budgets
- Without more info I am not qualified to answer
- You must include more information
- I don't care what you send your money on …
- I don't have enough information to make informed comments, but the budget seems a little high for a city this size.
- N/A (x6)

Transportation

- On Stange and Aspen, it is a business area. When we moved here 5 yrs ago my husband was almost killed. There are white lines on street flashing speed signs, it does nothing for slowing traffic! I reported this also to the city.
- Roads could be better.
- More public transport and better walkable city planning.
- Fixing those traffic lights that are unevenly timed.
- I appreciate the efforts to expand bicycling facilities and aquatic/swimming facilities. Time is still needed to see the results.

Arts

- Arts create vibrant community, a sense of safety and place - outcomes are increased quality of life, and business, tourism!
- I am part of a community group that benefits from COTA. Arts are so important!
- Public arts and education programs.
- The library has huge endowment base already for arts and recreation. Should do more to

solicit donations to further their programs.

Parks and Conservation

- It would be nice to have accountability for park projects – the ice ribbon taking too long! Needs to have beautification as it's a bit of an eyesore!
- Preservation of our green space.
- Stop using pesticides and replace natural pest reduction techniques. Enforce on local farms, runoff reduction. Stop chemtrails from flying over Ames.
- Street tree plantings along roadways 1. Construction, 2. Reconstruction, 3. Bike trails, 4. Where there are none, 5. Storm water/naturalized area along public row. Note: Trees were planted on Grand Ave. but were so small and not cared for that several have died.

Satisfied

- I know funding is hard based on what Ames receives from the state, but they do a great job allocating it!
- I think it is important to fund certain aspects of the city so just continuing to use the tax dollars to give back to the residents.
- I am pretty satisfied with things the way they are. We have only lived in Ames for 5 years, but we love it here!

Police

- I made my comments on the police department before I saw these dollar amounts. It seems quite evident that a disproportionate amount is spent on law enforcement.
- Ames police don't need all that money - give it to better things.
- Take a moment and think about what the police budget is and what it's actually doing.
- When I say less for law enforcement, I only mean 2 million less. (10,082,884.)
- We spend $12 million a year on our APD LEOs, and can't they even be bothered to avoid hitting pedestrians?
- More assistance with mental health issues for police.

Services and Utilities

- Provide more frequent "Free yard waste days" - (2/month), more recycling centers throughout the city, more efficient hazardous waste material disposal, and make it easier especially for home living seniors.
- More drinking supplies and public bathrooms. Clean water to drink, with pressure and no bad odor or rust.
- The city should beef up basic services - fire, police, water, streets, etc.

Homelessness

- I travel (the US) by Amtrak and see a lot of homelessness. We need to ensure we have cheap housing to prevent it happening here. I support that move. We need more funding for homelessness.
- If possible, please allocate more funding towards programs that will help address the

rising rate of homelessness and helping people affected by this.

Miscellaneous

- I think you should define COTA and ASSET for people taking this survey.
- Land use planning appears to result in destroying the older neighborhoods of Ames and treating them as dumping ground rather than valued areas.
- Whatever is needed (for safety).
- I would be willing to pay more taxes for increased budgets in these areas, and others if needed.
- Animal shelter may need extra transition funding and then hope to level off after the move.

Comments on City of Ames Services

Satisfied

- Again, my use/lack of use in many of these areas makes this difficult to answer but speaking to others I believe our services are well thought out and positive through Ames.
- Continue, and do your best as they always do.
- Generally good.
- Generally, I believe Ames is a very good town to raise a family. I also know of some retired people who came back after retirement.
- I am proud to live in Ames. Ames is a great place to live and work! All my encounters with the City of Ames services have been positive.
- I have lived in Ames for 60 years and I am happy that we have quality services.
- I haven't used all these services, but I haven't heard friends or family complain about any of these.
- In general, Ames provides excellent services.
- Outstanding!
- Y'all are doing great!
- Think we enjoy living in Ames because the city takes care of us citizens.
- Overall, I am happy to live in Ames!

Property and Housing Enforcement

- How is residential lack of yard upkeep being monitored and addressed?
- I think Ames does a wonderful job, but I do wish they'd pay more attention to vacant houses and overgrown lawns.
- Rental properties are very rough looking. Especially on Lincoln Way.
- Nuisance and rental enforcement need to be overhauled if no proactive measures are implemented.
- There are some areas that I've noticed with a lot of trash (cans, bottles, plastic bags). For example, the empty lot between Target and Walmart, and the ditch in the south side of Lincoln way west of North Dakota. I am unsure who is responsible for the cleaning of this.
- The way rental properties have all sync with their leases is unbelievable. Leaving some people homeless for several days. This should be addressed by the City Hall at some point.

Police/Emergency Services

- Glad to hear about the addition of another fire station and moving one out of campus town congestion. Ames is growing and sprawling- obviously putting pressure on services.
- I would like to see the city put more of our money into police and fire.
- Need to expand the law enforcement force.
- Services are good except for APD and the protection of living standards.
- N/A (x6)

Streets and Traffic

- Always have and always should be that way. Traffic with poor traffic management is a huge problem. Constant construction on roads is a huge problem.
- I don't like how we switched from four-lane roads to two to accommodate a bike line, because so few cyclists utilize them. 16th and Duff streets are a nightmare, I go through it multiple times a day, and in all these years I've only seen 3-5 cyclists.
- I would love more accommodation for bikes, scooters, skateboards, etc. on the road. I almost got hit twice coming to school today, and that's a daily occurrence.
- One thing that could be improved is road construction. I think if they chose to re-construct roads during the summer, it would be more beneficial. It causes so much traffic.

Water

- We drink bottled water in our home.
- Last evening the water was shut off to replace a valve. It would have been nice to know beforehand.
- It would be nice if there could be a grey water system to use for outside watering so we would not be using drinking water on the grass (new) and new trees. In general, I do not irrigate.

CyRide

- CyRide buses that reach far west Ames (especially purple) should offer a wider variety of times in the middle of the day.
- Glad for noise enforcement CyRide if needed!
- There should be a way to indicate what bus stops are also break spots for drivers.

Bike paths

- The neighborhood park is maintained (and constructed) w/ HOA dues. The (pedestrian) bike path is not maintained in the winter and it should be.
- We could use more paved bike trails.

Miscellaneous

- I have tried for several years to get a garden spot for the summertime, and I was never able to do it. It would be nice to have more community gardens across the city.
- Parks and Rec. swim lessons fill quickly. Sometimes it is hard to get a spot.
- Dog barking: have talked to them and it’s better, but now we don't visit them. Also, plenty of dogs barking in our neighborhood. In which they shouldn't even have a dog or two
- Everything is great, the only thing is possibly renovating the website to be more user friendly.
- A public library should be a place that the community uses for meetings and events and most importantly it should encourage learning and education. It should not be a center for promoting political and cultural ideologies.
- Very concerned about people sleeping in public spaces and the safety issues that it brings.

Comments on Police Department Activities

Satisfied

- Keep up the great work! Thank you for all that you do for the community!
- Does a great job!
- I have had an emergency 3 1/2 years ago. The response was good. The department was very helpful and compassionate.
- I view our Police as protections of our social order. They do it well in Ames
- I'm very thankful for the professional and high-quality police force in Ames.
- It's a good sector.
- My experience with the Ames Police Dept. about 3 years ago when I was the victim of credit card scam was wonderful; they helped me very much.
- My few interactions have been very positive.
- No interaction with police services for many years, yet I am very grateful for their services and professionalism.
- No issues. They are nice and helpful.
- Officer was very helpful when I woke up in ER after being hit by a car.
- Thank you for installing stop signs on E. 14th St when 16th St. was under construction. Much safer!
- Thank you for keeping our community safe!
- The few times I have had contact with them have been pleasant and helpful.
- The interactions I have had in my place of employment have been positive.
- The officers at the Trinity Church Trunk or Treat were very pleasant
- They are very good! The Facebook page is very helpful with timely information.
- They deserve every nickel they earn. They do a remarkable job
- They have always been helpful when needed (thankfully not often) and provide reasonable interactions.
- I am very satisfied with community and business involvement.
- We back the blue in this house.
- We have a great police department, even if I get stopped.
- While I do not know the officers personally, I have been consistently impressed by the professionalism and presence of the Ames Police Department. Their work helps maintain a strong sense of safety and order in our community. I appreciate their service and the role they play in keeping Ames a secure and livable city.
- I enjoy the APD's Facebook posts.
- I've seen more in my area doing patrol stops I'm assuming for speeding and in the past for drug busts I've heard about for college dorms. I'm glad they're enforcing the local laws and even handling the college issues.
- Citizen Police Academy is an excellent program.
- I know this is mostly ISU PD and not Ames as much, but I do appreciate how on days like 801 or on ISU football game days, the police in Ames all around seem to focus more on getting people home safely and preventing conflicts rather than busting people for underage drinking/parties/etc.; it makes us feel far safer (for the record I am 22 but it's still nice to see for others).

- I appreciate the outreach activities and donate to Shop with a Cop yearly. Unfortunately, I am not aware of most of the other activities mentioned.
- Ames' animal control is a valuable resource to our community.

More Traffic Enforcement

- Speeding on Lincoln Way, South 4th, South 16th between University and Duff, and Mortenson needs to be cracked down on while ISU students are here.
- Give more speeding tickets.
- I have observed serious issues with people running red lights throughout Ames, but especially on Lincoln Way around ISU. As a high pedestrian stretch of road, I look to the Ames Police Department to do more to reduce reckless driving behavior in this part of town.
- I wish that speed limits were more widely enforced, especially on Grand, 13th, Lincoln Way, and Stange
- Too much speeding on residential streets, including our street, Ash Ave. There is little or no enforcement of speed limit. Otherwise, good service!
- We live by an apartment complex and when calling in parking violators, police don't seem to care. They never get ticketed!
- Traffic enforcement at known high speed residential and at all-way stops will stop many "roll throughs."
- Traffic light enforcement is #1. What's the use of posting speed limit signs if 99% of drivers ignore them. People are driving way above the speed limits everywhere in town.
- Residential patrolling because there is sometimes noise pollution due to excessively loud vehicles and street racing near the high school and along 13th near Furman.
- People who park in handicapped places at the public library and leave when cops come because they have no permit.

More Drug Enforcement

- A lot of the students in the dorms and apartments still smoke and do drugs. Action taken in this regard would be appreciated.
- Many people in my apartment building smoke weed. It isn't allowed and the landlord can't do much. When cops are called, they also don't do anything. It fumes up through our vents making my place smell.
- Something not asked in the last question was drug enforcement. I think that aggressive outreach, enforcement, and follow up especially with underage users and ISU is essential. More important than anything else.

Better Training

- The City needs to provide continued support to the police department in working with mental health issues.
- My highest priority for Ames PD is anti-bias training, specifically with regards to mental health and LGBTQ+ individuals
- De-escalation training.
- I'd appreciate it if the City could empower the Police Department more to deal with the homeless population in east Ames.
- Community policing (I think it's called). Training in sensitivity and profiling. I don't think I

have seen any foot/cycle/horse patrols anywhere outside of a special city event.

Bad Interactions

- Mixed experiences depending on which officers respond. I had a weird interaction with an officer re: parking ticket. I wanted to take it and leave but he wanted me to answer a trivia question. Felt very condescending and kind of creepy (I am female).
- The difference between ISU PD and APD is astonishing. APD is wildly unprofessional and willfully negligent in their driving behaviors. They need training in professionalism and a lesson in accountability. I trust ISU PD. APD has lost all respect and trust in my household.
- Officer involved in a case for us was rude and refused to get back to us. He may have even lied about not receiving camera footage, since the business claimed they sent it. Verified his name. Maybe some customer service training.
- Most officers I've interacted with are very professional and community focused. Occasionally, I have interacted with someone whose biases are showing in their interactions. Not unprofessional, but a little concerning.
- Called police about a sick wild animal. They told me to contact animal control. They wouldn't transfer the call for one. Not Happy!

More Public Safety

- Focus on public safety.
- Expand the police force to enable more community safety programming.
- I think they should focus less on parking issues and more on the safety of the town.

Over Policing

- I think they focus too much on petty stuff honestly sometimes, but way better than ISU police.
- It seems the P.D. is very large - a disproportionate amount of money is spent on it. I can't believe the number of P.D. vehicles at the lot by the station. I once saw assault rifles being unpacked outside the station. Do we really need so many weapons in what seems like a safe city? Of course, safety is important, but do we need so many police?
- Their parking enforcement is unjust and incredibly overbearing. I've been ticketed for being even slightly over a yellow curb.
- They prey on college kids to give as many parking tickets as possible. My roommate has gotten 3 parking tickets because one of his tires was off the driveway.
- I think that more positive outreach would be more beneficial than more enforcement.

Gun Violence

- I'm very concerned about the current "carrying" laws and young people here. Mix in booze, competitive events, etc. and trouble will follow.
- One of my biggest concerns in the US is the potential risk of an encounter of an active shooter to any member of my family and friends. Unfortunately, I don’t know what I can do to help mitigate this problem.
- There really aren't any rules about active shooters or what to do in the heavily populated campus so I think it would be beneficial if there was an email with information.

More/Continued Funding

- Keep it growing. Retain them and make sure your salary schedule is in line with the area. Make sure they are funded fully with the best equipment.
- We have an outstanding police department who go way above and beyond with all that they do. They are transparent and have many outreach events. I just wish there were more of them.

Miscellaneous

- Got any fun surplus for sale?
- I feel perfectly safe in my community.
- I just hope they know where their priorities lie, especially in times like these.
- I wish there was less drunk driving but don't want more people to be arrested for it.
- It seems like there is always a very large amount of police vehicles parked at the police station- sometimes more than 10.
- I've been involved in check theft, online scam.
- Haven't had any need.
- We haven't had any interaction.
- Is parking meter cost effective? After purchasing, installation, collections and monitoring, how much does the city gain?
- Community mental health options.
- The police department should electrify its vehicle fleet.
- Ames PD seems better than ISUPD, but I've not interacted much with either. I'd say prioritize fast response time over making traffic stops.

Comments on Fire Department

Satisfied

- Fast Response Time
  - Around November 2024, about four fires (or at least some form of fire alarm activation) happened in my residence hall. The Fire Department arrived quickly and dealt with the issues rather quickly.
  - Fast response when someone sets off the building alarms.
  - I have used city ambulances a couple times and response times are mostly very good.
  - I luckily have not had to deal with this much but one time there was a fire in my apartment complex they got there quick and had little damage.
  - They get to dorm fire alarms quick which is nice :)
  - Their response was excellent when a car ran into our house.
- Good Outreach
  - I love their open house events.
  - Loved the Fire Safety event put on by the Fire Department for the community. My child was very engaged and learned a lot!
  - Luckily only know them from outreach events like firehouse tours, but they were so kind to kids.
  - Thankfully, I have not had to have the fire dep. come to my house. I have taken my grandkids to open house and educational events at the fire station and they loved shooting the hoses and climbing in the fire trucks. The fire people around here seem nice!
  - The firefighters at the trunk or treat event were great with the kids.
  - Great interactions with youth.
- General
  - They were responsive and helpful with my application to burn a small prairie area on my property.
  - As an RA at Iowa State, I find the fire department SUPER helpful and great to work with!
  - Good Job.
  - The fire inspector was exceptionally helpful with our church.
  - The Ames Fire Department consistently delivers outstanding service. The leadership—Chief and his deputy chief set a strong example through their professionalism, responsiveness, and accessibility. The firefighters themselves are reliable, respectful, and bring a sense of calm competence to every interaction. This is a well-leading and well-supported department.
  - Thank you for all that you do!
  - My experiences have been perfect.
  - Great professional fire department.
  - I love the Fire Department.
  - It's a very active and helpful sector that is fulfilling their duties.
  - Keep on going well.

- I have only really used them for medical emergencies and CPR training, but I am very satisfied with both.
- Only called for a carbon monoxide alarm and they were very kind as it was only a battery going out.
- Thank you for all that you do for our community!
- Thankfully have not needed these services, yet grateful for their education and protection.
- Have not had to call the fire department but I bet they'd do a great job.
- I have never had to use Fire Dept. services, but my sense is that they are very good.
- Never had to use so far, but feel Ames has a real sound fire dept.
- I have seen them out doing things and they are nice when I have seen them at other things.
- Good to hear that the campus station is moving to west part of Ames.

Haven't Used

- Fortunately, I didn't need their services.
- Fortunately, I haven't used the fire department.
- Fortunately, we've never needed to call them!
- Haven't had to use their services.
- Haven't had to use. I hear sirens so am assuming their response time is adequate.
- I am fortunate to have never needed the fire department service in the 47 years I have lived in Ames.
- I haven't had any experience with the fire department.
- I thankfully have not had to call or use the fire department.
- I've never encountered the fire department in action
- I've seen them around but have not personally had to deal with them or heard from them at all.
- Luckily, I didn't need their services.
- Thankfully, I have never needed this service.
- Thankfully, they never needed them for a real emergency.
- Thankfully I haven't had to experience this.
- Thankful to have never needed them!
- Never interacted (x4)
- I'm not familiar with programs they offer.
- Not very familiar with this.
- Very limited interaction with the Fire Department.
- Have never called
- Can't judge

More Outreach

- I would like to see more promotion for the fire and EMS here in Ames not such during fire

prevention week.

- Haven't seen fire prevention activities and outreach
- See Fire Department staff at grocery store. This could be an opportunity for outreach.
- There are outreach activities.

More Stations

- Relocation of fire station #2 is badly needed. A fourth station in northern Ames would be great.
- I don't think there are enough fire stations for the size of our city. The amount of time it would take to get to certain parts of the city is concerning. My family is very satisfied with the firefighters that serve this community.

Comments on City Electric Service

Satisfied

- Have always been a great service, they just helped me last night.
- Have no complaints.
- I haven't had any issues with Ames Electric. And they are reliable.
- I love Ames Electric Services and its solar initiative!
- I was very impressed with the customer service when setting it up for the first time.
- Never had to call. Very good as we've been here around 11 years.
- No issues.
- Overall excellent
- Overall good service (x2)
- So far so good!
- The city does good work.
- They do very well with communicating to their users on what is going on and the solution they are taking.
- I think it is being managed very well. Quality of service is very good.
- I was very impressed with the quick response to an outage on a Sunday morning. Power restored in about an hour and further repairs done later for long term repair.
- We are so fortunate to have such a responsive crew. They are highly effective often in very poor weather conditions. Thank you :)
- I really appreciate the approach in Ames to efficient lighting! Dark sky fixtures and adding solar. You folks are the best!!!
- The monthly newsletter is a great source of information.
- Love the electric price in Ames. I just hope they can meet the power demand in the next 30 years. I found out that over 10 years the power pack was too expensive for me.
- Only one time was my electric meter misread, and I think the person on the phone handled it well.

SunSmart

- Positives
  - This is so cool!
  - SunSmart Ames is such a cool project, and if I were in town long-term, I would absolutely participate.
  - Sounds like a great plan
  - Should offer this to apartment owners.
  - Should allow residents to purchase as many shares as they would like.
  - Seems like a good opportunity.
  - If I was younger I would.
  - I won't be here long enough to participate but it sounds beneficial!
  - I would participate in SunSmart Ames if I knew I'd be staying here after college! That is a wonderful program.
  - We are participating via our church.

- Improve SunSmart
  - [SunSmart] Seems somewhat expensive.
  - Since we purchased two at $300 each, maybe consider giving us 3rd at half price.
  - How well is it [SunSmart] performing? Newsletter?

More Renewable

- Ames should do more to encourage solar energy such as buying solar energy at a better price.
- I would like to see solar become a larger part of electricity generation in Ames.
- I want more community solar.
- Continue increasing the renewable energy in the area, though could we find a clean thing to mix with the garbage, like bio diesel from algae or hydrogen in the power plant?

Complaints

- I rent and my landlord couldn't care less. My utility bill is high because they pass the heating expenses on to their tenants.
- Renewable energy initiations allow people to feel better about themselves while the only actual "real" result they produce is increasing the cost of energy rates.
- When I first bought my Ames home, I was auto enrolled in the program where Ames can control your AC, but I knew nothing about it. Come summer my AC was switching off and it took me a while to figure it out, and it was incredibly unsettling. I called and asked for it to be disconnected--and the tech even showed me when he came out that he was completely cutting the wires, which made me feel back in control, but I really wish I would've been asked vs. forced.
- Link is broken

Continue Incineration

- I hope City continues to provide electricity via trash incineration to reduce landfill issues, power has rarely failed here even when neighboring towns have outages.
- I know the upfront rehab cost is staggering, but I'd prefer to see us upgrade our trash incinerator (and I don't like the idea of trucking things to a landfill far away). It's a huge point of pride in our community for my demographic.

Comments on Drinking Water Service

Great Water

- Ames's water!
- Ames has great water! (x8)
- Ames has some of the best water. We are very satisfied with it.
- Ames has the best water. We get spoiled with how good it is.
- Ames's water is the best I've had out of anywhere I've lived
- Ames's water is the BEST!
- Ames's water tastes great, it's one of my favorite things about Ames
- Award winning water!! Hooray for Ames!
- Best tasting water anywhere!
- Best tasting water I have ever had
- Best water
- Delicious
- Excellent (x3)
- Excellent water quality in Ames.
- Good drinking water
- I drink the water here more often because it tastes better than other places I've been.
- I love Ames's water!
- LOVE Ames water! Great job!
- Love it!
- I love the quality of Ames drinking water.
- Love the water here.
- Perfect almost always
- The water is amazing here in Ames!
- They do great job with this
- Very happy with water in Ames
- Water in Ames tastes good
- It's the best in Iowa for a reason!
- It tastes very good
- Love the Ames water taste! There does tend to be too many calcium deposits in other water.
- I've had excellent drinking water services and delivery.
- Very good service and water
- The drinking water service is one of the best in the country, with no complaints.

Hard Water and Build-Up

- Ames's water is on the hard side, but good.
- I thought Ames's water was considered hard water, so I'm not sure what is meant by asking if we've had hard or soft water. Nor do I have any idea how I would know if it changed from one or the other (maybe if it was drastic), or if hard/soft is to be considered an aberration from "normal" (or "regular" or "neither-hard-nor-soft").

- Water is generally hard but not a major problem
- Water is hard and so I have residue buildup on faucets, sinks, etc. But it tastes great! So, I'll deal with the buildup. I do not want soft water.
- Water is really hard and builds up on our clothes. Still, we love the taste.
- orange discoloration in shower
- In the last five years, the water in our neighborhood runs reddish/brown more often. It leaves pinkish red stains in bathtub, sinks, washer, some clothes. It keeps getting worse over time. :(
- Notice iron bacteria around drain on occasion.
- We also get a lot of what appears to be calcium in our sinks, drains, etc.

Poor Quality

- Poor.
- Can be improved. And have it in more areas.
- I always have sediment in the bottom of my water bottle after filling from the tap
- I don't trust drinking water every day.
- I think I'm an outlier here, but I do not like the taste of Ames water. I can't drink it unless it's been iced.

Worried about Pollution

- I am concerned about nitrates and other pesticides. Perhaps more information can be shared in an accessible way.
- Although Ames has some of the best tap water/drinking water, I think it would be beneficial to test for PFAs and other potential contaminates on a regular basis at multiple locations around the city and make this data available for the public if it isn't already.
- Our water seems to have more rust here (south Ames) than anywhere I've lived in this town, and I've lived here 35 years.

No Issues

- No concerns
- No issues.
- I have no issues

Hydrant Flushing

- Significant rust after hydrant flushing; had to run enough water that it likely increased my monthly bill significantly.
- There was a lot of rust in March but no notification of possible hydrant flushing in the area. Discovered the rusty water after using it for laundry, cooking, and vaporizer. Never saw a hydrant flushing truck on my side of town, but I did see one downtown.
- Only had issues when flushing hydrants in area.
- Only when flush hydrant.

Temporary Issue

- The water didn't taste bad; it just tasted weird for a month.
- There was a day when we got an email that the tap water would be "dirty." That only lasted a couple days, to my knowledge.
- We just had very little to no water coming from the taps once and it was resolved within a day

- Only problems when water main breaks nearby.

Miscellaneous

- Ok-plus hope rates don't rise.
- If Ames is adding fluoride to our drinking water, you need to stop adding it to the water supply.
- Sometimes it burns my eyes.
- It’s getting pricey.
- Water main was repaired but water is still a little colored occasionally
- I drink all my water out of reverse osmosis and remineralization filter, so I don't know what tap is like.
- We have a water softener.

Comments on Water and Pollution Control

Stormwater Management and Sewers

- Could you get landlords to construct garages, so water flows out rather than in? They fail half the building inspections anyways, why not check the garages too?
- Better follow up and commitment to maintenance. Projects along 24th St. are a disappointment both in the Hayes-Hoover area and to the west near Kent St. Not sure the western site even collects or stores run off in a storm.
- Need to be more communicative about storm water issues and why we are increasing rates - benefits of stormwater projects for resilience, minimizing long term & immediate risks, cumulative impacts of system improvements- be more like the electrical services.
- Storm outlets just east of Wilder Blvd on Lincoln Way have trees, vegetation, and other debris restricting water flow.
- Stormwater backs up on driveway of alley. City did some mitigation years ago when it encroached on the garage. It is only a minor nuisance now
- In 2016 water came back into our yard from a culvert under entry street. I do have pictures. Evidently need bigger outlet from pond area.
- My back yard is next to a drainage area. I am used to occasional high-water runoffs.
- They came and power sprayed blockages from the sewer drains into our yard and sidewalk without removing the debris. Next time it rains hard again that debris will go right back into the sewer or be stuck in my yard.
- The city needs to pay more attention to creek erosion and the impact of urban expansion on stormwater drainage and creek levels.
- "Landlord made [tenant] aware" [of sewer and storm water backup] “See above comments. Think this is an ongoing issue."
- N/A (x5)
- No experience!
- Sorry, there is nothing city could do about this.
- None (x2)

Satisfied

- Huge compliments coming: In my second or third year as homeowner here, my sump pump was getting pushback when it tried to discharge. A plumber said there was nothing wrong with my pump, that the issue was the line. I went over to Public Works and someone talked to me and listened, and then a couple of guys came out to the house to check things out, and they were fantastic. They took their time to ask questions and watched the system, confirmed it was plumbed correctly and (most of all) were supportive of me as a new and younger homeowner. They found out the problem was several houses down with tree roots getting into the line; then they took the initiative to clear them out, and it ran fine again. They gave me an emergency workaround if it happened again so my basement wouldn't flood. I thought they went above and beyond, and it felt good
- I live in an apartment, so I have no issues.
- They are a helpful, vital resource!
- Great!
- Love Ames water. We have the expensive water "meter" for vegetation but water more

from other faucets
- Seems fine.
- Maybe there could be a way to encourage bidets.

Communication

- I am very dissatisfied with the lack of community input or notification about the work on new wells at the Carr Woods/East River Valley Park. Reflects poorly on the city at large.
- Great notification of hydrant flushing in my neighborhood.
- I didn't know we were supposed to report sewer backups.

Cost

- Everything is getting more expensive, and income is staying the same, it’s getting harder to pay bills.
- Water rates keep increasing!
- Seems odd to pay for an extra meter and pay monthly charge continually increasing rates. Should plan for ongoing maintenance/replacement.

Garden Watering

- I do like to water my trees and new plants in time of drought, so it is unfortunate we have to use expensive drinking water to do that.
- If you water garden or flowers, sewer rate is high
- Need a better way to offer "garden" watering separate from server.

Water Quality

- If question above is related to how clean the Skunk River is, I'm somewhat dissatisfied with that water quality. We still boat down it but know how contaminated it is.
- Iowa's cancer rates continue to rise. What can be done now to reduce these mortality rates? The DNR regularly reports wastewater spills. What can be done to protect our water quality safety and also reduce these spills?

Comments on Neighborhood Nuisance Enforcement

No Issues

- Have not had any interaction or difficulties with these issues.
- Haven't had to deal with it thus far.
- I've never submitted a report.
- I live in a well-maintained area of Ames... few if any students or poverty or overcrowding issues.
- My community is peaceful, friendly, and respectful.
- Our neighborhood is paradise.
- Resolved quickly with city judge, so I have none.
- They seem to be going fine, nothing needs to change
- The City of Ames app works great to report issues.
- Reporting app was very easy to use to report dumped furniture! Fast responses.
- I am glad the city has such ordinances and that they are enforced. None have been an issue yet where I live.
- Called the city about a neglected yard, they did what they could, and I was happy.
- Dog barking kept down.

Property Maintenance

- Yard upkeep. Property owners allowing lawns to overgrow or "crowd" sidewalks overhanging bushes and trees. Tree roots heaving sidewalks. Nothing is corrected.
- Weeds along Bloomington on private property.
- Some properties have overgrown vegetation obscuring traffic around corners.
- Have the new ordinances concerning yard upkeep been enforced?
- The apartment complex directly north of our property continues to accumulate garbage on our property. Their dumpster isn't adequately large enough for their residents, and residents continue to just throw garbage down the hill onto our property.
- Need to put some teeth behind the enforcement of poorly maintained properties with slum lords who can do so much better. Hope this changes or I will consider another. Never been impressed by the realtors, property mangers., etc., and landlords.
- Rental ordinance enforcement is nearly nonexistent. You should not rely on see-click-fix. Moving vegetation overgrowth, sidewalk shoveling are huge issues with rentals
- The appearance of rental properties on Lincoln Way is very poor.
- A house has been abandoned in our neighborhood for several years. Racoons and other animals are living inside it. City inspections have said they can't do anything about it.
- Complained about a neighborhood house falling apart. I was told unless they had thistles, they couldn’t do anything. House is still falling apart. Also complained re: dangerous sidewalk and within a year was fixed.
- I wish there were more proactive steps to reduce littering, and over occupancy in campus towns in peak party times of the year.

Poor Enforcement

- Did not continue or take further even though the issues did not stop.
- Police never came.
- Allow more reporting/enforcement of nuisances by police and other citizens and not just a neighbor. I have been driven by properties that are definitely trashy, overgrown yards and dilapidated and they remain so over several years.
- Somewhat satisfied. Dispatch was initially dismissive instead of listening to account.
- Reported one major 'Over Occupancy' and was ignored: no call back/no response.
- It's frustrating because I've had a report filed on me for overgrown weeds despite keeping my lawn very nice and tidy and taking extra care of the way my house looks. but yet my neighbor right next door has never had a complaint filed and for the entire year since they've moved in, they park cars and boats on their front yard, let their lawn grow insanely high in the summers, all their bushes/vegetation grows uncontrolled, and they leave waste and old tired and trash piled on the side of their driveway.

Noise

- I am not aware of noise limits - maybe people could stop lawn mowing and especially leaf blowing after a certain time.
- I didn't know a dog could bark from 9pm-5am without taking a break. City officials didn't seem to care and just "made a note of it".
- Barking dogs!!
- City and campus events appear to be completely exempt from noise ordinances- why is this allowed?
- Noise from loud music (college students)
- Noise limits are extremely high, especially for daytime but even nighttime limits are too lax.
- Only problem is fireworks around 4th of July
- FIREWORKS & PARTIES IN CAMPUSTOWN WHILE VISITING A FRIEND I DON'T EVEN CALL THESE THINGS IN ANYMORE.

Over Enforcement

- Overgrown lawns are such a pointless nuisance ordinance. Perfect 1950's-esque lawns are asinine in the first place. The city should not waste their time caring for what people do on their own property unless it poses an imminent hazard to other people.
- Probably gets a bit overdone here.
- You should not send fines to someone for having what someone would call a "junk car" in their yard.
- I'm not, nor ever will be, a fan of the "City of Ames HOA ordinance" that was recently passed. Someone's overgrown vegetation or old shed is not a nuisance to someone else.
- I've known people to be charged because the grass in their lawn was slightly too tall and fined even after shoveling their sidewalk to their best extent during the snowstorms these past years. It's a bit ridiculous.

- Why is it illegal to park on your own front lawn, when it is also illegal to park on the streets? The street parking in residential areas makes zero sense.

Parking and Junk Cars

- Cars parked too long on street.
- Parking
- Junk car/truck parked in front of residence never moves. Been an issue for 5yrs +. Called in - tires marked sticker notice. Move for a day or so & put it right back. The ordinance needs to change!

Miscellaneous

- Sick animal. I waited an hour and a half to get Animal Control here.
- Rent is too damn high.
- I think Ames does a good job at holding people accountable for trash in the yards or any nuisance items. I do think there should be a rule for people that have presidential signs up on houses when the voting season is over. If it is no longer voting season there should not be presidential signage or fandom signs allowed.
- I have reported a condo that has a severely bright roof, none of the other apartment buildings have lights like that. I have even called the company that owns it before I reported it to you. I asked her to be a good neighbor and tip the light down. She wasn't going to do anything; I talked to our HOA no change

Comments on Traffic Signals

Timing and Coordination

- I have never lived in a town with more stop light where the untimed light creates way too much traffic. These factors lead to an already taxed number of vehicles. Why??
- IT IS RARE THAT I CAN GET FROM ONE SIDE OF AMES TO THE OTHER WITHOUT HITTING EVERY POSSIBLE LIGHT.
- It seems like I'm spending more time waiting at red lights. It's especially frustrating when signals turn when there are no cars on the side street or in turn lanes. If the city is serious about reducing idling/emissions, they should invest in more efficient traffic signals.
- It would be great if signal lights, especially Lincoln Way and Grand Ave. were synchronized to get through most lights with no stops!
- Sometimes I'll sit at a traffic light for 5 min before it turns when there is zero traffic.
- There's coordination between traffic signals? I've lived in Ames for 28 years and frequently have cursed the complete lack of signal coordination like no other cities have! Exactly where is this alleged to exist?? Hard to believe this is even attempted.
- They seemed poorly timed and sometimes changed without being "tripped".
- Traffic Signals need better vehicle sensor programming.
- At times traffic signals are acceptable except late night and early morning when no other cars are around.
- Some should be timed.
- You always have to stop at traffic lights everywhere, particularly on Lincoln Way and Duff Ave. In Cedar Falls, we had roundabouts instead so rarely had to wait at traffic lights, and when I worked in downtown Waterloo, all the traffic signals were well-timed.
- I know they are coordinated but many times it doesn't seem that way. Strive for consistency in left turn signals ... they seem to differ in various areas.
- Some intersections the signal from yellow to red is very fast.
- No matter where I drive, I hit a lot of red lights. It's rare to get multiple greens.
- Traffic signals on (ineligible) do not seem properly coordinated. In fact, it almost seems to encourage you to drive 5+ mph over speed limit to hit multiple green lights.
- Intersection at 6th & Brookridge - when approaching north to cross 6th street over the rail tracks onto N. Hazel after the light will not change for a long time. No problems with the light changing coming from S, E & W.
- Seems I have to stop at every light.

13th and Grand Ave

- 13th & Grand needs traffic flow improvements ASAP.
- 13th and Grand are horrible as east/west don't have turning lanes.
- Turn lanes Grand and 13th terrible for turn lanes.
- Eastbound traffic on 13th St. at Grand Ave needs a turn arrow. Takes 3 light changes to turn left/north at busy times like 3 p.m. when school is getting out.
- I hear this is in the works already, but a solution to the traffic issues on 13th/Grand would

be appreciated. (Left Turns)

- PLEASE add a left turn arrow (on traffic light) at 13th and Grand intersection for cars facing east at that intersection. It basically becomes a one lane road, everyone traveling straight goes in the right lane and cars pile up in the left lane waiting to go left!
- There needs to be a left signal sign at the intersection of Grand Ave and 13th Street. The road is weirdly elevated, and it is difficult to see oncoming traffic when turning left, so a green arrow light would be very effective there.
- Put a left turn arrow on 13th + Grand eastbound.
- There needs to be a turn light at grand and 13th east/west.
- They added a Left turn arrow on 16th and Grand which has been AWESOME, and my next suggestion is putting a left turn arrow for 13th and Grand. When on 13th St, turning left onto Grand is very slow and often dangerous and would benefit greatly.
- We could really use a north/south turn signal for traffic at 13th and Grand.
- We really need a green arrow system on 13th and Grand. I'm afraid of turning to the left to get to North Grand Mall. It feels unsafe.
- I heard a rumor that there will be a roundabout put in at the intersection of Grand and 13th Street. If this happens, I think it would be dangerous and very ineffective. I think it would cause multiple moto-vehicle accidents.
- You need to install a green arrow on 13th and Grand.
- There needs to be a left turn arrow on 13th & Grand. Congestion has been compounded by closure of Stange.
- Results at Grand & 13th are too long- need a turning lane east/west.
- Sensory-traffic backups often Grand + 13th
- Inefficient lights at the light at 13th St and Grand Ave. People trying to turn left from 13th onto Grand during busy times create large traffic back-ups. The use of green arrows is highly necessary here.

Lincoln Way

- Need more green arrows on Lincoln Way.
- There are some lights notably on Lincoln Way which feel especially poorly timed and will have no traffic moving for extended periods of time.
- Too long of a wait to cross Lincoln Way at campus and too short of a green light at Campustown.
- Lincoln Way at times during the day, is impossible to drive through two green lights. I have to stop at every single traffic light due to lack of coordination
- There are major traffic light issues on Lincoln Way. If you hit one red light while driving through campus, you'll probably hit every subsequent light. It's a huge waste of time.
- The signal at Dakota Ave and Lincoln Way is ridiculously long if you’re going north/south. It needs to switch a lot faster. You can wait at that one light for 4-5 minutes.
- Sheldon intersection light timing does not work effectively. If you want to go North/South, you end up having to wait through multiple cycles of East/West without the North/South ever changing.
- The intersection of Lincoln Way and Sheldon is terrible, cars going north and south do not

have enough time to go before the light changes and it takes upwards of 60 seconds for the light to change even if there is no oncoming traffic from Lincoln Way.

- Please make the lights on Lincoln Way near ISU better. I hit every single red light every time.
- The light at the intersection of Lincoln Way and State Ave is dreadful when trying to turn left from State onto Lincoln. Whatever timer/weight-checking system the light is on is far too long. This also leads to an excessive wait time for pedestrians trying to cross Lincoln at this light.

Grand Ave

- Grand is terrible and I wish east and west were separate, but I know you all rush
- I often get stopped by red light repeatedly on Grand.
- Please consider the left turn lane at Grand & 20th!!
- Sometimes, the traffic signal at the intersection of Grand Ave and Bloomington Road in North Ames lags, especially the pedestrian walk signal. Authority should look into the matter.
- East & West bound 20th St green signal at Grand is too short, especially if there is a CyRide or Ames School District bus waiting to turn.
- 6th St & Grand- if you're on 6th St the light takes too long to switch.
- 6th + Grand signal needs to travel sooner when there is no traffic.
- Lights at 13th and 6th turning onto Grand can be very slow.
- A light I take issue with is at Grand and 16th. Trying to turn from 16th left onto Grand takes forever when it is busy. A higher chance for green arrows would be highly beneficial here. Currently, it only rarely gives a green left arrow.

No Issues

- Generally visible and they seem to work.
- I have not had any problems with traffic signals.
- I love that Ames has long yellow lights, it prevents accidents and allows safer left turns during busy traffic hours.
- Nice job.
- No issues.
- Not a big issue for me- seems to work well. Patience is a virtue ...
- They are very functional.
- Signals working well- just wish people would adhere to the appropriate signal and not race through a yellow light.
- Work well overall.
- Medians and side streets with rain gardens are always beautiful! Great job on these.

Duff Ave

- Duff is frustrating but to your credit, it is getting better. I like what you did with S Duff.
- I drive from N Duff to S Duff often and it doesn't work well. Can you cancel the cars

entering from a side street and make a red turn light so we don't stop and wait for nothing??

- Traffic lights need to be synced on Duff. The flow of lights is inefficient and impairs the flow of traffic.
- Timing of lights on S Duff Ave causes traffic backup.
- No more traffic lights on S. Duff. Jeez!
- I most definitely think the traffic signal at S. Duff and Target/Chick-fil-A needs to be changed to where there is a left turn arrow (i.e., no yield) because it is extremely difficult to turn onto S Duff at peak times of the day.
- I tried to avoid So Duff, and moved to North Ames when I got tired of driving. So much congestion from South Ames through to north and beyond. Extending Grand to 16th was a good move. Expanding 16th should help, especially with event management.

Crosswalks

- Maybe the beeping at crossing points could be quieter, I can hear the beeps from feet away.
- Our crosswalk policy and codes are archaic for a population of this size but so is the rest of Iowa. Cars don't have to yield to pedestrians according to the police.
- More stoplights need to have the countdown, making it much easier for big vehicles
- It takes many rotations to get a walk signal.
- Traffic signals on bus routes such as intersections of Lincoln/Beedle and Lincoln/Marshall should be timed to allow pedestrians to cross more frequently. Currently the waiting time can be quite long.
- My final thought is that the light to cross Lincoln at Sheldon could be more pedestrian friendly. The waiting time is currently pretty long compared to other lights near campus.

13th St

- 13th on Ontario and Stange are horrible during rush hours even before construction.
- Ames includes at least 1 incredibly dangerous intersection. At the intersection of Stange and 13th, a vehicle making a left hand turn in the southbound lane of Stange may receive a solid green signal. While yielding, if there is a large vehicle stationary in the northbound left lane, it can COMPLETELY obscure the northbound right lane. This greatly increases the risk for the driver making the left turn. A spherical mirror should be installed on the southeast corner of this intersection. 8 lane traffic lights with solid green signals should not be present in Ames, a city with a traffic infrastructure routinely bottlenecked by a large student population.
- I wish the Hyland-Ontario/13th St intersection was a bit quicker for people turning left from Hyland.
- The lights on 13th street between Grand Ave and Iowa State campus are horribly timed and back up because of left-hand traffic without an arrow

Road Conditions

- Please address the 13th Street to Burnett - incline at fire department, very uneven.
- Poor [road conditions in Old Town]

- Many ISU roads and some Ames roads are bumpy and poorly constructed. Most are excellent.
- New road on West 24- nice road but top surface terrible.

Highway and Exit Signals

- The traffic signals on Dayton by the Highway 30 bridge need better coordination. There are 3 signals close together that can impede traffic at times.
- Traffic lights at 13th I-35 exit are silly. Blinking lights would be sufficient and utilize full lights on game days/high traffic events only.
- 1-35 to 13th exit is time limited.

Miscellaneous

- I am a college student, don't drive.
- I hardly ever drive enough, and I pick my routes to avoid traffic signals.
- I think Ames should follow in the footsteps of other cities and set lower traffic intersections to blink yellow after 11 p.m.
- It would be nice if s 17th street extended to S Grand Ave by Copper Beach and The Quarters so The Quarters residence could cross 16th St with a light instead of trying to cross off Golden Aspen Drive. There is only a yard or so of grass in between these roads and it would make more sense if they were connected.
- They do not make sense.
- When did the City start putting up stop signs at every intersection in the residentials? I'm not sure who is asking for them, but no one asked me.
- State and Mortensen can be a huge back up during am/pm commute.
- We need more proper turn lanes.
- Not enough left turn signals on busier streets.
- The Vet Med stoplight is also annoying when it causes a significant backup of cars on 16th, and I feel the issue there would have been much more efficiently solved with a roundabout.

Comments on CyRide

Satisfied

- All around effective for every aspect.
- Always very professional
- CyRide is good for those that need to use it.
- CyRide is a great transit system! My husband and I use it daily (throughout the week) to get to and from campus. This is a huge benefit.
- CyRide is fantastic for the community in addition to being a good place to work.
- CyRide makes it possible for me (and many others) to live in Ames without a car. The service is very consistent, and the buses are nice and clean. I love being able to have high-quality public transit.
- Excellent
- Excellent service; used it for decades
- Friendly drivers, good rides usually. If bus is too packed, there is usually a second bus right behind it.
- Good service (x2)
- Great (x6)
- I have a friend who cannot drive, who uses it all the time and is very satisfied
- I like the programming they do for daycares.
- Very well-ran. MyState app is very useful.
- We live next to a bus stop, it's nice and quiet. Love the electric buses!
- The most well-functioning public service I've encountered is in Ames.
- The East Ames service extension has saved my day at work a couple of times over the years when my vehicle had issues- great resource!
- The app is very helpful. Overall buses are on schedule, can transport me pretty much everywhere I need to go.
- Nice drivers. I like the app!
- My two-year daughter loves the CyRide and celebrates every time she gets to see a bus.
- Love CyRide (x5)
- LOVE CyRide! The buses are awesome and they're amazing about finding lost things!
- Love CyRide my love and my life
- Legends over there.
- It's a good thing for Ames
- It is a really good and helpful service.
- Incredible Service
- Very important for ISU. Daughters used it while attending ISU.
- I do not drive so I rely on CyRide a lot for transportation
- I love CyRide; I use the Orange Route every single day.
- I love taking CyRide because it cuts down on driving and parking. They're very prompt and friendly.
- I love that Ames provides public transit for students and the community!

- I love how efficient and friendly CyRide is!
- Nice it is here as an option
- Bus drivers are respectful and drive safely. Parking with passengers and other drivers in mind.
- If needed, I would gladly use
- Great reliable public transit!
- No issues with CyRide.
- A family member formerly used CyRide to get to campus. Good routes, reasonable cost. Quit when employment changed.

Not enough bus stops or routes

- We live in Northridge. Closest bus stop is on Stange.
- CyRide does not service neighborhoods in the southwest part of town, nor just north of Lincoln Way, past North and South Dakota.
- I do not have a CyRide come near my apartment.
- I feel that more routes across Ames would be nice. Transport from campus across town can take several hours.
- I may use it in the future but the walk to the nearest stop is too far for an older person to walk
- It’s a bit of a long walk to the nearest stop. We use it occasionally, but it requires planning ahead.
- It’s concentrated to go to and from ISU. We are beyond this and therefore it is not useful to us.
- CyRide is not designed for non-undergrads. The routes are mostly on the same roads, and they don't run often enough to facilitate all the students, let alone the public.
- CyRide is great! There needs to be more shelters around town to make it more useful beyond getting to ISU.
- I love CyRide and used to use it a lot when I needed the red bus between west Ames and downtown. Since moving to south Ames, it's not as convenient.
- It's pretty good, but it would be great if there were more stops near Reiman Gardens and BWR residence hall areas.
- There isn't a stop near where I live. Not a practical option for my transportation needs.
- The buses do not run frequently enough and to enough locations. They do not get close to Sams Club, and the times do not match the schedule. If there is construction the buses should still run that route as there are certain areas that need to be accessible via bus. The bus times should not change when there is construction (traffic not included). Buses need to maintain morning frequency until 4 p.m.
- The closest bus stop is roughly a half mile away and my current health will not let me walk that far.
- I’m unable to walk to a bus stop.
- I would have to walk half a mile to get to a bus stop. I doubt I would use it.
- The cutback on service to East Ames changed a lot for us and it greatly inconveniently affected us, to the point of us almost losing our home. We strongly feel that we want CyRide to expand and keep the fees. A free ride for a few blocks is not very useful to most. (Assuming CyRide maintains cost reduction services for low income and disabled

persons.)

- Need more routes in North Ames.
- Need more routes to the east side of town. Such as the ball fields near the Skunk River.
- Service was provided to more areas of Ames.
- Time constraints and routes prevent my riding to campus (live on north side).

Need more frequent buses

- I wish the green line would run more buses, but I understand why it doesn't.
- Bus number 7 usually is not available in the time frame I need a ride.
- I wish more routes were operated on weekends. Routes like Cardinal not running weekends make it hard to move around campus then especially with so little parking,
- I think more buses on weekends would be nice.
- I would use CyRide more to go to events of more frequent trips that were available for events - downtown, basketball.
- It's nice during weekdays, but weekends and evenings are harder to use with efficiency.
- Kind of sucks on the weekends though and getting around Ames.
- Not enough bus stops or routes.
- We live in Northridge. Closest bus stop is on Stange.
- CyRide does not service neighborhoods in the southwest part of town, nor just north of Lincoln Way, past North + South Dakota.
- I do not have a CyRide come near my apartment.
- I feel that more routes across Ames would be nice. Transport from campus across town can take several hours.
- I may use it in the future but the walk to the nearest stop is too far for an older person to walk.
- It's a bit of a long walk to the nearest stop. We use it occasionally, but it requires planning ahead.
- It's concentrated to go to and from ISU. We are beyond this and therefore it is not useful to us.
- CyRide is not designed for non-undergrads. The routes are mostly on the same roads, and they don't run often enough to facilitate all the students, let alone the public.
- CyRide is great! There need to be more shelters around town to make it more useful beyond getting to ISU.
- I love CyRide + used to use it a lot when I needed the red bus between west Ames + downtown. Since moving to south Ames, it's not as convenient.
- It's pretty good, but it would be great if there were more stops near Reiman Gardens and BWR residence hall areas.
- There isn't a stop near where I live - Not a practical option for my transportation needs.
- The buses do not run frequently enough and to enough locations. They do not get close to Costco, and the times do not match the schedule. If there is construction the buses should still run that route as there are certain areas that need to be accessible via bus. The bus times should not change when there is construction (traffic not included). Buses need to maintain morning frequency until 4pm.
- The closest bus stop is roughly 1/2 mile away and my current health will not let me walk

that far.

- Unable to walk to a bus stop.
- I would have to walk .5 miles to get to a bus stop. I doubt I would use it.
- The cutback on service to East Ames changed a lot for us & greatly inconveniently affected us, to the point of us almost losing our home. We strongly feel that we want CyRide to expand & keep the fees. A free ride for a few blocks is not very useful to most. (Assuming CyRide maintains cost reduction services for low income and disabled persons.)
- Need more routes in North Ames.
- To the east side of town. Such as the ball fields near the Skunk River.
- service was provided to more areas of Ames.
- Time constraints & route prevent my riding to campus (work north side).
- Don't use because I must be at work by 5:00 AM.
- Don't use the service.
- Great service! We just don't use the service.
- I don't ride it, I commute.
- I prefer to walk.
- I support the service, but I work from home and walk or bike to many things. I simply don't need it.
- I work from home and do not need CyRide for anything.
- It is faster for me to ride my bike than to take CyRide, so I bike if the weather allows it. Because closest stop is a ~10 min walk, I don't ride the bus in bad weather, either, because that is too far to walk (closest stop to walk is 10 min, otherwise stop is on the edge of my yard). I do occasionally ride the bus. I also bike for exercise so I wouldn't ride the bus in good weather anyway.
- Think it is great, but I only drive twice a week.
- I would use it if I could not ride a bike or drive a car.

Used to Use it

- I used CyRide when I worked at ISU.
- I used it while attending Iowa State.
- I used CyRide as a student due to lack of parking on campus and it was good.
- I used it when I was in college at ISU and loved it.
- I loved it in college!

Fares

- I strongly support CyRide as a service to the Ames community. I recall fare free was provided several years ago. I would encourage consideration for this again.
- I live close enough to places I often visit (downtown, library, work, store) so I can walk or bike. I would use CyRide more if I went across town and if the fare was lower or free. I enjoy CyRide on very rare occasions when I use it.
- If ISU students can ride Cyride by showing thier ID for free because they pay student fees, then why can't the Ames school kids ride CyRide by showing their school Id's? Our parents pay our taxes so why can't our kids ride for free during the year?

- Would ride more if the fare when boarding was no cost.
- No one is suddenly going to decide to start riding CyRide because you stop charging a dollar to ride it. That monetary amount is not impacting decision making. Furthermore, it just means I'll be charged more in property taxes that I do not use.
- Used to ride CyRide. Give a thought to how much the fare helps with the budget of the system, then decide on free fares or not.

Driving is Easier

- I have my own transportation
- Driving is just so much easier. I'm looking at a time when I will no longer be driving and hope I can get to and from bus stops. I have looked at schedules and time needed to travel versus driving, and driving always wins.
- I love that we have CyRide and appreciate the service throughout Ames, but I do not ride it due to preferring the flexibility of my own vehicle.
- Still can drive.
- I just prefer to travel by car, though I use CyRide on football gamedays. I used it extensively in college over a decade ago and had no issues.
- When I first came here (2006) I didn't have a car and lived in W. Ames. I used CyRide and thought it was a good service. After getting a vehicle and moving close to downtown I haven't used it. It's very hard to convert people back to using the bus once they have a vehicle in the city where there doesn't seem to be traffic and parking problems. In a major city where there are these problems it makes sense to use public transport. If I was in the college faculty or worked a job where I didn't need to carry supplies in my vehicle, I would more likely use CyRide.

Overcrowded Buses

- Orange route is usually over capacity in the morning. It needs a good way to flexibly add buses when there's high demand. The rest has been fine, besides having difficulty finding a bus later at night last year when I had no car.
- Sometimes they force too many people on the bus.
- Overcrowded (2x)

Drivers/Driving

- Drivers need to be more considerate of other cars
- Drivers need to be less harsh on the brakes.
- Lot of the drivers brake hard

N/A

- N/A (x3)

Apps

- Poor app.
- They do a decent job, but I believe that the app needs to be entirely reworked as it often bugs out.

Miscellaneous

- Pets affect several services and are important for many people. I think more pet forward services would be great; maybe add "dogs in public space/dog training" class for kids, pet owners to facilitate appropriate facility use. Organize volunteers to help manage natural areas, remove exotics, and restore ground layer, industry. Think of the watershed impacts if all our riparian, parks had great ground cover, less run off- move infiltration. Put swan/watershed dollars towards restoration/infiltration.
- Appears when events occur CyRide is always given a hall pass. Why??
- Automobiles operated by CyRide to shuttle bus drivers around should be electric.
- I will be using it more in the next year or two.
- ISU students ride CyRide when traveling between campus and dorm.
- Need to get their hiring team together. Took months for them to get back to my husband because the manager kept forgetting him.
- Accessibility is a nightmare and often blocks traffic for two to three blocks due to trying to get the wheelchairs into the rusty straps.
- The bus stops are too close to one another. Also, they create dangerous blind spots at intersections.
- I love it and I want more of it. I wish there was some sort of service that would pick people up from Des Moines Airport.
- Overall excellent service to the community and ISU but too many empty or almost empty buses and double long buses, especially during ISU breaks.

Comments on Ames Parks and Recreation Services

Satisfied

- Ada Hayden is a gem!
- Ames is a great city to live in. There are plenty of options for parks and trails to go on whenever I want to walk my dog.
- Ames parks are wonderful. Love the pool for water walking and entertaining grandchildren
- Ames Parks with nature trails are my favorite. I love going to North River Valley trails, McFarland, and Emma McCarthy Lee for their wooded areas.
- Areas I use at Brookside are always clean and well-kept.
- Beautiful parks and natural areas within Ames.
- Good parks.
- Homewood Golf Course is a fantastic resource in our community.
- Homewood is excellent value.
- I have found Parks & Rec staff to be responsive and helpful every time I've had a question.
- I love Ada Hayden! It's a beautiful park
- I love all the little hidden gems in the parks and so many different trails to hike!
- I love the environment.
- I love the variety of parks and outdoor spaces in Ames!
- I really enjoy going on runs around Ada Hayden and other parks around Ames. I appreciate that Ames has a lot of sidewalks and trails I can use for running.
- I really enjoy how hard Ames works to include things for the community.
- I walk quite often at Ada Hayden and am really happy about the plans to widen the trail and make it concrete.
- I went to Brookside Park, and it was pretty good. I like the seating area and the open space.
- I'm pretty impressed by Ames's initiative to improve recreation.
- Love the trails, very well maintained.
- Overall good as far as I've seen.
- Overall, I think it is very good.
- Sixty Forward has been a great addition to Ames.
- Thank you for your work! Your dedication makes Ames a better place for everyone who lives here.
- The parks are generally great!
- Very good.
- Well maintained, especially Brookside Park
- When my grandchildren visit, the aquatic center is a favorite spot as are many playgrounds. When my children still lived at home, we made great use of the recreational facilities and programming; appreciated the variety. Both girls learned to swim through Ames Parks + Rec and started soccer there.
- Anxiously awaiting the indoor pool.
- Excited to see the finished indoor aquatic facility. Huge disappointment when indoor

swimming at Forker on ISU campus closed this past year.

- I am looking forward to the new indoor aquatics' facility.
- Looking forward to new indoor aquatics.
- I do love the Furman Aquatic Center and look forward to the new indoor aquatic center.
- It is alright I suppose.

Improved Swimming Facilities

- Furman Aquatic Center does not have any size-accessible slides for those who are too large for tube slides other than the drop slide, which can be intimidating, and the family slide, which is limited to people with children only. My peers and I believe that anyone should be able to use the family slide, because someone's size shouldn't impact their ability to have fun at the pool.
- Quality of kids' swim lessons needs work. Please turn off sprinklers on the lazy river.
- No wading pools for kids.
- Pool water is always too cold
- I hope there will be two Furman Aquatic Centers!
- Currently there is no indoor public pool. (Bad)
- I've been very disappointed with the complete lack of indoor aquatic classes/options after the closure of the high school and Forker pools. I know a new facility is under construction but in the meantime, there are zero other options besides joining a gym.
- I think outdoor aquatics are okay due to apartment complexes but other than that there are no real opportunities for residents other than the one known outdoor pool. For indoor aquatics there is one option that I know of at Ames Fitness, which requires a pass.
- I'd love to swim laps year-round in a 25/50 meter pool. I hope the new indoor pool offers a lot of options for moderate-fast lap swimming too. I wish there was a 50 meter lap swimming during the day/evening, not just the crack of dawn.
- As of right now there isn't an indoor pool. The outdoor pool is always packed.

Park Maintenance and Clean-Up

- Could use more proactive cleanup and repairs instead of relying on citizen reporting.
- Many of the wooded areas are full of invasive species (Brookside for example)
- Munn Woods trail needs maintenance and clearer signage.
- The shelter at Daley Park could use some maintenance. Basketball backboard and nets need replaced at Daley Park.
- The grass in park areas is often spotty, rough, and full of bugs that cause reactions on the skin.
- Most shelters are nice, but some are bad. We had a department picnic at Inis Grove and two whole tables were covered in vomit and all (half dozen) trash bins full and swarming with wasps.
- My only noticeable concern when using parks and trails is the trash littered everywhere.
- I wish the city would address all of the homeless people who have taken over the parks and trashed the restrooms. Including having sex in them.
- More trash cans

- Need to manage invasive plants and add more natives to wooded natural areas.
- I would love to see more areas protected and zones on wooded/natural areas, trees and native prairie plants planted. I'd like to see Carr Park repaired better when the pipes were laid.
- Deteriorating quality of habitat and invasive species

Improved Trail System

- Although the quality of recreational trails and parks is good, they are very limited on the southwest side of town.
- More trails please!
- Mountain bike single track trials would be so much fun in Ames.
- Please continue adding connection trails. Cyclists need safe ways to travel that don't involve riding in traffic, e.g. no bike lanes.
- I would like a trail system that connects trails in west and east Ames.
- It’s nice to get out to the local parks. I wish there were more natural forest trails away from traffic, but all in all I enjoy the outdoor spaces.
- Better connection/organization of city bike trails. They seem to start/end randomly. Crossing signal/lower speed limit where bike paths crosses 13th near Stagecoach. Duff is not a "bike friendly" street. Lots of traffic, including buses, seams, weeds & debris are unfortunate obstacles of the bike lane (and sewer grates.)
- I think there could be more trails in Ames but the ones we have are good.
- Existing trails are good, need more connected network inside city + between cities.
- I appreciate that Ames has a lot of parks because I love being able to walk my dogs and see nature around me. I'd love more walking trails around the city, but I think that's just a product of being in a busy city. What we did was great!
- Trails by Emma McCarthy Lee Park need to be paved to be more accessible to all residents. Could have better connectivity to campus pathways and sidewalks.
- Lots of informal bike trails
- I would like to see more connections of trails/bike trails across town.

More or Improved Bathrooms

- Add more bathrooms to Ada Hayden
- Greenbrier Park is right next to a bike trail, and it is also near the stadium. I think it would be beneficial if this park had a restroom. I know many people who walk on the trail nearby on a regular basis and think a restroom would be beneficial.
- Having proper, clean restrooms in the Ada Hayden Heritage Park would be great.
- More restrooms at Ada Hayden
- Never enough restrooms
- No open (year-round) bathrooms is a real problem!
- Would love indoor plumbing at Carr and at Tedesco
- The parks I have been to have been nice and are used by many but there are rarely open/clean bathrooms.
- I wish the park bathrooms opened earlier in the year, but I understand why that wouldn't

work.

Improved Playgrounds and Parks

- Need better play equipment at Inis Grove & in all neighborhoods.
- As playgrounds continue to be updated, the variety of equipment continues to decline. The quality is great though! We appreciate the updates
- Could use more swings.
- I'd love to have more of a variety of playground equipment around Ames, especially for those 5 & under! Inis Grove is fantastic, but other areas are lacking. I miss having a splash pad. I am hoping one of the planned splash pads will be open this summer.
- I would like to see more playgrounds and parks in north Ames
- Need more parks with more wooded areas and more shelters
- The city is woefully short of pickleball courts. The ones recently placed at Emma McCarthy Lee are already cracked. The city needs to put more emphasis in this area. The existing courts are always full and there are usually people waiting. It's embarrassing to hear of people going to neighboring towns to find decent courts.
- They are overall in good condition; we need more tennis courts and pickleball courts in my opinion.
- Wish there were many more parks, outdoor pools (the aquatic center is expensive and crowded), and general gathering areas.

Costs

- I hope that people/families with low incomes have reduced or no fees
- We would use the aquatic center but it’s not affordable for low-income families.
- Worried about cost for retired citizens.
- Consider offering 1 week or daily package for when out-of-town grandchildren visit.
- The option of purchasing a seasonal pass for the city gym would be beneficial.

Better Signage and Information

- I would love for information to be more readily available! For example, posted trail routes and camping areas.
- I hope there were better resources to learn about trails and wooded areas. e.g. Reactor Woods & Munn Woods.
- Multi-use trails with signage to let residents and visitors know of the network and parks.
- I wish there were more wayfinding signs in the park

Programming and Activities

- I would like to see more "senior-only" sports options offered like senior volleyball or senior pickleball.
- I am a graduate student and am always looking for things to do through Ames Parks and Rec! My only wish is that there were more activities that someone could sign up for without having a previous team, as the free-agent option for summer team sports rarely gets anyone picked up.

- I would love to see more variety of adult info sessions for beginners. For example, gardening, mountain biking, hunting, etc. Different levels would be great too! Maybe trips as well around Iowa!
- I'd love to see sports other than gymnastics or dance for 2-year-olds!

Miscellaneous

- I enjoy volunteering for the biannual community tree plantings.
- I would love it if Petersons Pits would allow dogs on the beach. It's super hard to find an area in Ames that is dog and kid friendly. For families with pets, this is a hardship always having to leave the dog at home alone.
- Overall, while I see a lot of perks with Ames Parks and Recreation, there is also room for growth! Some of the Parks and Recreation facilities in Ames are also a lot better than the others.
- The TV feed in the City Gym cardio room has not been working for months, please fix it!
- I wish I was still able to use all these services.
- Allow deer hunting.
- We don't use golf areas they are of no interest to my family.
- I also think a community the size of Ames should have a decent fitness facility with weight room, exercise class space & gym space. The proposal (that failed) was poorly marketed & tried to do too much
- Accessibility matters and it’s largely nonexistent here.
- Look at the bus route. Could every park at least have one stop on the routes? Maybe more ISU students would use them.

Comments on Ames Public Library

Satisfied

- General
  - Great (x2)
  - I love the library (x2)
  - A+
  - I love going there with my family when we have time!
  - I love our library! Keep up the great work!
  - I love the Ames Public Library! I've spent many hours there studying and it's a great location when I want to get away from the college. The atmosphere is great, people have been so lovely, and the building is beautiful. I wish I had more time to enjoy the library.
  - Great facility. It’s welcoming and has a wonderful variety of resources.
  - Excellent and important resource for Ames.
  - Excellent amenity. Well trained welcoming staff. There are a variety of programs for all ages, cooperation with Story County Genealogical Society, Ames History Museum, Repair Day, etc.
  - Assisted with Raising Readers and was impressed by library facilities.
  - Amazing staff!! Everyone is so welcoming and helpful whenever I visit!! Everything is always clean and organized. Seating is not always comfortable. I enjoy the book sales- great selection and price
  - I ADORE the library. It's great for meeting with friends in the summer and refilling my water bottle while taking walks! I love playing mobile games downtown, and the library is a great central area.
  - Great place to meet and have discussions with your group or organization
  - I love the environment and all the amenities they provide for the community.
  - I think our library is excellent, everyone has always been very helpful
  - I volunteer at the Ames public library! Enjoy it very much
  - I’ve lived in several places and metros, and this is the finest library.
  - Keep up the great work!
  - Love the library, only place I get books.
  - LOVE the public library! I wish I had more time to hang out there and use the resources - such a wonderful place to be!
  - Nice library.
  - Our family has recently expanded so we hope to take our newborn to the library once the time comes. We only had very good references for the Ames Public Library, and we appreciate the service you provide!
  - Overall, a nice setup.
  - Overall, very good
  - I really enjoy our library!
  - Take my child there sometimes. It is a very cool and interesting place especially for kids.

- This is one of my favorite places in Ames and I am so grateful to be a patron there.
- Very nice place, especially for children. I love the layout of the library. I think it's very pretty, decent size, and there are very cool activities/projects to do at the library that they give you access to.
- Visited once a week all through August-December 2023! Enjoyed their services very much.
- We are very happy with the library because it meets our expectations
- We have an amazing library & library staff- a great asset to our community
- Welcoming community, I have been able to make use of their online resources as well. Good place to study because of the outlets on the tables. Also, nice that there are separate areas for children/teens/college students.
- Love it!
- It's a very nice library. I don't use enough.
- The Ames Public Library is amazing, and I love being able to use the Bookmobile to pick up and drop off books without having to drive downtown.
- Ames Public Library is a great resource, and we are lucky to have such an exceptional place.
- I love the library!! LOVE the book mobile!

- Staff
  - Amazing helpful staff!
  - Friendly staff
  - Good experience every time I go. Staff on the 4 p.m. shift are very helpful.
  - Great Staff!
  - Helpful personnel in locating materials
  - Enjoyable interior, kind staff
  - Staff have helped me out and wife to numerous questions. The checkout is already so friendly. Many children love Storytime.
  - The books are maintained very well, and the staff is great to talk to and work with!
  - Welcoming staff!
  - Wonderful building with friendly and helpful staff.
  - Library staff have been super helpful in answering questions and suggesting resources and recommending books to me and my kids. I very much appreciate the variety of options to get involved and be connected at the library.
  - I like to use the library. Staff are friendly, well-trained and helpful
- Environment/Atmosphere
  - Every time I have been to the library it has been clean and welcoming
  - I love it there and it is a beautiful space!
  - I love libraries! And it is such a nice environment to be in.
  - I love the warm and welcoming environment! It is in a great location by Main Street and is a great place to study or relax.
  - It's a quite cozy place. I would say it is one of the best places to get your work done and prepare for exams.
  - Very welcoming and great resources there

- Books and Resources
  - A great place with great collection of books
  - I appreciate digital resources as well as the library building collections.
  - I appreciate the commitment to providing books and resources to diverse groups.
  - I appreciate the variety of genres within the library. I also love the way the library looks.
  - Great selection of books and always have good resources with a welcoming staff.
  - I love the Bookmobile as a college student!
  - I love the Bookmobile service- clever idea!
  - It is a very good facility and has good resources.
  - I think the bus outreach at different places is a good feature.
  - It's a great resource. I use Hoopla for online access to audio books and music
  - Thank you for Hoopla and Libby!
  - We love the library! We have rented hundreds of movies and books and use the resources heavily.
  - Wonderful community resources.
  - Love it. I hope they keep the IDEA center. I don't usually see other people in there, so I worry that it isn't being utilized (and might get taken away).
- Programming and Events
  - I absolutely love all the programming provided!
  - Classes are very good. Instructors great and volunteers helpful.
- Continued/More Funding
  - Our local library is a wonderful resource and should continue to receive proper funding and support
  - One of the most important third spaces available to the community. It is irreplaceable and should receive all the funding it requests and then some
  - The Ames Public Library is amazing! It always deserves more funding.

Don’t Use

- As a college student I have very little need for the Ames Public Library because I use the library on campus.
- Don't use it (x2)
- Do not use it at all, but have heard good things about it
- I don't have any reason to use it regularly.
- I don't have time
- I haven't heard much about the Ames Public Library, so I have never used it.
- I use Parks library instead.
- I've never been there
- It is difficult to use the public library when Iowa State has one on campus. I don't find myself ever thinking about using it since Iowa States is so close.
- n/a (x3)
- Never been. Parks Library is good enough

- Nothing to say, I don't use it.
- Not as often as I like
- I've only been in once or twice, but it seems very nice
- I do not use the library. When the children were young, we used the library and were glad to have such a nice facility. I bring books and magazines to donate but that is all.

Free/Expanded Parking

- I don't like to pay to park near the library.
- Just an observation... I don't care to put money into parking meter if I don't have to and I guess I am not alone this way as a library user. Many times, the library parking lot is almost empty, but street parking spots are rare. Several times I have almost parked at the hospital.
- Ours is the only library that we have visited that does not have free parking. (Our children live all over and we have visited a lot of libraries.)
- Parking is often an issue- Bridges worked well for me.
- Parking is very limited and what is available is pay to park.
- There are no available parking spaces for the public without a meter, which under the State of Iowa laws regarding public libraries there are certain requirements for public spaces based on population. There is also the standard of every other city or town in Iowa providing parking for patrons, however Ames does not. That is the main reason why I do not use the library, because it is not welcoming to all people.
- There is no free parking near the Public Library making it expensive and inconvenient to access.
- I like Ames Public Library! However, I believe parking is difficult, and it is much more convenient location-wise to go to Parks instead.
- I just wish there was more free parking, especially for people needing handicapped spots.
- I just wish there was more parking available around the library and that it was free.

Homeless/Other Patrons

- I have felt intimated by the loiterers in front of the library, not there for library services but because it's a place to hang out. In addition, I have experienced having to walk by people smoking on the bench nearest the book drop. No smoking is clearly posted, and library staff went to speak to those concerned but is this really the job of the library staff?
- I have heard too many homeless people are allowed to sleep inside the library
- The library is no longer safe as it appears to be a homeless shelter instead of a library. No longer welcoming, I would not take my kids there.
- The library itself is great. Don't like it is a hangout for the homeless
- While the library should be open to everyone, it's off-putting spending time in the adult's section because of the number of homeless people sleeping and taking up so many seats not using the services or reading.
- Too many mentally ill and homeless people use the library resources and do not follow the rules. There are people yelling, smoking, eating, and drinking on the library grounds and inside. It makes it feel unsafe and unwelcoming. It is not good to have kids walk past people huffing smoke.

Accessibility

- We need tall toilets in the handicap stalls. The ones there are too low for those of us who have knee + hip problems
- Accessibility is way more than just having a ramp.
- I would like there to be an easier way to get there
- Consider push button stop all traffic for peds.

Expanded Hours

- My only wish is that it would open earlier on Sundays. The library is such an important place for those who lack a safe space elsewhere
- Unfortunately, I like to pick out books at the end of the day and the library is usually closed.

Improved Resources and Services

- My son says it needs Nintendo Switch video games
- Audio books can sometimes be 3 months' wait time.
- Great, and great materials, I just wish there were more study rooms. I also wish the study rooms were more soundproof and had better chairs (the red rollie chairs in front of the computers instead of the hard metal chairs)
- I would love to see fiction be grouped into genres. Not many newish romance books. I would love to see desk seating by windows in adult section.
- Need a more obvious way to request books be brought to the library that they do not currently provide.
- should add cafe attachment
- We disagree with the policy that allows minors to have library cards with no oversight from parents- I should be able to ask a staff member for help with my very young son's account without his permission.
- I hope more study rooms were available, and it would be a bit nicer.
- Love the Library! I wish more availability on Libby and Hoopla but overall satisfied (some books just too popular :)
- We have a wonderful library! I wish that hoopla borrows hadn't been reduced.

Miscellaneous

- I also have access to Parks Library
- I don't know what they offer. Perhaps a welcome to Ames Library email or newsletter would be beneficial for new people in the area.
- I grew up frequently visiting the library.
- I know my great grandchildren use the library
- Please protect books from the state and federal government as best as possible.

Comments on Sense of Belonging as an Ames Resident

What, if anything, could be done to enhance your sense of belonging as an Ames resident?"

Government Viewpoints and Actions

- Less Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion
  - [Circles "diversity, equity, inclusion"] "shouldn't have"
  - Ames has a strong commitment to the liberal idea of diversity, equity, and inclusion which excludes anyone who has more conservative values.
  - DEI should be eliminated as a city commitment.
  - Get rid of DEI
  - I do not believe in diversity, equity, and inclusion forced upon me.
  - Less DEI. The city spends a lot of time and money on DEI, and it is not necessary. Liberal indoctrination. People who are more conservative are not valued in Ames.
  - Make the DEI programs more inclusive and less anti-Caucasian or eliminate the programs all together. They alienate everyone who is not the "minority." They call the "minority" population the victims and suggest that parents that work hard and sacrifice for their children to give them opportunities make the children entitled. They use the word entitled as a negative connotation and make it seem like the sacrifices that their parents made for them are null and void because they're Caucasian or not the minority. I have never been so alienated by a program and systematically racially and ethnically profiled in my life. It is a program that harps equality but creates victims, hatred, and racism. The university is creating a stigma that all Christians are bigots because they don't support the lifestyle choices of others. I can have my opinions and beliefs just like anyone else. I don't hate people because they choose to be gay or trans or any other orientations. I do my best to find and treat everyone how I would like to be treated, but this does not mean I will support their lifestyle or tell them they are doing the right thing. I don't believe in what they are doing and that it is okay for me to have an opposing stance. I can love the person they are but dislike the lifestyle they choose and not support the groups, rallies, or lifestyle they're a part of. Please address this for future generations because it is sad to see the division it has created in the community.
  - The diversity and equality thing is a waste of time. Each person is valuable
- More Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion
  - Continue to support and actively embrace all aspects of diversity & inclusion
  - Great question. I generally feel I belong, but I don't think I would if I were queer and/or a person of color.
  - Increase education on language barriers, meaning not necessarily teach people more English, but rather create ways in which they can better understand each other.
  - More diverse visibility
  - More senior inclusion?
  - More support for DEI & non-white enrichment projects
  - Repaint the queer crosswalks
  - Stand with the LGBTQIA+ community and our immigrant community.
  - Vocal support for trans people, the LGBTQ+ community is welcomed but currently there are a lot of legal attacks on trans rights happening in Iowa and I would love to keep living in Ames, but my partner and I will be moving as soon as we receive our

degrees.
    - I think both Ames and the university need to do more to actively stand up for and include groups such as POC and LGBTQ community members who are being targeted by Iowa state government policies.
    - More diversity in the shops, eating areas, and community events to spread knowledge
    - Accessibility
- Political Viewpoints
    - Feeling like my conservative viewpoint is respected if not accepted
    - Tolerance of a non-leftist viewpoint
    - Flip the state government!
- Other
    - A new mayor and city council would be a good start.
    - Get city officials to care about more people or at least pretend. Don't be so difficult to contact and communicate with.
    - Value and protect permanent residents over college students
    - Ames doesn't really have a community identity. It's missing.
    - Not assuming that all mothers of young children don't work outside the home.

Services and Infrastructure

- Making Ames safer at traffic lights.
- Maybe more support from non-profit organizations in their community-oriented services or activities
- Medical freedom. McFarland clinic & Mary Greeley Medical Center like to push their own agenda and don't really care about the patients' health, beliefs or diet.
- More walkability and more public transit
- See previous answer regarding housing- more flexible leases that don't leave you homeless for a week & rent control to incentivize people to stay and build community.
- The policing could be improved. Generally, I consider officers to conduct themselves well, but there have also been unfortunate and unjustified problematic experiences with the City and University police forces.

Community Events, Activities, and Spaces

- Better advertising of opportunities and activities for meeting and engaging with people with similar interests
- Create more fun events
- Free community events that are advertised to all.
- Have more community events
- I know ISU obviously has a million programs for students, but I think advertising Ames programs and events to ISU students would help ISU students connect with the rest of the city; we're integrated physically, but not so much socially, I feel. Local businesses connect with us, but less so the Ames government or public events, and I think it's simply because school events get shoved into our faces and I usually hear about Ames events after they happen.
- IMPROVE PARKING FOR COMMUNITY EVENTS. IF IT'S GOING TO BE A HASSLE TO PARK. I PROBABLY WON'T GO.
- Maybe make it a more happening place by inviting people to group meets for games and

stuff. Have more public events.

- More communication about community events
- More community get togethers, community activities (garage sales, etc.)
- More community involvement and Iowa State
- More events for my community and better communication of them
- More events in downtown Ames for college students!
- More free programs and activities.
- More friend events for 25–35-year-olds or events for this!
- More neighborhood music events
- More space for remote workers because I get tired of working in my home office.
- More opportunities for social gatherings at parks
- More outreach activities
- More ways to meet people.
- Someone tried to put together a block party and got reprimanded by the landlord about how they did it.
- Promote block parties & more neighborhood interactions. Welcome program for new residents
- Bigger parks, seating and lights
- Ways to mingle get to know people.

Businesses

- Bring more businesses to Ames!
- Have more restaurants that have good food
- If jobs in the community had gotten back to me about applications rather than no response.
- Honestly my main concern about Ames is just the lack of good food options. Sure there's a few decent restaurants, but I need a good fried chicken spot which Ames does not have. The addition of a good fried chicken spot would make me feel like I belong.
- More ethnic stores and grocery stores.

Resident Relations

- Nicer people
- I would like more integration between the student body of ISU and the larger Ames community because I think they currently feel disjointed.
- Ames isn't as friendly as I'm used to coming from SW Iowa. People don't wave or say hi/hello when you speak to them.
- Residents don’t always seem to agree with college students
- Less foreigners

Personal Actions

- Engaging more
- For many years, I thought of volunteering on one of the city boards
- Getting to know my neighbors more
- Having a strong relationship with neighbors

- I should utilize more of the community events that happen in Ames.
- Join activities at the library and meet people at the parks.
- Joined groups and communities with people of similar interests
- Not stay cooped up inside playing video games
- Volunteer as I have in the past
- Serving the community at a larger capacity

Nothing/Do not know

- Already feel comfortable
  - I am comfortable with my current sense of belonging
  - I feel like I have found my place- I don't think I am looking for more at this time.
  - I have lived with my family in Ames since 1998 and love every minute
  - I am an 89-year-old woman who loves Ames- the big-little town.
  - I like living in Ames.
  - It's already good
  - Not sure, I feel like I belong
  - Nothing really. I already feel belonged
  - Nothing that I'm aware of because I feel I belong.
- Do not need help
  - I think as a student I don't really think of myself as an Ames resident, and that is probably okay.
  - I'm an ISU student. I belong in Kansas.
  - N/A- do not have a lot of time to engage with the larger Ames community
  - Not interested. Too much time commitment to job, family, activities. I don't need the community to make me feel a sense of belonging.
  - Nothing I just don't put myself out there
  - Nothing really; I am an Iowa State student from Chicago, and I want to live in a big city when I'm done with school. There is nothing wrong with Ames; it is just not my end goal of living place.
  - Nothing the city can do
  - Eh I don't really want to live in Iowa after finishing school, so it's nothing Ames has done per say. It's more I would rather dip out of the Midwest.
  - Iowa (state government) is the problem & not much Ames can do about this
- None/Don't know
  - N/A (x4)
  - None (x4)
  - I do not know (x7)

Comments on "What is the best thing about living in Ames?

The people

- The residents are kind, grounded, and genuinely supportive of one another, which makes living here both comfortable and meaningful.
- Nice people (x2)
- Family & Friends (x2)
- Welcoming culture
- Friendly people (x11)
- Friendly and caring people
- Good People (x11)
- Having friendly people who help each other.
- I enjoy the people
- I think the friendly people, library, the water are great to use.
- I've met so many people who are willing to help and refer to programs for mental health, fun, and home improvement.
- The best thing about Ames is the people living in it
- Like minded citizens
- People are friendly and want to help
- My neighbors
- Neighbors + Friends are unmatchable!
- One sister lives in Ames so closeness of family
- Our kind of people
- People by far
- People in Ames really seem to try to live to our state motto of being Iowa nice.
- The best thing about living in Ames is the community and its people.
- The best thing is how friendly the workers in Ames facilities are
- The folks
- The people who are here during the summer. I especially appreciate it when students stay and keep contributing.
- The people. They're all very welcoming and open.
- The residents

Parks, Greenery, and Trails

- Ledges State Park
- A lot of walkable parks
- Access to parks. I'm not a huge fan of governmental spending, but the city does do a good job with the parks and playground system.
- Nice outdoor spaces (parks/bike paths/etc.)
- All the city parks + green spaces
- Trees (x2)
- Good parks (x12)
- Lots of parks

- The trails (x4)
- Good trail systems just need better connections throughout city.
- Green spaces
- I enjoy using the outdoor spaces
- I love the parks + the library! My husband and I run the trails frequently.
- I love parks and trails.
- It's a good blend of nature and community town.
- There's a good number of nature/parks both in separate areas and integrated into the city
- The nearness of nature
- Natural life and the parks
- Nature and tree preservation
- The trails are a pretty nice and there are wooded areas in town to walk.
- The trees and the woods
- Ada Hayden Park

Events and Activities

- 8:01 Day
- Available activities (x2)
- Community events (x9)
- Recreation offerings for the kids
- Farmers market (x4)
- Good recreation facilities
- Hard to say but I love the farmers market, library, & parks and would love to see more rec events.
- High quality entertainment facilities
- The farmer's market is a highlight of the year, along with the different events that happen on Main Street.
- I love how active Main Street is with events and things.
- Outdoor activities in the summer
- It is easy to navigate and find community with all activities planned around town, especially in the summertime.
- Sports
- Entertainment
- Main street activities

Iowa State University

- Access to education (The University)
- Love living in a college town!
- ISU (x19)
- College Town atmosphere (x2)
- Going to Iowa State University
- The academic culture and pride that the university supplies
- Iowa state! The campus is so beautiful and great to be a part of.

- Iowa State's beautiful campus (x2)
- ISU Sports activities, arts opportunities at CY Stephens
- I love seeing students around
- Events and activities are plenty with ISU
- ISU adds an abundance of wonderful learning and entertainment and recreation opportunities to life here in Ames also.
- Being a cyclone fan
- The college community
- the energy of the students
- The university and the diversity, the educational programs, and opportunities it brings to the community

Safety

- Safety (x15)
- Relatively safe (x2)
- Safe neighborhoods
- I always feel safe. (x3)
- I like how safe I feel in the community!
- I love how safe Ames feels. I appreciate that I feel safe walking home alone as a young woman when I am in Ames.
- I love how the community feels safe and clean!
- It's a safe community.
- Low crime (x3)
- Low crime rates, although lately crime is going up. Need more residential patrolling.
- Safety maintenance
- Overall safe environment

Sense of Community

- Community (x14)
- Engaged community
- High quality, caring community.
- I enjoy the community
- Strong sense of community (x4)
- The community. Even though it is always changing, there remains a strong sense of belonging and safeness.
- The connectedness between everyone
- The sense of community- people are proud to live here and are helpful to their neighbors

Atmosphere

- The ambience, the friendly geese, neighborhood dogs
- Atmosphere (x2)
- Homey
- Welcoming atmosphere

- Hometown feels in a larger town
- I like the small-town feel (x4)
- It's a vibrant community with several options of things to do.
- It's peaceful, green and clean.
- It's quiet, pretty and feels relatively safe.
- It’s a big city with a small-town vibe.
- Peace and quiet
- Beauty
- Quiet, private, welcoming
- Small town feel with big city amenities (x2)
- Small town feel, big town opportunities.
- The calmness and serenity
- the community feels
- The community is wonderful and very safe.
- The quiet, the order
- The culture

Community Services and Resources

- City services are fantastic
- Community services (x3)
- Community Resources
- Community support & programs
- Public services (x2)
- Library (x6)
- Free public services such as the library
- Community mental health efforts
- I feel there is a great amount of community resources available to help those who may need it.
- Public spaces such as the library.
- Services are getting good

Amenities

- All the amenities!
- All the opportunities and services provided. Ames is a wonderful place to live.
- Good amenities such as groceries, restaurants, parks.
- Good amenities/perks of a college town but still safe and fun community to be part of.
- Has good amenities (x3)
- The abundance of great amenities and choices and the general proximity to them
- Large variety of things to do, restaurants, etc.
- Great community and always something to do
- Lots to see and do (x6)
- Love all restaurants, stores, farmers market, and neighborhood paths.
- Nice community and many things to offer

- I also like it that Ames has all the features of a big town but still small-town friendliness and convenience.
- Small town feeling while still having access to many resources, including options for groceries, medical care, and activities.
- The 3rd spaces available
- The combination of services and conveniences of a city with the closeness to nature.
- Sustainable options
- There's a lot to do around Ames with parks, trails, farmer's markets, and other events.
- The variety of food/stores/parks that are in Ames
- Various high-quality amenities.

Size

- Big enough to be big, small enough to be small.
- Big enough to have most amenities but small enough to have good community
- Good size (x8)
- Not too big, not too small.
- Overall, it's a relatively small town where neighbors know each other.
- Small enough to not have a lot of hassles but big enough to have needed services
- Small community/town (x4)
- Small town with everything most people need.
- The fact that it is a "big town-little town" is the friendliness of a small-town living and yet the advantage of big town living!

Businesses and Restaurants

- The Bars, Cellar 626, the mall
- Variety of businesses (x2)
- The 13 Starbucks, B-Bops, Dublin Bay, Jethro's
- Accessibility to restaurants and shopping
- Interesting local businesses
- Food choices (x2)
- The small businesses that make Ames special.
- High quality shopping (x2)
- Grocery stores
- Store options (x2)
- The food
- The high-quality small business that thrives here
- Main St. businesses
- Restaurants (x2)

Quality of Life

- Ames is a beautiful town and a nice place to live.
- Ames Nice
- Ames offers a high quality of life anchored by a strong sense of community.

- The opportunity to live healthily, eat healthy, work healthy.
- Easy living (x2)
- Except for crime, living in Ames is easy. I love Ames!
- Have what I need
- I appreciate living in a healthy, attractive, and safe environment, which offers good a quality of amenities and is still affordable.
- It is just a great place to live
- Quality of life (x2)
- Simple life. Iowa.
- The welcoming and diverse community with lots of opportunities for its residents.
- We are old, safety is our major concern, and we are pleased with our quality of life here.

Public Transit

- Affordable and accessible public transit
- Public Transit (x2)
- CyRide (x5)
- CyRide is a huge benefit to me and my family.
- Free CyRide for students
- The transportation system (x2)
- The transportation, while flawed, makes everything easier which is why it should be improved

Water

- Water (x4)
- Great water quality (x5)
- I also love our tap water.
- Tap water (x2)
- Great Water for drinking

Diverse Population

- Amazing community with a relatively diverse population.
- Diverse population
- Diversity (x2)
- Mixture of people: racial cultures, languages, backgrounds, religions, etc.
- Cultural diversity
- The diversity of people I get to meet and learn about their respective cultures and backgrounds.
- The diversity of people; living environments.
- The variety of people who live here
- We love the diversity of the neighborhood.

Walkability and Bike-ability

- Safety- Most things are walkable from our home

- Bike-ability
- Biking to work. Ames is walkable and not spread out.
- Everything is very close together, in a walkable distance
- I've enjoyed raising my kids here. Easy and safe to bike to school & late at night coming home from work
- Most of Ames is walkable
- Most walkable city in Iowa if not the Midwest
- Ability to bike around

Easy to Get Around

- Close to everything
- How close everything is and how easy it is to get around
- Low traffic due to low population.
- proximity to stores/restaurants.
- I also like the fact that the traffic is mostly localized on the south side of Ames.
- the accessibility (x2)
- The closeness of everything (i live on campus as an fyi)
- The convenience of everything in one area. Need more places to eat on the west side of Ames
- The ease in getting around town (x2)
- Generally, the city is very user friendly

Clean

- Clean (x3)
- Clean Communities
- Clean spaces
- Overall, clean and quiet, however crime seems to be increasing

Downtown

- Free Parking Downtown
- Very nice downtown (x2)
- Downtown (x3)
- Main Street

Opportunities

- Opportunities (x3)
- Work
- We have a wide variety of opportunities in Ames- small town living but big city opportunities.

Government and Leadership

- BLUE DOT IN A RED STATE
- Good local government

- The City Council is so great and responsive, and I truly appreciate how much Ames cares about its residents.
- The mayor and staff keep the property tax by being efficient.
- Citizens and leadership within community, City staff is responsive at one level. Good working relationship (historically) w/ ISU. This should continue.
- Overall well-run
- Progression, responsiveness, and competent leadership and workers
- Responsive Govt
- Government response, citizen involvement.
- Upkeep of town and parks

Schools

- Ames community schools
- Schools (x2)

Affordability

- Affordable rent
- Cheap/affordable quality of life
- Cost of living
- Cheaper than surrounding large cities like Des Moines

Arts

- Importance of the arts!!
- Octagon
- Art festivals

Family Friendly

- Great place to raise a family
- Family friendly
- The family friendly atmosphere

Location

- Central location to the state health services
- Being close to work and family
- Quiet living but can get to a larger city easily.

Growing

- Healthy and growing community
- Growth

Health/Dental Care

- High quality health, dentals
- I like the size, friendliness, education (k-12 & University) and health care. We moved here to educate our family because of jobs in healthcare.

Home

- I was born and raised here, it’s home. You could get to a better mall. The mall in Ames sucks!!! Best store is JC Pennys. Need more!!!
- My home

Miscellaneous

- It is not Des Moines.
- It’s not Iowa City
- It’s a decent community. It's kind of expensive to live here but overall, I've enjoyed living here so far.
- No Fireworks!
- When the students are on break it is a very good place to live.

Comments on Other Issues the City should focus its attention

Walkability and Bike-ability

- Bicycle infrastructure: more bikes = less traffic
- Bike lanes would be a great addition.
- Biker safety and educating drivers on pedestrian/biker right-of-way.
- Crosswalk safely
- I am concerned about the street near me - a neighbor uses a scooter to get around and the street is uneven. I hope that condition doesn't tip him over (No Sidewalk)
- I honestly think the City should focus on making Ames more bike friendly to allow for safe commute options for people within the city that want to bike everywhere. It shouldn't just be on campus that is bike friendly, it should be at least 70% of the town. I think a lot more people would be inclined to go out and do public events if there was an option between public transit and walking everywhere. It would also be more eco-friendly so please. Please, please put in more bike paths in the city.
- I would like more bike friendly streets. I now use an electric-assist trike in Ames.
- Making the city more walkable and less dependent on cars
- More bike paths and more sidewalks.
- More lights that stop traffic that cross the road on Stange for pedestrians
- Safety of Pedestrians, bicyclists, scooters, etc.
- Multi-purpose bike paths to and from ISU campus are not located on the actual road itself.
- Please add safety features at Mortensen + University to wake up drivers to northbound pedestrians and cyclists using the multi-use path, when drivers are turning south on red. Drivers don't look to the right and overhanging shrubs block their view of the multi-use path
- Bicycles
- Bike lanes
- We don't bike but for safety/rec. it would be good to create better off street paths
- Making streets safer and more comfortable for pedestrians, especially arterials such as Duff Ave.
- Safer pedestrian crossings. Better bike infrastructure
- Bike ability

Traffic

- Duff Ave traffic flow
- Finding a way to make Duff more enjoyable for drivers.
- Getting through Ames sucks. We need a NW beltway.
- Traffic around campus
- Making a left turn onto grand from 13th (either direction) is impossible
- I would like to see police helping when ISU center events are over. Just dumping traffic out into the streets and relying on stoplights to control traffic isn't working. Again, if the City is prioritizing reducing emissions, improving traffic flow after events should be a priority.
- Left turn arrows at Grand/13th St intersection.

- I think the road condition and traffic flow in Ames is a major concern. Traffic and driving conditions in Ames are much worse than comparably sized cities. I think the addition of turn lanes to Ames roads, when possible, would not only improve the driving conditions but also make the roads safer
- More roundabouts
- Traffic on Duff is an issue. When south Duff was redone a few years ago I do not understand why it was not made 4 lanes all the way outside of town.
- You've probably heard this already, but the 13th and Grand intersection needs to be fixed, even just adding left turn only green arrows would help.
- The intersection at 13th and Grand needs to be improved. It feels dangerous and chaotic.
- They added a left turn arrow on 16th and Grand which has been AWESOME, and my next suggestion is putting a left turn arrow for 13th and Grand because when on 13th, turning left onto Grand is very slow and often dangerous and would benefit greatly.
- Put in light at blind intersection by dentistry of Somerset
- Frontage road on south Duff.
- Noise from cars in residential environments
- Need more left turn lanes and lights.
- Turning lane at 13th + Grand.
- Traffic

Businesses and Development

- Bringing more business to Ames.
- Finishing the Lincoln Way build-out of empty lots west of Duff . Ugly & depressing looking!
- Encourage business development on Lincoln Way between Duff & Grand.
- Under development of Main Street areas, less fast food, more homegrown restaurants
- Stupid growth. Quit developing Duff! Finish Main St area project that hasn't ever really started.
- There are not many good food options in Ames.
- Need more places to eat on west side. Open a Popeyes.
- Promoting more local, unique shopping & dining options in Ames. With Jax closing, I'll have to go to Des Moines to shop.
- WHY DID WE LOSE A GREAT BUSINESS LIKE JAX, WHICH CLAIMED THEY COULDN'T FIND A NEW LOCATION IN AMES? IF THAT'S THE REAL REASON (NOT JUST A P.R. EXCUSE) WE SHIULD FIND WAYS TO KEEP THEM, IF POSSIBLE.
- Smart growth like Ankeny
- More parks, stores, restaurants in North Ames
- Culinary Diversity
- More retail stores
- I am concerned about small local businesses I have come to love during these uncertain times. I would love to see robust support for small businesses.
- Lincoln Way & Duff need serious improvements, stop building apartments, hold developers and rental companies to high standards
- Don't turn Ames into a smart city

Homelessness

- Having services for increasing homeless population
- Homelessness (x3)
- Homeless camps clogging paths and walkways, garbage, litter.
- Homeless population- HOST does great but need funding to emergency services
- Homeless population and violence
- Homelessness- compassionate housing
- Long term approach for our growing # of homeless in Ames. Emphasis on long term!
- Mentally ill and homeless people making downtown feel dangerous.
- The growing homeless population and all the issues that come as a result.
- The homeless! You can't use the library, the parks are full, and property is damaged. Needing a no camping ban like Des Moines and other areas before Ames is a giant homeless shelter.
- Housing with food for the homeless.
- Increase in people experiencing homelessness and needing resources

Housing and Cost of Living

- C.O.L.
- Affordable home buying programs for low/med income earners that make too much for habitat but can't afford a decent home for their families.
- Affordable housing for senior citizens.
- Breaking up the ridiculous rent cycle that I've only ever experienced in Ames. Yes, I know it's based on academic year, but I've lived in 4 other college towns and NONE of them do this. It promotes slum-lording, and you can see that in the unreasonably high rent prices for sub-par housing and tenet conditions that regularly violate and state law.
- Cost of housing
- Less apartment building, more town homes
- Low-income housing isn't apartments.
- The inflated rents and home prices.
- Developing a livelier main street. This means more apartments and townhouses in town, not at the edge.
- RENTAL OPTIONS FOR YOUNG PROFFESIONALS. It's hard to want to stay here when the leases are so inflexible and home prices are too high for single households. My mortgage in Phoenix is less than my rent in Ames.

Crime and Safety

- 1. Drugs + drug trafficking 2. Illegal alien population 3. Too little emphasis on major crime- human trafficking drugs, etc.
- Guns locked up. Drugs, pills locked up
- We have had an increased issue with gun violence in Ames and West Ames. Crime in general seems to have increased since we moved here 14 yrs. ago. We need to find ways to ensure that Ames is a safe place to live.
- Safety- it seems Ames is losing small town & developing bigger city problems- drug shooting, etc.

- Security
- Public Safety
- Why nearly all crime in town happens on Tripp St.
- Crime (x2)
- Ames High School has been getting bad reputation for crime and violence.
- Maybe try and focus on reducing the amount of crime.
- Keeping neighborhoods clean and safe.

Waste Disposal

- Free city-wide recycling at your door.
- City-wide yard waste and junk removal pick-up days. Many don't have the proper vehicles to haul; they can't take advantage of the days.
- Litter in public areas.
- I believe that the city should focus on trash pickup in main areas; I see so much trash on the sides of roads and in the grass.
- 1. Limit trash pick-up to one or two vendors. Right now, multiple garbage trucks go up and down our street. 2. Pick up leaves in parking like how Cedar Rapids, IA. 3. Have a yard waste receptacle.
- Preventing garbage (particularly plastic waste/single use plastic) from entering the park system. There's a real litter problem in certain areas. 2 areas I constantly see are the east side of Haber Rd.
- Recycling, waste management. Kudos for increasing recycling options at Resource Recovery.
- Provide multiple trash cans on trails for dog poop bags. Often you have to hold the bag the entire walk and always see bags full of poop just left on ground on side of trail.
- More recycling/compost drop off locations
- Consolidating Trash

Relations and Communication

- Continue to strengthen tie to ISU
- More collaboration between students and Ames outreach, not enough students utilize Ames' public spaces, downtown businesses, and other resources.
- I commented on design review for a city street project. The council rep said, "thank you" But there was no response from city staff. Very disappointing!
- Better coordination with county, city, and ISU - i.e. swimming pool and other community projects for everyone and leverage our tax dollars.
- Listening to the 80% of the public and not the 20% that scream and holler.
- Newsletter that is included in city invoice monthly is helpful.
- On the website, more in depth "events" calendar. Perhaps to capture public and private events.
- Park improvements are never fully explained (Tell us what you are doing!)
- The city website is unattractive and outdated. An update would be helpful to current and future residents and visitors.
- Adequate information about road construction and predicted timelines
- Also, no communication with NADL. Why??

Sustainability and Conservation

- More climate change planning
- Sustainability and green theories throughout the city. Education on waste effects and the impact that it can have on our children's generation.
- Sustainability (x2)
- Conserving the environment
- Moving farm fields away from waterways & implementing prairie strips & supporting no till. Ag practices/more diversified crops.
- We have lost so many trees to storms and the Emerald Ash Bore that I hope we can continue to emphasize tree planting.
- Clearing invasive plants Carr Park Woods
- Stormwater erosion
- It is important also to take action to reduce greenhouse gas omission.
- Reduce the amount of paper used. (Small issue of course)

Recreation, Events, and Activities

- Consider providing an indoor walking facility- people exercise in different ways not just biking or swimming (which gets all the attention) and need a place to walk in bad weather (too hot or too cold).
- Easier booking of recreational services (rec classes/pickleball courts)
- Give more social options for young adults in the community to keep them from moving away.
- More programming targeted at parents of young children who also work (e.g. evenings + weekends)
- More simple large events to build community. Live entertainment, farmers markets, random holiday celebrations, etc.
- Winter activities for families and kids. Dog parks
- Season passes for the city gym.
- The cost of things for kids & teens. Provide more places for them to hang out. Open an arcade place.
- A consolidated fitness facility instead of pieces all over town
- More indoor play places for children, better parks

Services, Facilities, and Utilities

- I would also love to see initiative in bringing more mental health care workers to the Ames area. For so many surrounding small towns, this is the big city. I have PTSD and could not find someone qualified to work with me in Ames. I have to meet with my therapist located in West Des Moines.
- Stability during challenging times - maintaining services at the high level they are at.
- There is likely to be sharply increased need for food, housing, etc. assistance.
- We should have a city-wide library :)
- Animal shelter
- Upkeep on existing city facilities rather than making new ones
- They should bury more of the residential lines so the storms will not affect the house. Keep replacing the water pipes Keep up with maintenance

- Public schools
- Hardening the power plant against EMP
- Getting fluoride out of the drinking water
- Paying lifeguards (very much more!) more as well as recreation employees

Parking

- More parking near the library, what's there is too expensive
- Parking
- Parking in no parking areas.
- Parking/Land usage. Build for the future with the present in mind.
- Get rid of parking meters throughout the city.
- Make all public parking free of charge

Street Maintenance

- Streets and making the contractor make them smooth when finished
- Road closures/times
- Road maintenance
- Bridge on Minnesota Ave
- Potholes
- Just the roads

Taxes and Public Spending

- Cut unnecessary spending from city budget, lower property taxes, lower public school taxes.
- Iowa property taxes or freeze them for retired citizens. Even Illinois does this. The City doesn't want retired citizens to live here.
- Property tax reduction
- Financial literacy
- Property taxes

Ice and Snow

- Ice/ snow coverage in residential areas
- The city needs to significantly improve its efforts in snow removal and ice control. These are areas where Ames consistently underperforms compared to other cities. There is a noticeable gap in service quality, and it is time to evaluate best practices from municipalities that manage winter conditions more effectively. This deserves urgent attention.
- Snow removal from roads often comes at the expense of bike lanes, which are impossible to use in the winter. Bike commuting can happen year-round!

Transit

- Preschool busing. The only preschool option for those who need to utilize busing is Northwood. It would be awesome to extend the option to other schools
- Improving bus service at weekends/during the summer

- Extending CyRide routes (although the overall quality of CyRide is very good)

Inclusion

- Safe spaces, more Pride events
- Promote DEI
- Inclusion + accessibility

Code enforcement

- Yards that are not taken care of make the city look bad. Too much of that exists in our neighborhoods. Police patrolling neighborhoods
- Rental enforcement. Street parking and visibility when turning create major risks because rentals often house 4-5 residents w/ 4-5 cars and they park on residential streets (not driveways).

Additional Comments

Positive

- Ames has been a great place to live and raise a family.
- Ames is a wonderful place to live and work!
- Ames is great. I lived in Des Moines for over 35 years and Ames is 100 times better! Ames is home to us.
- Ames is one of the best communities in the country - but don't advertise it! That will wreck it! The worst part of Ames is the weather, and that it keeps it small.
- Go Ames! and Cyclones! Hoo-yeah!
- Golden cornfields sway, Cyclones rise with pride and strength Ames, where hearts find home.
- Great town for retirees (only lived here in retirement).
- I grew up in Saratoga Springs, NY - basically if a town were a teacup. Ames is very different of course but it has been a lovely place to live!
- I like Ames' friendly attitude to pets.
- I like living in Ames.
- I lived in a suburb of Chicago, in the city of Chicago, and in Story City, Iowa, before moving to Ames. In Ames, I found my nirvana. I feel very fortunate to have the opportunity to live in Ames and am hopeful that it will be my home forever.
- I love Ames + I live in the best neighborhood in all of Ames!
- I moved to town last winter & so far am impressed with the intentionality & investment in the community (including this survey)! It feels like a very caring place.
- I really like living in Ames! It's such a beautiful town!
- Love living in Ames!
- Nice place to Live.
- Overall, I love Ames and various benefits the city offers.
- We love Ames.
- We love Ames and would stay if there were jobs relevant to my husband. He is graduating with his Ph. D in chemistry, not many non-Ag jobs in Iowa (not Ames' fault!).
- We love Ames. It is a very quiet, safe place. Great for raising kids + working. Not a lot of crime + no bad part of town. I feel safe anywhere in town. Love It.
- We love Ames, glad we moved here 40+ years ago.
- Ames is a great place to live and work!

Cost of Living

- Housing
  - Considering the cost of requiring homes being built to be more affordable, it being too costly to purchase if the City requires them to have more climate-friendly products.
  - Household income is approximate, with four other roommates.
  - Housing prices are out of control. Affordable rent should be a huge push for anybody allowed to build rentals in Ames. $2k/month for a 3 bedroom is insane. Those landlords should be evicted from town unless they agree to lower rent prices.

- I have many opinions as a mid/young professional trying to decide if I stay here or move to Des Moines. I like Ames, I want to stay but the housing is so frustrating.
- I moved to Ames for clerical work at ISU in 1976. It was unaffordable then and still is. There's talk but no action to make affordable housing. Once you reach about age 25 you don't want roommates anymore. And then you realize how ownership is not a possibility. Ames needs to look at Ankeny for town home developments and ways to make them affordable for builders and price them so lower to middle income ranges can own a home.
- I think Ames is a great place to live but it is costly. I'm lucky to be able to afford to live here. Property taxes (+ home values) are high + discouraging to young families.
- More low-income housing options.
- I think there are some big challenges coming with overall cost of living + increasing needs for inexpensive housing + social services.
- Rent and housing prices are getting really high. I work for a nonprofit agency, and raises are not promised, so when electric rent, water keeps going up and pay stays the same it gets harder to buy groceries for our home.
- Rentals and lack of regulation or ordinance enforcement is a huge issue. Streets are overcrowded w/ parked cars due to # of people with vehicles living in residential neighborhoods. Mowing/vegetation problems at rentals reduce visibility on corners. Shoveling (and lack of shoveling) causes people with mobility issues in west Ames to be unable to leave home/ use sidewalks click fix is not adequate for these ongoing issues. Landlords and residents seem to want to report to do anything. West Ames is treated differently by the city than north Ames - lack of HOAs and other internal enforcement as well as income disparity needs to be accounted for.
- Sense of community is being eroded by growing number of rentals in our neighborhood. I realize this is a national problem as well and have no solution to offer but it is definitely affecting our area.
- We lived on South Stanton Ave for 54 years + loved living there mostly. That feeling was ruined when the state would not let us have a rental cap so we could salvage our neighborhood. We have just moved to Green Hills and really like living here

- Homelessness
  - Ames needs to clean up the Main Street area and help fix the homeless crisis and people breaking the rules downtown and disrupting businesses and learning.
  - Attention needs to be given to the increasing problem of homelessness. It seems like when Des Moines criminalized homelessness, the homeless population increased substantially.
  - It is distressing to see the homeless population increasing, and to see the public library and the old town areas being treated as “logical" places for them. The City of Ames needs to do a better job of serving the needs of all its inhabitants, and not just by creating a ghetto of the older parts of town for the needy.
  - The City needs to start making progress on homeless issues. Too worried about the homeless while we can’t use the parks or the library.
  - I would prefer lower cost in rent. Too many homeless people in Ames.
- Taxes
  - Taxes in Ames are causing me to consider moving. I'm retired and can't afford constant tax increases.

- You recently adjusted property value and hit us with a non-negotiable 68% increase!
- You've got to do something to ensure senior citizens can continue to be able to live here. Property taxes are rolling everyone- I understand- but hit retired fixed income people the hardest.

Infrastructure

- Road and Vehicle Transportation
  - Frontage road on South Duff, Countdown signals at stop lights, green arrow at 13th & Grand
  - 30th St. + N. Duff bike lanes are not used. The seam between street + the concrete curb is a hazard. Bike tires get caught in this seam + cause bike movement. If you ride to the right of the seam, you risk hitting the curb with your pedal. If you ride to the left of the seam you are basically in part of the street. The 30th street center turn lane is a waste. Many people do not understand how to use it + causes more problems than it solves. I can't turn west onto 30th St. if coming from the north with my travel trailer. There is not enough space if cars are waiting in the turning lane. The CyRide stop in front of Walmart can cause cars to back up on to the east + even block the 30th/Grand intersection. Put 30th St. back to 2 lanes in each direction + eliminate the in-street bike lanes!!!
  - All the entrances into the city could be improved greatly w/ the exception of university boulevard, which is very pretty.
  - As annoying as it is, I really like that Ames keeps up with its streets- resurfacing- and keeps after the university to do its part, too.
  - Again - turn left arrows on 13th at Grand.
  - Concerning streets. The various City departments need to coordinate their planning when it comes to budgets, repairs + maintenance. I've seen streets torn up for sewer work one year and again the following year for water main repair. Some street conditions are pathetic.
  - Parking downtown continues to be a problem and will become even more so as business and residential areas are constructed along Lincoln way.
  - Road construction seems to go on much too long. One repair site had 5 workers for a small job, large jobs often have no one working. Seems inefficiently run to a lay person who doesn't understand construction engineering.
  - If the construction in Ames could get done sooner than it takes.
  - [Poor surface conditions of major streets] 13th St. by Aquatic Center,
  - Traffic patterns sometimes bug us - intersection of Grand & 13th needs a turn lane for E-W & W-E.
  - Parking should be free please! Especially by the library.
- Walking and Biking
  - Thanks for fixing the crumbling asphalt on the Stuart Smith bike path. We love to bike & are looking forward to a longer stretch we can ride which doesn't involve much vehicle traffic.
  - It would be nice to make Ames more pedestrian friendly.
  - The intersection of Hyland & West St as the students don't ever yield to cars/bikes & scooters go right through expecting cars to yield. Comment on Sidewalks: I've complained many times about the lack of sidewalk on Ross Road. 25 years ago, there

was a plan for (a) sidewalk but when I last checked, Ross Rd. Was no longer in the plan. I've walked the street many times with & without my dog. Many properties do not even have an easement to step to. (Planting out to the curb). The curbs are unpredictable, some good, some dangerous. Traffic speeds on the curves. For a city that strives to be "walkable," Ross Road is dangerous.

- Miscellaneous Infrastructure
  - There is a lot of focus on expanding the city to the west through new construction, but not enough attention on the stormwater issues this creates downstream. New homes restrict the ability of the watershed to absorb water, and this leads to more water in the creeks. The creeks are essentially like "utility infrastructure" in a sense, so they need to be maintained better. Right now, the burden is being pushed onto property owners downstream! This leads to flooding.
  - Solar is not a long-term answer.
  - The climate action plan is a ridiculous use of time and resources. We should not be investing in solar panels. If you are north of a latitude of Oklahoma they are not nearly as effective. Hard to believe they will offset carbon impact of their supply chain construction and installation.
  - I think Ames needs to plan a new power plant in the next years. Bury more of our electric lines. The city electric did a great job restoring the power to our house. Power lines across the city were down. And keep replacing the water lines.
  - Glad we have municipal electric services.

Government, Decision-Making, and Politics

- Critiques and Improvements
  - Time to quit wasting time on DEI.
  - Big developers have way too much sway in this town. I don't think it's a secret who they are.
  - City council is way too liberal in their decisions to spend way too much time on "Green" things.
  - I really like this town, and I wish more people felt the same way. I can't blame them though, the number of poor experiences I've had with City officials over the years is very discouraging. I get that a lot of students come and go, but they're still residents and many of them are looking to stay after graduation. They might if they were treated well their first 4 years here.
  - There is a lot of private wealth in Ames that should be carrying more of the cost of arts, rec, and extracurricular public services.
  - Please add proposed zoning change information more prominently on the website. It is very hard to find in meeting minutes.
  - Consider partnerships w/ ISU + Story County for expanded naturalized trails + connecting what do ISU students want from community to make Ames a better place for them &/or student recruitment as they contribute to prop. taxes through rentals.
- Positives
  - I want to compliment the city on derecho response. The most meaningful thing was after our power was out, maybe the second day, and then this lady working for the City came around house to house, and she found me cleaning up the yard, and she had a paper handout with numbers we could call, and asked if I had questions, and was very

friendly and wanted to offer help or information however she could. I sincerely appreciated that.

- I wish to thank City staff and all City employees for their good work and for keeping this a good place to live!
- Please note all communications recently with Assessor's Office, (Ranie), and water dept. Miss X is very helpful - polite and informative
- One of the things I like most about Ames is all the ways it works to provide safety & stability, through cleanliness and constantly working to improve 'conditions' with inclusivity on the forefront.
- Overall, I'm happy with this community + the work the city does.
- I would suggest getting an account on Bluesky. Social, it's the next big social media. In times like this, I know it's hard with everything going on. Do the best for the people in this town, even with the state and federal pressure I know you must be feeling. I also know there's going to be laws trying to change our town for the worse, please do your best to fight against it. I fear our community will need your action more than in any time in history. The work done here if done right can help this town be an island of stability in this time of malaise. I know the city can gov do it. Please take care, and good luck.
- Thanks to those who are on the city council, school board, and other communities/boards. Their contributions are appreciated. Are they regularly honored for their service?
- Ames does not waste much money and so my property tax is good.
- Thank you for all you do to make Ames a great community!
- Thank you for all that you do!
- I value our healthcare system in partnership w COA

Survey Comments

- Thank you for the survey.
- Good job with survey.
- How and when will we know the results/findings of the survey? Thank you for the opportunity for sharing my initial thoughts.
- This survey is too long.
- Survey was way too long.
- Thank you.
- Thank you for conducting this survey & taking the time to consider residents' thoughts.
- Thank you for this opportunity to share my opinions. I had no idea this program existed. You should publicize it so that even people who are not selected to participate are given that opportunity.
- Thanks for soliciting feedback! I feel valued and am a very statistical resident!

Businesses

- More business development on Lincoln Way.
- Ames doesn't seem to attract a lot of new diverse types of business whether it be shopping or food. I'm not sure what can be done but the same group of people own the 3 or 4 local restaurants, we can't seem to attract any really great restaurants and lots of people go to

Des Moines. Our grocery stores are lacking. It's either Hy-Vee, Fareway (both companies I don't want to support) or Wheatsfield, which is terribly expensive. Something like Trader Joes would be great. We don't attract a lot of clothing aside from chain stores. Just would be nice to get new businesses + not a bunch of part stores, Mexican food, & chain clothing stores.

- I know the Ames mall has been here for several years, and malls are kind of becoming a thing of the past. It would be nice to see more stores move in instead of moving out. Not sure if the City owns it or a private company, I've noticed that some stores have built other facilities and moved out. Is that because rent has increased so much over the years? I also understand there is a cost in maintaining it but that probably should have paid off years ago. So, if the City owns it, you should be able to offer low rent to bring in new businesses. Like I said, I'm not sure if it's privately owned or not just a thought.
- I would love to see Ames become more of a destination for dining, shopping, entertainment, with other communities coming here, especially those N + E + W instead of going to D.M. Our "mall", the bare lots on Lincoln Way, empty stores on Main Street (& almost more hair salons than clothing stores) make Ames look like a community on the decline - that makes me sad
- Need more places to eat on the west side we would prefer Hardees, Popeyes, Sonic. Need more choices.
- Not enough development. I must leave Ames to find things to do. Not sure what the city is doing, but we're headed in the wrong direction.

Planning and Development

- We need much stricter control of development & rental.
- Concerned about the Link project + the lack of movement. Need to move on from current investors. After traveling in Europe, I've come to love the town squares with restaurants, trees + activities. Would that be a possibility for that area?
- Consider reducing the number of commercial/residential buildings in neighborhoods where increased traffic will become a problem, barrier for travel.
- I appreciate efforts to improve Main St. as a hub for culture & services. It would be nice to somehow bridge the gap to the university, make the two areas feel less separated
- I think the City should try to preserve and nurture the old town area and consider it a cultural resource instead of allowing it to become a breeding ground for make-shift social service providers and landlords who do not maintain their properties. You also MUST revise the historic guidelines to allow more reasonable upkeep options homeowners can't be expected to only use 19th century building options in the 21st century.
- It would be nice to keep the small university town feeling - less construction of tall buildings + the downtown Hotel would look "out of place" Also, Cy Town will take away the ISU "campus feeling."
- Lincoln way between Duff and Clark is an eyesore and has been for several years. Progress needs to be made on whatever development is planned for the area.
- The progress on the plaza east of City Hall has been disappointing and very inefficient. This seems like a waste of money and should have remained like parking.

Waste

- The garbage seems to be blowing out of the Frederickson court dumpsters, it blows east

across the car park (east side of Huber) into the field and then into woods at Brookside Park, where it's impacting the wildlife. The same thing is happening at the student dumpsters on Bruner Drive where the plastic waste is blowing into the woods west side of the high school prairie. In both areas, in the winter it's shocking to see how much garbage is polluting the woods, now it's spring the lush foliage has hidden most of the waste but it's still there. Surely bigger, better dumpsters could be provided to contain the student garbage & perhaps some signage to make people more mindful of their waste. I think Ames is a fantastic city & I love the park system, especially Brookside, the one spoiling factor is this garbage.

- A few places in town look bad.
- You didn't mention any recycling or community yard waste days in this survey? The resource recovery plant is a huge benefit to our community in terms of recycling. Why does Ames not have a yard waste disposal area? With only one spring yard waste day and a couple in the fall this is something that needs to be improved/added.
- When can we get one brand of garbage truck in my block instead of five ones? Clean up the street, dirties the air and makes us have trucks come one more day of the week. Please solve this + not just think about it.

Resources and Events

- More community gatherings (bandshell & the library are excellent locations).
- A lot of City programming seems targeted to stay at home moms or retirees. Would be nice to see more programs targeted to younger crowds + working families.
- Season passes for city gymnasium, Indoor play structures for kids of all ages.
- 60 Forward facility is nice, but as a 60+, I work, so that facility is not open when I could use it.
- Create more indoor children's activities.
- I appreciate the resources the library offers, but I've personally felt uncomfortable bringing my children to the library. There tends to be a crowd around and inside the library that creates an environment I don't always feel is safe or family friendly. Additionally, I've noticed a strong emphasis on certain political viewpoints, which feels unbalanced for a public institution meant to serve a diverse community. I hope the library can work toward creating a more welcoming and neutral space for all patrons.
- Please restore cable to cardio room at city gym.
- The dog park is too expensive & thus isn't easily available to travelers. We stopped going although we do like the facility itself.
- Continuing to provide events open and of interest to all ages needs to remain hallmark.

Miscellaneous

- Trees and Green Spaces
  - Continue expansion in green spaces & forested spaces.
  - Replacement of trees in the city easement areas. No response when we reached out
- Safety
  - Cautious when out at night, especially in the historic downtown area.
  - In general, I feel fairly safe in Ames although recent events have created some doubt with that security, shootings and robbery on Union, and then between Ace Hardware +

Inis grove, witnessed a robbery at midday at south Walmart - (although remote in the parking lot) still creating some unease with the situation. I have become more "aware" of my surroundings. My neighborhood is very connected, and we look out for one another - very lucky + feel grateful and fortunate.

- City Vehicles
  - It annoys me when I drive by the police station and see so many patrol cars parked.
  - I think all-electric City vehicles would be a terrible idea in Ames because it is too cold here. Not a wise idea.
- Other
  - I try to contribute to assisting library, bridge home, food bank police funds etc., and plan to do more for animal shelter this year.
  - If my household is my apartment, then we make $25,000 per year; if it's my family back home that does somewhat support me, then it's around $150000 per year.
  - I don't know if you can do this but help pay more for jobs in social services. Social workers do so much for so little!
  - I don't + won't use social media for information-systems are too unsecured.

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